

EMAIL MARKETING DEMYSTIFIED

THIRD EDITION

Build a Massive Mailing List, Write Copy
that Converts, and Generate More Sales



MATTHEW PAULSON

Praise for *Email Marketing Demystified*

“I’ve done email marketing for over a decade and have interviewed over 1,000 entrepreneurs about how they built their businesses, and I still learned a lot about growing an email list from *Email Marketing Demystified*. What sets it apart is that Matthew does not give empty theories. He shows actionable techniques that he used to build a 200k+ mailing list and includes examples of how he used those techniques.”

Andrew Warner
Founder and CEO, Mixergy
Mixergy.com

“*Email Marketing Demystified* is a great primer. I thought the book was a really great primer for anyone that doesn’t understand the mechanics of the process of email marketing.”

Perry Belcher
Co-Founder, Native Commerce
Co-Founder, DigitalMarketer
DigitalMarketer.com

“Matthew has already walked the walk with email marketing, and now he’s committed his knowledge to paper. Recommended.”

Rob Walling
Co-Founder, TinySeed
Host, Startup for the Rest of Us
StartupsForTheRestOfUs.com

“Matthew provides a step-by-step process that makes email marketing approachable and accessible to entrepreneurs at all levels. If you are just getting started with email or you already have a mailing list of 10,000 subscribers, *Email Marketing Demystified* can help grow your business through the power of email marketing.”

Jaime Tardy
Founder, Eventual Millionaire
EventualMillionaire.com

“Email marketing is an incredibly valuable marketing channel. I do it in my business, but I know I could be doing it a lot better. *Email Marketing Demystified* is a deep dive into the trenches of effective email marketing that shows what actually works. I found the book to be easy to digest and came away with some great takeaways that are immediately applicable to my business.”

John T. Meyer
Co-Founder, Lemonly
Lemonly.com

“With so many new options in social media, it seems some current marketers put more emphasis on techniques for selling rather than on creating value and true service. In this book, Matthew gives step-by-step practices to grow exponentially by giving massive value while honoring the time proven principles of integrity and wowing our customers. I expect this book to add \$1 million in new revenue to our business this year.”

Dan Miller

New York Times bestselling author of *48 Days to the Work You Love*
48Days.com

“If you have any doubt about the power of email marketing, *Email Marketing Demystified* will quickly dispel them. In the book, Matthew lays out an easy to implement step-by-step plan to create your own email marketing system that actually works! This book is a must-read for any entrepreneur that runs an online business and is prepared to IGNITE!”

John Lee Dumas

Host, EntrepreneurOnFire
EntrepreneurOnFire.com

“I’ve known Matt for several years now and watched him build several semi-automated businesses that created hundreds of thousands of dollars (and now into the millions) quickly. A little story: I shared with Matt an email “having a sale” sequence that I thought would quickly add 30% or more in revenue when one of his businesses was still under six figures. Instead of 30% growth he turned it into around 300% growth in a year. Listen to Matt when it comes to email for building a company fast. Read *Email Marketing Demystified* and follow Matt’s step-by-step plan and you too can grow your business rapidly.”

Tim Conley

TimConley.net

“*Email Marketing Demystified* is packed with real-world-tested strategies, tips and tricks only a veteran of email marketing would know. If you are new to email marketing, Matt’s detailed, step-by-step methods will cut your learning curve by years and allow you to start monetizing that portion of your business immediately. Even as an experienced email marketer, I found gems I implemented into my own business that have helped me grow my subscribers more quickly. Matt has a knack for thinking of ways to grow and monetize an email list that you probably never considered!”

Tim Bourquin

Co-founder, After Offers
AfterOffers.com

Email Marketing Demystified
Build a Massive Mailing List, Write Copy
that Converts, and Generate More Sales

Third Edition

MATTHEW PAULSON

Email Marketing Demystified: Build a Massive Mailing List, Write Copy that Converts, and Generate More Sales

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DEDICATION

To my children, Micah and Adylin (Ady), I love you more than anything in the world. You provide the hope, inspiration, and joy that I need to get up early every day and continue to grow my businesses.

To my wife Karine, thank you for continuing to support and encourage me in everything I do. Thank you for not shaking your head at me whenever I come up with a crazy new business idea and thank you for allowing me the opportunity to provide for our family in unique and creative ways. Most importantly, thank you for being my best friend.

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PREFACE TO THE THIRD EDITION

The first edition of *Email Marketing Demystified* was published almost eight years ago. The social media landscape has shifted dramatically during that time. Some platforms like Vine and Google+ no longer exist, while new platforms like Instagram and TikTok have generated massive user bases in just a few short years. Marketers that invested in building audiences on the wrong platforms lost big and people who were early to Instagram and TikTok have benefited from these platforms' rising popularity.

While social media platforms have come and gone, email's role as the most-used communications platform online remains unchallenged. The number of global email users surpassed 4 billion people in 2021. That's nearly 4 times the number of users that the largest current social media platform, Facebook, has registered. Nearly 100,000 non-spam emails now sent every single second. Billions of dollars' worth of commerce are conducted over email every year.

Marketers have certainly had to adapt to the changing technical and privacy landscape surrounding email. However, the time-tested strategies and tactics that fuel effective email marketing campaigns have not changed significantly since the first edition of this book was published in 2015. This is a testament to the stability, longevity, and profitability of email as a marketing tool. Email is the slow, steady, and massive platform that allows marketers to build audiences that will last for years, even decades if managed properly. While social platforms are important tools for marketers, email is the marketer's platform that will stand the test of time.

Since the second edition of this book was published in early 2019, there have been several developments that warranted writing a new edition of this book:

Email is now a mobile first experience, with more users than ever reading email primarily on their smartphones.

New legislative privacy initiatives, such as the California Consumer Privacy Act, have given users more control over their personal data.

Email providers, most notably Apple, have made it more difficult to accurately track open rates and users' location data.

Simple email publishing platforms such as Substack and Revue have made it easier than ever for individual writers to grow an email audience.

Email newsletters have come back in a big way, with companies like Morning Brew and The Hustle building media companies whose primary media platform is email.

A new generation of email service providers are gaining popularity among marketers.

New best practices, such as the use of triggered email campaigns, have emerged as compelling email marketing tactics.

The third edition of *Email Marketing Demystified* has been updated to discuss these developments in detail including new best practices, tool recommendations, and tactics to leverage in your email marketing program. When you read the third edition of *Email Marketing Demystified*, you can rest assured that you are learning the latest email marketing information and strategy.

At MarketBeat, we have now sent more than 5 billion emails to our subscribers since launching our service in 2011.

Our email marketing program has grown significantly since *Email Marketing Demystified* was first released. We have grown our email list from 250,000 subscribers to nearly 3 million subscribers over the last eight years. We attract approximately 125,000 new subscribers each month through our organic opt-in forms and paid media efforts. We now spend approximately \$500,000 each month on advertising to grow our email list through co-registration advertising, Google AdWords, Facebook ads, and other paid media platforms. In 2022, we expect to send more than 3 billion permission-based emails and generate \$25 million in revenue from premium newsletter subscriptions, newsletter sponsorship ads, and dedicated advertising emails to our mailing list.

Email marketing is the core of our business and I sincerely hope that you will be able to benefit from the skills, knowledge, and strategies I have picked up while building MarketBeat during the last decade.

Matthew Paulson

October 1st, 2022

FOREWORD

by John McIntyre

“But John, isn’t email marketing dead?” Dave asked.

I sighed.

It was 11:30am on a sunny Tuesday, and I was checking my email at Suvarnabhumi International Airport in Bangkok, Thailand.

I was en route to the U.S. to speak at a conference on the power email marketing has to make sales and revenue explode.

I had to laugh at the irony.

I had built a profitable business with email marketing, which generated 100% of its profits from email marketing, yet I was repeatedly being told by people like Dave that email marketing was dead.

These people were smart business owners who just didn’t get it. They thought email marketing was a waste of time.

That it didn’t work.

That it made people want to punch their computer.

Who could blame them?

We’ve been told “email marketing is dead” for years.

According to the “experts,” no one checks email anymore. They’ve all moved over to Facebook, Twitter, Pinstagram, Instarest, or whatever the latest social network is called.

Plus, most of us consider checking email to be a “necessary evil.” We don’t check email because we love it. We check it because we have to. We’d rather be checking how many likes our latest post on Facebook received.

But as business owners, our personal relationship with our inbox is not indicative of whether email marketing works or not.

Like every great marketer, Matt cares more about data than human emotion, and that’s why he begins *Email Marketing Demystified* by describing what the data says.

As it turns out, the data tells a *very* different story than what we’ve all heard.

Did you know that a study from the Direct Marketing Association found that businesses earn an average of \$43.00 for every \$1.00 invested in email marketing?

In other words, email marketing is *proven* to produce a 4,300% return on investment (ROI).

In the same study, not only did email marketing deliver a whopping 4,300% ROI, but it also beat every single other advertising channel including social media, search engine optimization, and direct mail.

Email marketing is not dead. Not even close.

But that's not all ...

If marketing channels were cars, even the best social media and SEO campaigns would be like a Mercedes Benz—fast and luxurious, but certainly not the best in their class—while email marketing would be a McLaren F1 or a Lamborghini Gallardo.

Email marketing doesn't just beat everything else. It leaves them in the dust.

And so, I have a question for you:

Have YOU implemented an email marketing strategy yet?

If you have, are you optimizing it, improving it, and always striving to make it better?

If you aren't, you are making a *huge* mistake.

Depending on the size of your business, you could be leaving hundreds of thousands of dollars on the table. Maybe even millions.

All because you haven't taken the time to implement an effective email marketing strategy.

Well, it's time for that to change.

When it comes to email marketing and learning how to generate a 4,300% ROI, I can't think of anyone I'd rather learn from than Matt Paulson.

Why?

Because unlike other so-called "experts," Matt lives and breathes email marketing. He is a bonafide expert.

One of his businesses is a financial newsletter which goes out to more than 900,000 investors on a daily basis.

Marketing books usually present ideas from some "fly by night" wantrapreneur who has never achieved anything substantial.

But that's not what you're going to get with *Email Marketing Demystified*.

Instead, you're going to get email marketing strategies from someone who knows how to apply them to wildly different businesses in totally different markets.

As a successful serial entrepreneur with a growing multimillion-dollar empire built largely on the back of the email marketing strategies you're about to learn, Matt is the *real deal*.

By now, I'm hoping that you're ready to generate a 4,300% ROI in your business (and you're ready to let someone as smart, successful, and savvy as Matt help you do it).

So let's talk specifics:

What are you going to learn in *Email Marketing Demystified*?

First, you'll get the low-down on the best email service providers for your business, including which companies offer the best features for the best price (and which will burn a hole in your pocket without offering you much in return).

Next, you'll discover the art and science of getting people to sign up for your email list on your website, including how to create a killer lead magnet that stops even your coldest prospects dead in their tracks and makes them sign up. Plus, you'll also find out exactly which type of opt-in forms to add to your website for maximum conversions (and how to craft the perfect message that communicates to your ideal prospect's deepest desires).

Now comes the part most people dread ... creating the email campaigns. However, you have nothing to worry about because Matt explains how writing amazing emails can be easy, simple, and fast. This is where you'll learn the ins and outs of creating email campaigns that are opened, clicked, and bought time and time again.

Plus, Matt even does a deep dive on copywriting (one of my favorite topics) and shows you how to write blockbuster emails on command.

Once you have your email software, lead magnet, email opt-ins, and various campaigns, you'll get to the most exciting step in the book: Monetization (in other words, how to make money with your email list).

In this section, Matt goes into all the various ways you can generate revenue from your email list (he even surprised me with a few methods of monetization that I wasn't aware of).

When it comes to monetizing your email list, selling your own products and services is the most common method, but it is far from the only method. Matt also covers co-registration advertising, selling another company's products, and running newsletter ads. He also explains how you can rent out your email list to other companies (this is perfect for a business that has an email list but no products of their own to sell).

After monetization, you'll jump into the dark, murky area of the legal side of email marketing. When does email marketing become spam?

How can you avoid breaking the law while also serving your customers by selling your products and services?

Once you've made it through the boring-but-totally-necessary legal aspects of email marketing, Matt hits you with some killer tips on how to avoid the spam box and promotions tab; how to maintain a good reputation with Gmail, Yahoo!, and the other email companies; and how to ensure your email campaigns get delivered every single time you send them.

The final section of this book delves into cold email outreach, also known as outbound email marketing. This topic is particularly important to my company at the moment as we are doing a lot of cold email outreach. I was glad to find several tips and tricks in this section that I'm sure will improve our results. If your business sells high-ticket products and services like mine, cold email outreach is the strategy for you.

So there you have it:

Email Marketing Demystified is the complete guide to email marketing—from getting people onto your email list, converting them into customers with amazing campaigns, managing the legal side of things, and using cold email outreach to sell high-ticket products and services.

If you'd like to see breakthrough growth in your business, read this book and follow Matt's advice to the letter. It will transform your business. You will end up with more money than ever, with more time than ever, and you will finally be able to create the lifestyle you've wanted since the day you got started in business.

I've personally experienced the amazing benefits of email marketing in my own business. I've also seen it again and again in my clients' and customers' businesses.

Email marketing works like rocket-fuel for businesses ... but *only* if you implement what you learn.

So please, please, PLEASE: don't just read this book ... take action and enjoy the incredible results (because you deserve no less than the best).

Email marketing is *not* magic, but it certainly starts to *feel* that way when you see such incredible results.

When you implement these strategies and discover that they work splendidly, please email me and let me know how it worked out for you.

I would love to hear from you.

Best of luck,

John McIntyre

The Autoresponder Guy

john@themcmethod.com | TheMcMethod.com

Best-selling author of *Email Marketing: 63 Money-Making Insights*
From The Wildly Popular McMethod Email Marketing Podcast.

Medellín, Colombia

July 23, 2015

INTRODUCTION

Email is one of the most powerful and underutilized marketing channels available on earth. It has been the primary means of electronic communication since the 1970's. Since then, numerous bulletin board services, instant messaging services, chat services, social networks, and other “email killers” have come and gone. Yet email continues to serve as the core communication platform of the Internet—and it's only growing. Currently, 4,037 billion people, more than half of the world's population, have access to email and more than 3.4 billion non-spam emails are sent and received every hour of every day of the year.¹

Despite the widespread use of the digital juggernaut that is email, many entrepreneurs have yet to implement an effective email marketing strategy in their business because they don't know how to do it or haven't recognized how powerful of a marketing channel email can be. *Email Marketing Demystified* hopes to change that by providing a step-by-step guide for any business (or nonprofit) to leverage the power of email marketing.

Why Email Marketing?

Email provides you the opportunity to send a message to your audience for any purpose on any day of the year at effectively no cost to you. This is an incredibly powerful communication channel. When you do email marketing well and send the right messages to the right people at the right time, you are certain to build an audience of highly engaged fans that can't wait for your next message to hit their inboxes. Additionally, they are ready to buy whenever you have a product or service to promote.

There are several compelling reasons that your business should adopt email as a marketing channel:

- **Email Marketing Generates Massive ROI**

A study from the Direct Marketing Association found that a business will earn an average of \$43.00 for every \$1.00 invested in email marketing.² In a study from GigaOm, marketers have consistently ranked email marketing as the single most effective strategy for generating awareness, acquiring leads, generating sales, and customer retention.³

- **Email Marketing Generates Long-Term Results**

MarketBeat first started collecting opt-ins in late 2010. Nearly a decade later, a good number of our subscribers that signed up during the first year continue to read our content, engage with our advertisers, and buy products and services from our business. Your email list is a long-term asset that will generate revenue and social capital for your business for many years to come.

- **Most Customers Want Email from Businesses**

A study from MarketingSherpa found that 72% of U.S. consumers say email is their favorite way to communicate with the companies that they do business with. 61% of consumers reported they like to receive weekly promotional emails from their favorite brands, and 28% of consumers want to receive promotional emails more frequently.⁴ Additionally, 70% of consumers say they will always open email from their favorite companies,⁵ and 95% of people who opted in to receive email from brands say that the marketing email they receive is either somewhat useful or very useful.⁶

- **Email Marketing Dramatically Outperforms Social Media Marketing**

A study from McKinsey & Company found that businesses are 40 times more likely to create a new customer from email marketing than they are through social media.⁷ Another study found that 66% of marketers believe email marketing delivers a “good” or “excellent” ROI, while only 41% of them said they feel the same way about social media marketing.⁸

- **Email is Ubiquitous**

Nearly 87% of the population in the United States has Internet access in their home,⁹ and 95% of consumers use email.¹⁰ You just don’t have to worry whether or not any of your potential customers have an email address or not.

- **Email is a Resilient Technology**

Email has effectively existed in its current format since the early 1980s. That was 15 years before most homes had a personal computer and Internet access, and 25 years before the first iPhone was released. Despite the world’s massive amount of technological progress and the

proliferation of personal computers, smartphones, and tablets, the technical specifications for email have only been updated a handful of times in the last 30 years. While other communication technologies have come and gone, email continues to withstand the test of time. When you invest in email marketing, you know that the medium won't be replaced by a bigger and better thing a few years from now.

- **Email Doesn't Have Platform Risk**

When you build an audience on Facebook, YouTube, or Instagram, you are totally at the mercy of the whims of a company whose best interests are not aligned with yours. You could put a lot of time, energy, and money into building an audience on a particular platform only for that platform to change the rules in such a way that kills the profitability of your campaign. That will never be the case with email, because no one company has control of the technical specification for email or control over the technology infrastructure that allows email to be delivered to the world's six billion inboxes.

Email marketing continues to be one of the most effective and most resilient marketing strategies for both digital businesses and brick-and-mortar companies. It's hard to match the potential ROI offered by email marketing, and you can rest assured that your email marketing efforts will continue to generate revenue into the future.

Email Marketing Is Not Dead, But It Is Changing

Every now and then, a technology expert or a journalist will come out and declare the demise of email. In 2009, technology columnist John C. Dvorak argued that email is dead because of spam, competing social media platforms, security problems, and several of other issues.¹¹ In January 2014, Facebook co-founder Dustin Moskovitz declared that the world had reached "peak email" and said that the business world would quickly move to other platforms.¹² Inc.com Contributing Editor, John Brandon, wrote in April 2015 that email would be obsolete by 2020.¹³

While claiming that email is dead or dying makes for good click bait, such claims aren't in line with reality. Email serves as the core communications platform of the Internet, and email usage is only growing. Radicati expects the number of worldwide email users to grow by 11% between 2021 and 2024 to more than 4.481 billion people. Every major online service in the world, ranging from social media services like Facebook and Twitter to e-commerce stores like Amazon and Walmart, requires you to provide an email address to do business with them. Email is deeply ingrained into the fabric of the Internet and won't be brushed aside by a competing service anytime soon.

This isn't to say that email marketing is the same today as it was ten years ago. Email newsletters written by individual authors have come back in a big way, as journalists have realized they can create their own media platform using tools like Substack (substack.com) and Revue (getrevue.co). Companies like The Hustle (thehustle.co) and Morning Brew (morningbrew.com) proved that is possible to build a media company entirely around email. Email has become a form of news media, which is great news for email users and marketers alike.

Email marketing has also gotten more complicated for marketers. New privacy regulations, including Europe's General Data Protection Rules and the California Consumer Privacy Act, have made marketers be more careful about what information they collect and store about their subscribers. Email providers are limiting what data that marketers can collect about their subscribers by blocking tracking pixels and location data. Email providers are also innovating on top of email's base specification to create multiple inboxes and new ways to filter messages. While these developments require marketers to innovate, they are not an existential threat to email marketing and are ultimately good for a world that increasingly values privacy.

Isn't Email Marketing Spamming?

Some people who are unfamiliar with email marketing think that all types of commercial emails are spam. "Spamming" is sending the same commercial message indiscriminately to many recipients without their permission. Modern email marketing is based almost entirely on first receiving someone's permission to email them. When you provide news, updates, and product information to someone that has *signed up* on your website to receive news, updates, and product information, that's not spam.

While there are unscrupulous email marketers that use spam as a marketing strategy, most email marketers only send email to people that have opted-in to their mailing lists and have specifically asked to receive email from them. Savvy email marketers know they can generate much better business results by cultivating an audience that wants their content than by indiscriminately spamming their marketing material to strangers.

I Hate Marketing Email and Pop-up Opt-In Forms. Why Would I Want to Send Marketing Email to My Audience?

Many tech savvy people have a natural aversion to advertisements and other marketing materials. They think they are immune to being influenced by advertising and think advertisements just get in the way of their experience when using the web. They use ad-blocking plugins to remove ads from their web browser and use strict spam filters to keep unwanted messages out of their inboxes. They absolutely hate pop-up opt-in forms because they think they are annoying. If it were up to them,

they would never receive any kind of marketing email, because they think that it just clogs up their inboxes.

If this sounds like you, you may initially feel uncomfortable with many of the recommendations in this book. Remember that you are not your audience. Just because you don't like to receive email from brands doesn't mean your customers feel the same way. While I try to stay off most mailing lists and ensure my personal inbox is empty at the end of every day, my wife, Karine's, inbox is full of promotional email from every major clothing retailer and she loves it. She loves getting coupons, deals, and seeing what new styles are coming out. She receives at least 20 emails each day from brands and it doesn't bother her a bit.

Not everyone uses email in the same way. You might see your email inbox as a work "to do" list that needs to be cleared out. Other email users see it as a stream of information where they can pick and choose what they want to read and ignore. If an email user loves the content that you produce, of course they will want to have that as part of the email influx they receive every day. The entire process of list building, setting up an autoresponder series, and sending broadcast emails is just a way for your audience to better engage with the content and products that you are already producing through their email stream.

Every now and then, I'll hear someone that runs a website say something like, "I hate pop-ups and I hate marketing email. I would never use them in my business." What they're really saying is, "I hate making money" because email marketing is an incredibly effective marketing strategy. They just can't get past their personal biases against advertising to recognize the opportunity that's before them. If one of your audience members wants to get your latest content and product information through email, you should allow them to do so despite any personal misgivings you might have against seeing advertisements on the web. If someone genuinely doesn't want to receive email from you, they won't fill out an opt-in form on your website.

My Story

During the last decade, I have built four different businesses that rely heavily on email marketing. My largest business, MarketBeat, publishes a daily investment newsletter to 3 million subscribers. MarketBeat generated more than \$25 million in top-line revenue in 2021 and most of that revenue is directly attributable to email marketing. The company sends out more than 300 million permission-based emails monthly and attracts more than 125,000 new opt-ins each month. The company generates revenue through subscription information products, newsletter ads, display advertising, email list rentals, SMS text message ads, web push notification ads, and co-registration advertising.

The second business I built was called Lightning Releases, which was a press release writing and distribution service that used email as one of its primary marketing strategies. I started this service in 2012 as a low-cost alternative to some of the more expensive press release distribution services. For \$99.00, the service allowed individuals, businesses, and nonprofits the opportunity to have their press release featured in news portals like Google News, Bing News, and Topix, as well as the websites of many major national newspapers. The business generated more than \$200,000 in 2014. I sold it to a couple of investors in early 2015 so that I could focus on my other projects.

The third email-driven business I helped launch is called GoGo Photo Contest (gogophotocontest.com), which helps animal shelters and humane societies raise money through donate-to-vote photo contest fundraisers. I co-founded this company in 2013 with a couple of good friends of mine, Jason and Stevie Shea. GoGo Photo Contest uses outbound email marketing to contact executive directors of animal shelters and educate them, then make them aware of how we can help their organizations raise money. The company works with approximately 200 animal welfare groups each year and has helped animal shelters across the country raise more than \$25 million in donations between late 2013 and 2022.

Finally, I was a partner in a company called USGolfTV, which is a digital publishing company that produces a regionally syndicated television show that's available in 12 million homes and 25 states. USGolfTV also produces premium video training courses that help golfers improve their game. USGolfTV was founded in 2010 by Todd Kolb. I acquired an equity stake in the company in August 2014 and was tasked with helping the business build an email list and grow its ad revenue. In my first 12 months with the company, USGolfTV grew its email list from 5,000 subscribers to 75,000+ subscribers using the strategies outlined in this book. The company also doubled revenue by promoting its courses more heavily to its growing email list.

There are many different resources that teach email marketing that are of varying degrees of quality. Some of them are written by people that don't have a lot of experience and don't really know what they're talking about. You can rest assured that this is not the case with *Email Marketing Demystified*. The information and advice written in this book comes directly from my personal experiences building MarketBeat, Lightning Releases, GoGo Photo Contest, and USGolfTV. None of the information in this book is theoretical, made-up, or unproven. Every tip, trick, and strategy in this book has been tested and proven in at least one of my businesses.

What You'll Learn in *Email Marketing Demystified*

Email Marketing Demystified is a comprehensive work designed to teach you every aspect of email marketing. In the first chapter, you'll learn about the necessity of having an email service provider and the different types of email service providers that exist. You'll also learn what to look for in an email service provider and decide which service is best for you.

In the second and third chapters of this book, you will learn how to collect email sign-ups. I will show you how to create a lead magnet to attract more sign-ups on your website. You will also learn which types of opt-in forms work best and how to craft your messaging to maximize the number of opt-ins you receive. These chapters will also help you discover other creative ways to grow your mailing list independently of your website.

In the fourth and fifth chapters of the book, you'll learn about welcome emails, autoresponders, broadcast emails, and other types of messages you will send to your list. These chapters will show exactly what types of email you should send to engage your audience and generate revenue. There is also a deep dive into email copywriting so that you know exactly how to write different types of messages to your list.

The sixth chapter focuses entirely on monetization, or how to make money with your mailing list. You will learn six different ways to generate revenue through your email list, including co-registration advertising, selling your company's products and services, promoting another company's products as a service, running newsletter advertisements, renting your email list, and generating traffic for your website. If you want to learn how MarketBeat generates more than \$25 million per year through email marketing, read this chapter.

The seventh and eighth chapters of *Email Marketing Demystified* focus on the legal aspects of email marketing and making sure that your messages get delivered to your subscribers' inboxes and not in their spam folders. You will learn about the United States' CAN-SPAM legislation, Canada's anti-spam legislation (CASL), Europe's General Data Protection Rule (GDPR), and what you need to do to stay compliant with them. You will also learn about the best practices to follow to maintain your reputation as an email sender and keep your domain name and IP address off blacklists.

The ninth chapter of this book explains generating sales through outbound email marketing, also known as email prospecting. Most of the book focuses on attracting subscribers and keeping them engaged with your mailing list. This chapter focuses on identifying prospective customers, introducing your business to them through a cold email, qualifying them as customers, and generating sales. If your business has a relatively small set of potential customers and sells relatively high price

point products with an average order size of \$500.00 or more, read this chapter first.

The tenth chapter was a new addition to the second edition of this book. It focuses on the emerging technology of web push notifications (also referred to as browser notifications). MarketBeat has attracted more than 500,000 web push subscribers and now generates seven-figures in revenue annually from its web push campaigns. You will learn about push notification service providers, how collect web push subscribers on your website, what type of content to send you to your web push list, and how to generate revenue from your web push audience.

In the appendix, there are links to several other resources that will help with your effort to become a better email marketer, including books, blogs, podcasts, and educational products that are worth checking out. There are also four different case studies placed throughout the book to show you what kind of results and successes are possible through email marketing.

This book references several specific email marketing tools, plugins, and services you can utilize to get started quickly with your email marketing efforts, ensuring you can be confident in using reputable products and services. There are comparisons of the features and benefits of specific products. I also have a few personal product recommendations within the book, so keep an eye out for them. Please note that neither I nor my company receive any payment or any form of compensation of any kind for recommending these few products. I will only recommend a specific product or service if I truly think it is the best solution for my friends, business partners, acquaintances, and other readers of this book.

A Call to Action

Email marketing is an incredibly powerful marketing channel that will generate massive long-term results. You won't become a millionaire overnight by implementing email marketing in your business, but you will see steadily improving returns as your email list grows and your strategies mature.

If you had started gathering email addresses on your website five years ago, you could have had a mailing list of tens of thousands or *hundreds* of thousands of subscribers today. You would have built a long-term asset that could continue to generate revenue for your business even if everything else implodes, because you can always create a new product, service, or other offers and promote it to your mailing list.

While you can't go back in time and start your mailing list five years ago, you can do the next best thing and start growing your mailing list and implementing email marketing in your business (or your nonprofit) today.

CHAPTER ONE

Selecting an Email Service Provider (ESP)

The first step in developing your email marketing program is to put the technical infrastructure in place to handle the type and volume of email you will send. If you were going to set up a call center, you would never try to run it using only your personal cell phone. You would hire an expert to tell you what you need, get dozens of phone lines and other telecommunications hardware, and put software in place specifically to handle routing calls.

Likewise, you should never try to run an email marketing campaign using your personal email account. A standard Gmail, Outlook, or Yahoo email account will typically only let you send about 500 outbound messages per day, provides no list management tools, and will not ensure compliance with anti-spam laws such as CAN-SPAM. Consumer email accounts are simply not the appropriate tool for building and managing an email list. Instead, you will want to work with an email service provider (ESP) that provides specialized web software and infrastructure that can help manage your mailing list and deliver email to your subscribers.

What Email Service Providers Do

An email service provider is a company that provides web-based email marketing software and delivery infrastructure to businesses, nonprofits, and individuals.

Here are some common tasks that your ESP will handle:

- **List Management**

Your ESP will store the list of active subscribers on your mailing list(s). They will also automatically add new subscribers to your mailing list that sign up through your opt-in forms, process users that want to unsubscribe, and remove old email addresses that are no longer valid.

- **Opt-in Forms**

Your ESP will provide you with HTML opt-in forms that you can easily embed on your website to get people to sign-up for your

mailing list. Some ESPs also provide dedicated landing pages that you can send people to that will allow them to opt-in.

- **Templates**

Your ESP may offer pre-made HTML templates that will provide your email with a unique look and feel. Most ESPs also offer the ability to upload a custom HTML template created by you or a web designer that you hire. It may also offer the ability to ensure your HTML template is compatible with most major email clients.

- **Autoresponders and Mail Scheduling**

Your ESP will let you send a pre-written series of emails to all new subscribers over a period of several weeks or months. This is known as an autoresponder series. Your ESP will also allow you to create a calendar of future mailings and schedule mailings to send out at a particular date and time.

- **Marketing Automation**

Some ESPs will allow you to send a series of messages in response to users that take a specific action, such as opting in for a new offer, purchasing a product, or abandoning their shopping cart on an e-commerce site. This functionality, known as marketing automation, allows you to send more targeted email to your subscribers and will likely improve the long-term success of your email campaign. The quality of marketing automation tools can vary widely from ESP to ESP. If marketing automation is something that you want to take advantage of, select an ESP that was built with marketing automation in mind.

- **Mail Delivery**

Sending a large volume of email requires a significant technical infrastructure and knowledge of how email deliverability works. Your ESP will provide the servers and software needed to deliver your email messages to subscribers' inboxes. They can also help if you ever run into a deliverability issue, such as being blacklisted.

- **Tracking**

Your ESP will be able to track important metrics related to the performance of any given email campaign, including the total number of sends, opens, bounces, clicks, and unsubscribes. Some email service providers may also provide a tracking pixel that will allow you to tie any given sale back to a particular email.

- **Spam Testing**

Your ESP can gauge the content of each email that you send against commonly-used spam filters. You will receive an automatic warning if you use language found in many typical spam messages (such as “prescription drugs” or “free money”) or make other technical mistakes that may cause an email provider to block the message or deliver it to a subscriber’s spam folder.

- **Dynamic Messages**

Your email service provider will allow you to dynamically customize the content of each email to tailor it to each subscriber. The most common use of this functionality is to open each email with “Dear [FirstName]” instead of a more generic greeting.

- **HTML and Text Formatting**

Your ESP will be able to create emails that are formatted as both HTML and plain text, which may improve your deliverability rates to some email providers.

Types of Email Service Providers

Not all email service providers (ESPs) provide the same tools and functionality. There are three categories of email service providers that have different strengths, focuses, and levels of service: email API providers (EAPs), email service providers (ESPs), and marketing automation providers (MAPs).

Email API Providers

Email API providers (EAPs), also referred to as email infrastructure providers, focus primarily on the actual delivery of your email. They provide the network infrastructure and email deliverability expertise necessary to make sure that your email gets delivered to your subscribers’ inboxes. EAPs generally do not provide list management services, templates, marketing automation, or email scheduling tools. They are primarily used by software developers that do their own list management

through custom software. They are often used to send transactional emails, such as welcome messages and order confirmation messages. EAP users will often schedule messages using an SMTP server or an API provided by the EAP in lieu of a web interface. Generally, you will only select an EAP over a general ESP if you are writing custom marketing software or are using a piece of third-party software that requires an outside email server.

Here are some commonly used email API providers:

- AmazonSES - aws.amazon.com/ses
- Elastic Email - elasticemail.com
- Mailjet - mailjet.com
- MailGun – mailgun.com
- PostMark - postmarkapp.com
- SendGrid – sendgrid.com
- Socket Labs - socketlabs.com

It is important to note that the quality of service can vary substantially between EAPs. In my experience, you get what you pay for. My business, MarketBeat, had a less than desirable experience with a low-cost EAP several years back and has since then moved all our mailing over to an enterprise plan with SendGrid.

Email Service Providers

Like EAPs, email service providers (ESPs) provide the necessary network infrastructure and deliverability expertise needed to make sure that your email makes it to your subscribers' inboxes. ESPs will also provide all the list management, templating, mail scheduling, performance tracking, and spam testing that ESP customers expect. If you are building a general mailing list for the purpose of sending newsletters and other content to your audience, an ESP is your best bet.

Here are some commonly used email service providers:

- Aweber - aweber.com
- Constant Contact – constantcontact.com
- Campaign Monitor – campaignmonitor.com
- ConvertKit – convertkit.com
- Drip – drip.com
- iContact - icontact.com
- GetResponse – getresponse.com
- MailChimp – mailchimp.com

Marketing Automation Platforms

Marketing automation platforms (MAPs) include a superset of the functionality that email service providers offer. In addition to providing email delivery infrastructure and list management services, MAPs will provide special tools that allow you to send a specific email series to an individual subscriber based on any actions they take or tags that you assign them. For example, if a customer purchases a certain product, you might want to send them a series of emails that provide instructions to use that product. With a MAP, new customers will automatically be tagged as a purchaser of that product and will receive the email series that you set up ahead of time. When set up properly, MAPs can send more targeted and relevant email to your subscribers, which will dramatically improve the effectiveness of your email marketing campaigns.

The line between email service providers and marketing automation platforms has blurred during the last several years. Some older ESPs have added marketing automation functionality to compete with services that were built from the ground up with marketing automation in mind. At the same time, MAPs have worked to make sure they offer the same level of list management and email delivery services offered by ESPs.

Here are some commonly used email marketing automation platforms:

- Active Campaign – [activecampaign.com](https://www.activecampaign.com)
- Drip – drip.com
- Hubspot – [Hubspot.com](https://www.hubspot.com)
- Keap (Infusionsoft) – [keap.com](https://www.keap.com)
- Klaviyo – [klaviyo.com](https://www.klaviyo.com)
- Ontraport - [ontraport.com](https://www.ontraport.com)

Purchase Considerations

When selecting an email service provider, there are several factors to consider. Here are some things to keep in mind:

- **Type of ESP**

Determine whether you need an email API provider, an email service provider, or a marketing automation platform. Unless you are writing custom software and need to send email through an API call, your best bet is to choose one that offers high-quality list management services and advanced marketing automation tools. While you might not use marketing automation functionality when you are getting started, you will want to have it available for use later due to the incredible value it can provide to your email marketing efforts.

- **Functionality**

Most email service providers offer a similar baseline of functionality, including list management, email delivery, templating, spam testing, and message scheduling. List any advanced features that you might want to leverage in your email marketing strategy and compare competing services to see which might offer the best combination of tools and services for your business.

- **Age of Software**

Email service providers do not age well because of a variety of software and database issues. Some older ESPs launched between 10 and 20 years ago have simply not been able to keep up with the functionality, user interface, and quality of service offered by those launched more recently. Older ESPs must deal with massive datasets of customer information and with legacy software code, which make them difficult to upgrade over time.

- **Cost**

Pricing between ESPs can vary significantly based on your usage and the level of service provided. Use an ESP's pricing page to calculate your cost now based on your current sending level and consider what using an ESP will cost you as your mailing list grows over time.

- **Customer Service**

Some ESPs offer much better customer service than others. If you inadvertently get added to a blacklist or have some other deliverability issue, you are going to need an ESP that has your back and can step in to correct the situation. Use Google to search for customer reviews of the ESP you are considering and search for the company's name followed by the word "sucks" or the word "scam" to see how many users are dissatisfied with a given service.

- **Terms and Conditions**

Some ESPs will suspend your account without warning if too many users mark your emails as spam or if you have too high of a bounce rate. Make sure you that you read the terms and services of the ESP you are considering and understand what circumstances are grounds for shutting down your account.

One consideration that many businesses take into account is email deliverability, but I would not put too much stock into any reviews of a particular ESP's deliverability. If you are sending from your own domain and a dedicated IP addresses that your ESP provides, the email service provider you choose will make no meaningful impact on your deliverability. If someone is having deliverability issues with their ESP, it is much more likely they are having deliverability issues because of their individual sending practices and not some larger issue that impacts all customers of a given ESP.

Take a considerable amount of time to research and compare email service providers before selecting your ESP. After you have started building a mailing list with an ESP, it can be difficult to switch to another provider. A new ESP might require you to reconfirm your entire mailing list, which could cause you to lose a large portion of your subscribers. When switching ESPs, you will also lose your past message history and performance data as well.

Choosing the Right ESP for You

In the previous section, I provided a framework for you to evaluate and compare multiple email service providers. There are many good email service providers that will serve your email marketing efforts perfectly well. If you only have basic marketing needs that do not extend beyond sending email to a mailing list and setting up an autoresponder series, every well-known ESP will work for you just fine.

For specific types of email lists, there are some email service providers that work better than others based on pricing, functionality, and what types of users they are targeting. For individual content creators, artists, and musicians, I recommend ConvertKit (convertkit.com). ConvertKit has a low price of entry, including a free plan, and offers tools that allow creators to sell digital goods and services to their audience. ConvertKit is what I use for my personal email list.

For small non-profit organizations, I recommend MailChimp. MailChimp is easy for non-technical users to learn and send email with. It also allows you to easily build opt-in forms to get people to sign-up for your mailing list. It also has a free plan that allows you to build a list of up to 2,000 subscribers for free. It also remains affordable after you graduate from their free plan.

For e-commerce store owners, I recommend Klaviyo. Klaviyo was built with e-commerce store owners in mind and can integrate with

popular e-commerce platforms such as Shopify and WooCommerce. Klaviyo can track sales generated from an individual email send and will allow you to setup common automations used by e-commerce websites such as abandoned cart emails.

For software developers needing an email API provider (EAP), I recommend SendGrid. MarketBeat has used an enterprise plan from SendGrid for years for its transactional email. We have had a great experience working with their team growing our mail volume to more than 300 million emails each month and we can't say enough nice things about them.

For small businesses that don't meet any of the criteria above, I recommend ActiveCampaign. ActiveCampaign is a bit of a kitchen sink email provider. It provides all the email marketing functionality that a small business would need and then some. It's not the cheapest email service provider out there, but the cheapest option is rarely the best option for a for-profit business.

If you just aren't sure what email service provider to use, you may consider signing up for other email lists in your category. You can usually tell what email service provider someone is using by either looking at the footer of their emails, their "thank you" page that appears after signing up, or their cancellation page that shows up after clicking on their "unsubscribe" link. If you see many other individuals or companies in your space using the same email service provider, that is a good indication that it is the right ESP for your business.

The recommended email service providers listed in this chapter are companies that either I or someone that I know have used personally and had a good experience with. Please note that I do not receive any affiliate commissions or any other form of compensation for recommending the email providers listed in this chapter.

Email Service Provider Costs

The ongoing monthly cost of using an email service provider will be based primarily on the size of your mailing list and the frequency that you email your list. When you are first getting started, several email service providers offer a free tier that allows you to build a mailing list of a few thousand subscribers before you must start paying an ongoing monthly fee.

For example, Mailchimp allows you to build a list of 2,000 subscribers on their free tier. As your list grows to 10,000 subscribers, you can expect to pay \$50.00-\$75.00 per month with most providers.

Your monthly fee will continue to grow as your list grows, but do not let that be a major concern. Paying a large monthly email service provider is the cost of success.

As of mid-2022, MarketBeat was paying about \$22,000 per month to SendGrid for a package that allows us to send 300 million emails monthly. While the monthly fee is a big number, it is a small price to pay given that email marketing generates more than ten million dollars in annual revenue for our business.

Wrap-Up

Your email service provider will become the foundation of your email marketing efforts. They will provide the software and network infrastructure needed, so you do not have to focus on the technical intricacies of sending out email at scale. With a high-quality ESP in place, you can focus on growing your mailing list, writing marketing content, and generating revenue from your list.

Action Steps:

- Research and compare email service providers.
- Select an email service provider and register for an account.
- Become familiar with your email service provider's software platform.

CASE STUDY #1

MarketBeat

In early 2011, I founded MarketBeat (then called Analyst Ratings Network), a financial media company that empowers individuals to make better trading decisions by providing real-time financial data and objective market analysis. Prior to that, I had been running a financial news website called American Banking and Market News, which garnered more than one million page views per month and was generating well into five figures of monthly advertising revenue.

While the business was doing well, it was heavily dependent upon referral traffic from Google. They sent traffic to our website, and we sent traffic back to their advertisers through Google's AdSense program. This is a great strategy as long as Google continued to send traffic. As every entrepreneur that uses SEO as a marketing strategy has learned in the last decade, that's not ever guaranteed. I wanted my business to stand the test of time, and to do this, I knew we would need to cultivate a loyal audience of subscribers that kept coming back to MarketBeat as a trusted source of information. We would also need to monetize their attention, either by selling them products we produce or through advertising other people's products.

At the time, I wasn't quite sure what we could sell to our audience, but I knew that we would need to communicate with them in some way other than hoping they would come back to the website every day. It quickly became apparent to me that we needed to build an email list. We added some opt-in forms to our website and started publishing a daily financial newsletter that contains a wrap-up of the latest stock recommendations from equities research analysts.

MarketBeat's daily newsletter quickly found a product-market fit. Investors get emotionally invested in the companies they are invested in and want to stay up to date with the latest news and developments about their stocks. We were able to compile thousands of news stories, corporate events, and other financial data points and make them available to investors in a convenient and real-time format.

After running our newsletter for about six months, we had attracted our first 10,000 subscribers. At the same time, we were receiving requests to add additional features and types of information to our newsletter. We took the feedback from our subscribers and made a better version of the newsletter called MarketBeat Daily Premium that would be available to our subscribers for a monthly fee.

For \$19.97 per month or \$199.00 per year, subscribers could get their newsletter delivered earlier in the day, receive SMS or email alerts

for their stocks, customize the look and feel of their newsletter, and set up a watch list to get more news and information about the companies they have invested in.

While MarketBeat has expanded to other communication channels over the year, our free daily newsletter continues to serve as the core communication point between the company and our subscribers. It is still the primary lead magnet that our company uses and serves as an effective tool to keep our subscriber base engaged with the content that we produce.

MarketBeat's subscribers love the up-to-the-minute financial news and information that is included in our newsletter. In addition to keeping our users engaged, we also use our daily newsletter to share news and announcements from our company and send people back to our website. The newsletter also generates revenue through cost-per-click ads that are placed at the top and bottom of each newsletter.

We launched a suite of web-based investment research tools called MarketBeat All Access in 2012. This higher-tier service includes MarketBeat Daily Premium and gives users access to stock screeners, proprietary research reports, a real-time news feed, and extended data export tools so users can do their own analysis in Microsoft Excel. MarketBeat All Access is available to investors for \$39.97 per month or \$399.00 per year. MarketBeat All Access now accounts for two-thirds of our recurring annual revenue.

Furthermore, we have been able to dramatically improve MarketBeat's opt-in rates over the years by continually split-testing our opt-in forms and developing new and creative traffic sources. We attract more than 50,000 organic opt-ins each month through our "login wall" opt-in form, a Google One Tap opt-in, and opt-in forms integrated into the various pages on our website. We use a lightweight and simple form that automatically identifies typos and has a single call-to-action.

One big optimization win we had early on was to customize our pop-up on a per page basis to reference the name of the company discussed in the article. You can view MarketBeat's current pop-up opt-in form by navigating within your web browser to MarketBeat.com.

Since the initial publishing of this book, MarketBeat has had significant success in growing its list through paid acquisition. MarketBeat now spends over \$300,000 per month to grow its email list. We know that each email sign-up is worth about \$7.50 in revenue to our company over the course of two years. Since we can buy email sign-ups from other investing websites for \$2.00 to \$3.00, increasing our advertising budget was an easy decision.

MarketBeat utilizes several email marketing automation techniques. The company has a 30-day autoresponder series that every new

subscriber receives. We also send specific campaigns to subscribers based on the products and services they have or have not purchased. For our paid products, we send out an engagement campaign to new customers that shows them how to use the product they purchased. For subscribers that haven't opened a message in thirty days, we send a campaign to try and get them re-engaged with our mailing list.

We utilize cart abandonment tools, which allow us to market to subscribers that reviewed our sales page but didn't purchase. We also have campaigns that target individuals that had previously purchased our product but have since cancelled. These narrowly targeted campaigns have been incredibly effective at generating more sales and increasing the lifetime value of each customer.

MarketBeat generates revenue from both premium subscriptions and advertising. When I first launched the business, I expected most of the revenue to come from selling premium subscriptions. Over the years, MarketBeat's advertising revenue has grown exponentially, and our subscription growth has grown linearly. Advertising revenue now makes up 80% of MarketBeat's revenue and the company has really grown into primarily being a media company that also operates a smaller subscription products business.

MarketBeat has several different advertising channels, including display advertising on the MarketBeat.com website, co-registration ads, newsletter ads, dedicated email sends, SMS text blasts, and web push notifications. Most of our ad inventory is sold directly to a variety of financial advertisers including stock brokerages, publicly traded companies looking for exposure, financial software providers, and financial newsletter publishers. More information about MarketBeat's revenue streams is included in the monetization chapter of this book.

As of mid-2022, approximately 3 million investors subscribe to MarketBeat's daily newsletter, and we send more than 100 million permission-based emails each month. Between MarketBeat.com and its sister websites, we generate more than 10 million page views monthly. MarketBeat generated more than \$25 million in top-line revenue during our last fiscal year.

CHAPTER TWO

Building Your Mailing List Through Your Website

If your organization is going to develop a successful email marketing program, you are going to need a consistent strategy to build and grow your email list. One of the foundational elements of every list-building initiative should be collecting email opt-ins on your website. People who are interested in your content are likely already visiting your website on a regular basis. Since your website already has your audience's attention, it makes a lot of sense to use your website as one of your primary means of gathering email sign-ups.

Lead Magnets

You should offer your subscribers something of perceived value in exchange for signing up for your email list, such as a discount coupon, a free report, or a resource list. In the world of email marketing, this is known as a lead magnet. Many website visitors are hesitant to enter their email address into an opt-in form on a website because of the perceived risk of receiving more unwanted spam email. You need to develop a compelling and valuable offer so that your potential subscribers will desire your lead magnet enough to outweigh any potential fear of receiving more unwanted email. Your subscribers know that their email address is valuable to you, and you need to offer them something of equal value in return.

A good lead magnet will help your website visitors learn a specific skill, solve a specific problem, or accomplish a specific task. The content of your lead magnet should be as closely correlated to the content on your website as possible. If you have a website about mobile apps, you might offer a list of 25 essential apps that everyone should download. If you have a gardening website, you might offer a guide about the best plants to grow in a specific climate. If you have a website that helps someone study for a certification, you might offer a free downloadable study guide.

You may even consider creating multiple lead magnets for different sections of your website, so that your lead magnets can be more closely tied to the content on individual pages on your website. On a personal finance site, you might have a home buying guide on your real-estate content, a new investor check list on your investing content, and a coupon book on your content about saving money. While creating multiple lead magnets will take time, the additional work will significantly improve your opt-in rates.

Types of Lead Magnets

Here are a few common varieties of lead magnets that are typically offered in opt-in forms:

- **Free Report or Guide**

Free reports are the most common type of lead magnet. It should help your users learn about something they are interested in or help them accomplish a specific goal. For example, if you had a website about marketing, you might offer a free guide that helps people create their first Facebook ad campaign. The content of your free report should not otherwise be available on your website.

- **Resource List**

A resource list is simply a list of products, services, tools, and worksheets that will help your subscribers get started more quickly with what you want to teach them. If you had a personal finance blog, you might offer your subscribers a list of software budgeting tools and resources to keep track of their money, ensure they have the right kinds of insurance, and determine whether they are saving enough for retirement.

- **Free Trial**

If you run a software-as-a-service (SaaS) company, you might consider offering a 14-day or 30-day trial of your service as a lead magnet. Offering a free trial will get users engaged in your SaaS application and give you the opportunity to send them marketing content via email.

- **Educational Videos**

If you are good in front of a camera, you might record a series of instructional videos using your webcam. You can also record a screencast of an application, like Adobe Photoshop or Microsoft Excel, to show users how to perform a specific task like removing scratches from a photo in Photoshop or creating a pivot table in Excel.

- **Downloadable Software**

If your company or organization produces any kind of downloadable software, you might consider requiring a user to enter their email address to download your software.

- **Discounts or Free Shipping**

E-commerce stores often offer a one-time use coupon for 10% or 20% off a customer's first order as their lead magnet. While offering a discount might lower the total price of a customer's first order, it will significantly increase the probability that a website visitor will become a customer in the first place, because they will be receiving email about your company's products and services.

- **Catalog or Sales Material**

If your company sells business-to-business services or offers a product with a high price point, sending a product catalog or additional sales materials can serve as an effective lead magnet.

- **Physical Products**

If having a subscriber's physical mailing address is important to you, you can offer an inexpensive-to-produce physical product as your lead magnet. Small tools such as flashlights, knives, and screwdrivers are often used as physical product lead magnets. To make up the cost of producing and mailing a physical product, you can also charge a small shipping and handling fee that will generally pay for both the product and the shipping. A good example of this is the "free" credit card knife that SurvivalLife.com offered for years for \$4.95 shipping and handling. While they likely broke even on their lead magnet, they acquire the email address, phone number, and full mailing address of everyone that signed-up to receive a free credit card knife.

- **Worksheets and Templates**

If you are helping your subscribers achieve a specific task, you can send them a Word document or Excel file that contains a worksheet or template that helps them work through that task. For example, if you had a website about sewing, you could send free patterns that

help your readers make a particular garment. If you are writing to website designers, you could offer them a free proposal template.

Lead Magnet Examples

At MarketBeat, we use our free daily email newsletter as our primary lead magnet. We set the expectation to our subscribers that they are going to receive emails containing up-to-the-minute financial news and stock recommendations daily. By setting this expectation in advance, users will not be surprised by the relatively large volume of emails we send out. Through this daily interaction we also can promote our premium products in our newsletter and insert cost-per-click (CPC) ads for advertisers. We have tested other types of lead magnets in the past, but our daily newsletter has outperformed everything else we have tested.

When I was at USGolfTV, we used web-based training videos as our lead magnets. A website visitor might opt in to receive a series of five videos about how to improve their putting or how to fix their slice. They had to verify their email address to receive the first video and would receive an additional video each day for the following four days. After the video series was complete, the subscriber would begin to receive our weekly email newsletter and marketing content for USGolfTV's premium video training courses. The content in our lead magnets was often closely related to our premium video products, which made for a smooth transition between sending our free video content and promoting our paid products.

Many online clothing boutiques, including Filly Flair (fillyflair.com) and Chelsea's Boutique (chelseas.com), use discounts as their primary lead magnets. Clothing boutiques recognize that their customers love getting a good deal and have leveraged that reality in their lead magnets. Chelsea's Boutique offers a \$10.00 discount to each new subscriber's next purchase. Filly Flair pops up a prize wheel that lets shoppers "spin" to win a discount between 5% and 25% off their next order. By offering a coupon to new subscribers, these boutiques are increasing the likelihood that a customer will place another order quickly because they want to make use of their coupon.

More Lead Magnet Ideas

If you are not sure what lead magnet will work best for your website, there are many resources available online that offer specific ideas for lead magnets. A Google search for "lead magnet ideas" will return dozens of pages of articles that contain lead magnets you can model. You can also check out the websites of some of your competitors to see what kinds of lead magnets they are offering and get some more industry-specific ideas.

Do not agonize over the task of creating a lead magnet. It does not necessarily need to be long, complicated, or take a lot of work to create. You may be able to repurpose a piece of content that you have already created as your lead magnet, or even use a piece of content that someone else has made. For example, I once used a free guide produced by the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority (FINRA) as a lead magnet. Your lead magnet can be as simple as a one-page report or a list of your favorite tools and resources.

Regardless of what you choose as your lead magnet, remember that it should be a piece of content valuable to your readers. It should be closely related to the content on your website and should teach your readers how to accomplish a specific task, learn a specific skill, or solve a specific problem.

Messaging and Copy

After you have created your lead magnet, you will need to identify what kind of messaging you are going to use to get your potential subscribers to sign up for your mailing list. The language that you use on your opt-in forms will have a dramatic impact on the number of email sign-ups you receive. By creating a compelling and relevant offer and using strong language with clear calls-to-action, you will get much higher opt-in rates.

Before looking at opt-in form software, you will first need to write the actual text (or copy) that will appear on your opt-in form. You will need to write a short headline, which will be the first piece of text that a potential subscriber reads. Then you need a description that provides more detail about what the user can expect to receive when they give you their email address. You will also need to decide what kind of information to collect on your form and what you want on the text of your clickable button.

Writing Your Headline

The headline on your opt-in form is the first piece of copy that your potential subscribers will see and may be the most important words that you write in your business. A good headline will create desire for your lead magnet and encourage potential subscribers to read your opt-in description.

In contrast, a bad headline will be quickly passed over and ignored. It should be short, engaging, and briefly communicate what your website visitors will receive if they sign up for your mailing list.

Typically, the best headlines are between five and ten words in length and will ideally fit into a single line of text.

Here are some examples of headlines I have personally used:

- 10 Best Stocks to Own in 2023
- Insiders are Selling Shares of Apple Stock – Why?
- Get in on the \$100 Trillion Green Revolution
- Frustrated with Your Putting Skills?
- Learn to Eliminate the “Blow-Up Hole” (free video!)
- Add 20+ Yards to Your Drives Today!

Writing Your Description

The description on your opt-in form is the main copy that explains your lead magnet, sets the expectation for the type of email your recipients will receive, and provides an overall value proposition for why someone might want to be on your mailing list.

Your description should be between 20 and 50 words in length, and it should be clear and concise. Avoid unnecessary words and keep your description as short as possible while fully explaining your value proposition and setting a high expectation for the emails they will receive. Finally, include a call-to-action which instructs readers to complete the opt-in form.

Here is the opt-in description we use on MarketBeat to attract email sign-ups:

Enter your email address below to receive a concise daily summary of analysts’ upgrades and downgrades with MarketBeat’s FREE daily email newsletter.

Selecting Your Button Text

The text on your sign-up button will be the shortest part of your opt-in that you write. Your button text may only be two or three words but having the right text on your sign-up button can improve your opt-in rates by 10-30%. Most websites use a very generic button text like “Submit,” “Get Instant Access,” or “Subscribe Now.” Because web users are used to clicking on buttons that say “Subscribe” and “Submit,” using a generic button text will work reasonably well. We are currently using “Sign-Up Now (Free)” as the text on MarketBeat’s buttons, which has outperformed more than a dozen other variations we have tried.

You can also try creating a unique button text that ties into the copy in your title and description. Instead of “Sign-Up Now” on MarketBeat, we might test something like “Rate My Stock Portfolio” or “Send Me Stock Ideas.” On a clothing website, you might test a button text of “Show Me Outfits I’ll Love” or “Show Me The Latest Fall Styles.” Your mileage may vary with creative button text, but they are worth testing.

Types of Opt-In Forms

Opt-in forms come in many different shapes and sizes and can be put on many different places in your website's layout. Some are small and less intrusive, such as in a sidebar or below the fold of a website, but are less likely to be seen by users. Others are larger, well-placed, and hard to miss, and will generally get much better opt-in rates. As the use of opt-in forms on websites has expanded in the last decade, several broad categories of opt-in forms have been created by the Internet marketing community.

Here are some common types of opt-in forms that are used on the web today:

- **Entry Pop-up**

This is a rectangular opt-in form that appears at the center of the user's screen when they first navigate to your website. Typically, the rest of the web page will be dimmed to place an emphasis on the opt-in form. Entry pop-ups will also usually contain an "X" or "close" button that allows users to exit the opt-in form so they can view the rest of the website. To avoid being overly intrusive, many webmasters will only show a pop-up to their users the first time they visit their website each week. Entry pop-ups are an extremely effective tool to gather email opt-ins and often have rates three to five times higher than an opt-in form in a sidebar or at the bottom of an article.

- **Exit Pop-up**

An exit pop-up operates very similar to an entry pop-up, but only appears when the user has taken an action indicating they are getting ready to leave a website. If a user's mouse cursor leaves the main window of your website or if a user clicks on a link, an exit pop-up will appear. Webmasters sometimes choose exit pop-ups over entry pop-ups because they are perceived as less obtrusive, but they are also less visible than entry pop-ups because not all users leaving a website will see an exit pop-up before moving on to another website. Exit pop-ups also generally do not appear on smartphones and tablets because these devices do not have a mouse cursor to track.

- **Welcome Page**

A welcome page is an entry pop-up on steroids. A welcome page will cover the user's entire screen with a large opt-in form and

require them to click a close button or scroll down to see the webpage that they are trying to access.

- **Login Wall**

A login wall requires users to login or create an account after visiting a certain number of pages on your website. Login walls work well on news websites, tools-based websites, and websites where users will commonly visit dozens of pages in a single session. MarketBeat switched from an entry popup to a login wall in 2022 and immediately saw a 300% increase in opt-ins. Login walls can be incredibly effective, but they might push away some users and they also require custom coding to implement.

- **Footer Opt-In**

A footer opt-in is simply an opt-in form that appears at the bottom of an article. After a user is done reading an article on your website, they are naturally ready to read another article or take another action, such as signing up for your mailing list. Footer opt-in forms can attract highly engaged subscribers, because every subscriber that completes a footer opt-in has probably already read at least one article on your website. Footer opt-ins are also very unobtrusive, because they appear below the fold and only command a user's attention after they are reading an article. You can view an example of a footer opt-in by reading any article located on [AmericanBankingNews.com](https://www.americanbankingnews.com).

- **Sidebar Opt-in**

A sidebar opt-in is simply an opt-in form that appears in the sidebar of your website. These often get lower opt-in rates than other types because they are not in the main column of content that a user is reading. This doesn't mean that you should avoid sidebar opt-ins altogether, because sidebar opt-ins can complement other forms on your website. You can view an example of a sidebar opt-in by visiting [AmericanBankingNews.com](https://www.americanbankingnews.com).

- **Hello Bar**

A hello bar is a wide, rectangular opt-in form that sits at the top or bottom of your web browser. A hello bar will typically be about 50

pixels tall and span the entire width of your screen. Because of their relatively small size, a hello bar will typically only have a headline, a textbox for your email address, and a submit button. You can see what a hello bar might look like on your website by using the demo tool provided on HelloBar.com.

- **Scroll Box**

A scroll box is a square or rectangular box that appears in the bottom right corner of your website after a user scrolls down. A scroll box will float above the rest of the content on your website and is generally viewed as unobtrusive because they do not cover up the main content of your website. You can view a demo of a scroll box or add one to your website using the plugin produced by SumoMe at sumome.com/app/scroll-box.

- **Sign in With Google**

Many news-oriented websites now feature a small popup that allows users to sign into the website with their Google account. The pop-up only appears if a user is already signed into their Google account. The pop-up shows the user's Google account name, email address, and profile picture. Users can click on their account to sign into the website with one click. Integrating the "Sign in with Google" pop-up requires custom software development work, but it is incredibly effective as an opt-in mechanism because users can sign up for your email list without having to enter their email address.

Which Opt-In Forms Work Best?

While there are several types of opt-in forms that you can place on your website, some work much better than others. As a baseline, I recommend implementing an entry pop-up and a footer opt-in form on your website. The entry pop-up will be visible to everyone that visits your website for the first time. The footer opt-in will catch the attention of readers that have finished reading an article. If you want to be more aggressive, you can also add a sidebar opt-in form to your website in addition to the prior two suggestions. Using multiple opt-in forms on your website will generate a higher opt-in rate than using any single opt-in form because users that miss your entry popup may sign up through another opt-in form on your website.

Keep your opt-in forms simple to maximize their effectiveness. Use the minimum amount of copy necessary in your headline and description to ensure your potential subscribers will read all your copy. A simple and

consistent value proposition is the best route, because it lets users know exactly what they are getting in exchange for their email address. While it is tempting to try to collect a lot of information about your users up front—such as their name, gender, and interests—your best bet is to only ask for their email address on your opt-in form. Asking for additional information beyond a user's email address will make them less likely to complete your opt-in form. You can always ask for additional personal details later in your autoresponder series.

Your opt-in forms should have a good validation script to make sure users are entering valid email addresses into your form. If a user doesn't enter an email address and tries to click the submit button, they should receive an error message telling them they didn't complete the required field. If a user enters something that is not in the format of a valid email address, they should receive a different message informing them of such. If a user makes a common typo, such as indicating their email address is from "@gmial.com" or "@hotmial.com", your opt-in form should automatically warn the user that they may have typed in their email address wrong.

Ideally, your opt-in plugin will do these validation tasks for you. If you are using a form that you created yourself or one a developer made for you, you can use a script called MailCheck.js to automatically check for erroneous emails at: github.com/mailcheck/mailcheck.

While I recommend using an entry popup, a footer opt-in form, simple and clean copy, and minimal form elements, what works well for my companies may not work equally well for yours. Your website will have a different structure and audience than mine, so your mileage may vary with the recommendations listed above. For this reason, it is important to regularly test different messaging, lead magnets, and opt-in form plugins to see if you can improve your opt-in rates. Consider the recommendations listed above to be a good baseline until you find something that works better for your website.

Worried about Annoying Your Users?

Some webmasters will refuse to place large and hard-to-miss opt-in forms like pop-ups and welcome pages because they believe those types of opt-in forms are obtrusive, annoying, and degrade the user's overall experience. Do not let any personal feelings or opinions you might have stop you from using large opt-in forms. Remember that you are not your users. Many technology enthusiasts think that all ads are annoying and should be avoided, but that doesn't mean that your potential subscribers think the same.

Your subscribers may be glad that you have a large opt-in form that appears when they first visit your website because they want your lead magnet and other email content that you produce.

If you truly believe that a large opt-in form or a popup is too annoying for your users, let the data do the talking. Run a split-test with half of your website visitors seeing the opt-in form and the other half not seeing the opt-in form at all. If the users who see the opt-in form visit the same average number of pages on your website that users who do not see the opt-in form do, you know the opt-in form is not driving any visitors away from your website.

Common Opt-in Form Plugins and Services

To design and place opt-in forms on your website, you will most likely need to make use of an opt-in form plugin or a cloud-based opt-in form service. As email marketing has grown in popularity over the years, several high-quality opt-in form plugins have been developed for WordPress and every other major content management system. They will provide templates that allow you to customize the look-and-feel of your opt-in form and generate the HTML, CSS, and JavaScript necessary for your opt-in forms to run. These plugins will also integrate with your email service provider (ESP), so new sign-ups are automatically funneled to your ESP.

Here are some of the most popular opt-in form plugins:

- **OptinMonster**

OptinMonster ([optinmonster.com](https://www.optinmonster.com)) is a widely-used service that can place many different types of opt-ins on your website. This service integrates with all content management systems, has integrated split-testing functionality, and enables you to use custom messaging on a per page or per category basis. OptinMonster works with nearly all email service providers including MailChimp, AWeber, Keap, Constant Contact, and 15 others. While OptinMonster is incredibly flexible and feature-rich, it is one of the few services that charge an ongoing monthly fee for its use. Depending on your level of traffic, you will pay between \$9.00 and \$49.00 per month to use their service.

- **Sumo List Builder**

Sumo ([sumo.com](https://www.sumo.com)) offers a highly customizable list-building script called List Builder that can be added to any website. List Builder works either as an entry pop-up or exit pop-up and works with most major email service providers. Sumo is a freemium service that allows you to use their basic tools for free. They also have a

premium offering called Sumo Pro that costs \$39.00 per month that is geared toward high traffic websites.

- **HelloBar**

HelloBar (hellobar.com) is a service that allows you to integrate a hello bar, entry popup, scroll box, or welcome page on your website. The look and feel of their forms are highly customizable and are mobile friendly. HelloBar is a freemium service that offers basic services for free with a variety of premium subscription tiers ranging from \$29.00 to \$99.00 per month.

- **Popup Domination**

Popup Domination (popupdomination.com) is a WordPress plugin that will allow you to create entry and exit pop-ups on your website. It features integrated A/B testing and analytics and allows you to show different pop-ups on a per-page or per-category basis. Popup Domination offers very visually appealing opt-in form templates that are a step above many other opt-in form plugins. Popup Domination works with all major email service providers and is available for an annual fee of \$54.00 per year to \$174.00 per year.

- **Bloom**

Bloom (elegantthemes.com/plugins/bloom) is a WordPress opt-in plugin created by Elegant Themes. Bloom can add an entry pop-up, footer opt-in form, or sidebar opt-in form to your website. It boasts more than 100 customizable templates, has integrated A/B testing, and works with nearly all major email service providers. Bloom is available as part of Elegant Themes' membership program, which costs \$89.00 per year.

- **WPForms**

WPForms (wpforms.com) is a drag and drop WordPress form builder that allows users to create contact forms, payment forms, newsletter opt-in forms. WPForms is known for its simple user interface allowing non-developers to build great-looking opt-in forms. WPForms integrates with most email service providers and has subscription tiers ranging from \$39.50 to \$299.50 per year.

Which Opt-In Plugin Is Best?

There are dozens of different opt-in form plugins that you can choose from. While it would be nice to recommend an opt-in form plugin that is ideally suited to everyone, there is no one-size-fits-all plugin that works for everyone in every situation. Some opt-in form plugins and services are specific to a single content management system, such as WordPress or Drupal. Other opt-in plugins only create certain types of opt-in forms, such as landing pages, exit pop-ups, or entry pop-ups.

I recommend looking at the marketing material for all the opt-in plugins previously listed and find one that meets your specific needs. If your website runs WordPress, you will have several different opt-in form plugins to choose from. If your website is powered by another platform, you can use a cloud-based opt-in form service such as SumoMe, OptinMonster, or HelloBar.

Special Considerations for Opt-in Forms

Make sure that the opt-in form you select doesn't negatively impact the load speed of your website. Some opt-in plugins are written much more efficiently than others. If your opt-in plugin noticeably slows down how fast your website loads, you should probably switch to a different plugin or service.

You can test the impact of your opt-in form plugin on your website's load speed using a tool called GTMetrix (gtmetrix.com). Test your website first before installing your opt-in form and test it again after putting your opt-in form in place. If the addition of your opt-in software slows down your website's load speed by more than a second, it probably wasn't written very efficiently.

In special situations, it may be better to have a custom opt-in form created by a front-end web developer. I personally do not use any third-party opt-in plugins on my websites. A while back, I hired a developer to create a lightweight, custom opt-in form on my website that would work as an entry popup, a footer opt-in form, and a sidebar opt-in form. By having a custom script written, I was able to reduce the file size of the opt-in script from about 150KB to about 12KB. This significantly improved my website's load speed. I was also able to integrate better form validation through MailCheck.js and KickBox (kickbox.io) than was available with the off-the-shelf plugin I was using previously. However, it will not make sense for you to have a custom opt-in script created by a web developer when you are first getting started because you need a simpler option.

Many large websites still use off-the-shelf opt-in plugins. However, if you have a very popular website, need some custom functionality added to your opt-in form, or are very concerned about the load speed of

your website, it may then make sense to use a custom opt-in form created by a web developer.

How Many Opt-Ins Can I Expect?

Asking how many opt-ins you should expect to receive on your website is one of the most common questions I hear from new email marketers. The volume of opt-ins that you can expect will be totally dependent on how much traffic your website receives, the quality of that traffic, and the effectiveness of your opt-in forms.

If you are getting 20,000 page views per month on your website, you are probably going to receive twice as many opt-ins than you would if you only had 10,000 page views per month. If most of your visitors come to your website from search engines and other websites like yours, you are likely going to get better opt-in rates, because people doing searches and looking at websites similar to yours are either doing research or are generally more engaged than people that wander onto your website from social media or unrelated websites. Working to attract a steadily growing stream of high-quality traffic is the single best way to set yourself up to build a large mailing list.

The size, number, design, content, and placement of your opt-in forms will have a significant impact on your opt-in rate. When you are first getting started with email marketing, you will not have any idea what combination of lead magnets, messaging, and opt-in forms will yield the highest opt-in rates.

Your best bet is to start with the practices I have outlined earlier in this chapter and do a few dozen split-tests over time to determine if there are ways that you can improve your opt-in rates from the baseline that I recommend.

A highly effective set of opt-in forms on a website with good traffic sources might yield an opt-in rate of 4-5%. A less effective set of opt-in forms on the same website might only command an opt-in rate of 0.5%. There is no industry standard for what opt-in rates you should expect, so do not beat yourself up if you get low rates for the first few months of your email marketing efforts. Instead, focus on whether your opt-in rates are *improving* every month.

Let's say that during the first month of your email marketing initiative that you get 20,000 page views and 200 opt-ins. You had an opt-in rate of 1%. During the second month, your website attracts a bit more traffic and receives 25,000 page views. You set up a highly effective pop-up opt-in form, and you receive 500 opt-ins. Your opt-in rate grew to 2% during the second month. During the third month, your traffic stays flat at 25,000 page views, but you identify a highly effective lead magnet, and you attract 750 new opt-ins. Your opt-in rate just grew to 3%. By making

a series of improvements and running a series of split-tests, your opt-in rates will slowly improve over time.

What If My Website Doesn't Get Much Traffic?

If you are just getting started and your website is not getting much traffic yet, you should still place opt-in forms on your website. It takes time to create a popular website and build a large mailing list. You may only get 50 or 100 opt-ins per month for the first several months of operating your website, and that's okay. Your total list size will continue to grow as weeks and months go on. As new subscribers sign up, your list will grow like a snowball rolling down a hill. Before you know it, you will have a few thousand people on your mailing list that want to receive email from you on a regular basis.

While growing the amount of traffic your website receives is beyond the scope of this book, there are several great resources available that can teach you how to build a popular website. The book *Traction* by Gabriel Weinberg provides an overview of 19 different marketing channels you can use to grow your business and get more people onto your website. There are several books in the "For Dummies" series that teach traffic generation concepts, such as search engine optimization, social media marketing, and Facebook marketing. DigitalMarketer.com and SmartMarketer.com both produce courses and other resources that show you how to attract more web traffic. If you are not sure what marketing channels you should pursue initially, you can use SimilarWeb (similarweb.com) to see where some of your competitors are currently getting their traffic from.

Split-Testing Your Opt-in Forms

The key to getting great opt-in rates is regularly running tests to determine if making changes to your forms will increase the percentage of people that complete them. To do this, identify one change to your forms that might improve your opt-in rates. Show half of your website's visitors the original version of your opt-in form and show the new variation you created to the other half. Your opt-in form software's split-testing capability will be able to handle the 50-50 split for you without having to write any code. Wait until about 300 more people complete your opt-in form.

If the two versions are equally effective, they should both receive about 150 opt-ins. If your variation gets 175 opt-ins and your original opt-in form only gets 125, you know that the change you made likely improved your opt-in rates. On the other hand, if the original opt-in form gets more opt-ins than the variation, you know that the split-test didn't work, and you should stick with your original opt-in form.

Every aspect of your opt-in forms can and should be tested. You might find that an entry pop-up works better than an exit pop-up. You might find that adding a second opt-in form to your website improves your opt-in rates. You can test changing the language in your headline, description, and button text. You can test a different lead magnet to see if it better resonates with your subscribers. You can even try changing the colors and fonts in your opt-in forms. Remember, however, that you should only test one change on your website at a time. If you make multiple changes at once, you will not know which changes are helping your opt-in rates and which are hurting them.

If your website doesn't receive a lot of opt-ins, it may take a while for you to run a statistically valid split-test. If you only receive 100 opt-ins each month, it is going to take you several months to identify a clear winner. Because you can't run as many split-tests when you are first getting started, you should put significantly more thought into the changes that you evaluate. Start with big changes, such as re-writing your headline or trying a different lead magnet. Only test smaller changes like colors and button text after you have thoroughly exhausted the more visible aspects of your opt-in form.

You will eventually reach a point where your opt-in forms are homed in, and you start to see diminishing returns on your split-testing efforts. This does not mean you should stop testing altogether. The effectiveness of different types of lead magnets and opt-in forms will change over time as web users' behaviors change. If you had a highly optimized set of opt-in forms three years ago and haven't done any split-testing since then, it is probably time to start testing new lead magnets, new messaging, and new types of opt-in forms.

Creating Your “Thank You” Page

The page that users are redirected to after they sign up for your mailing list is often referred to as a “thank you” page, because it usually contains a message that thanks a subscriber for signing up for a mailing list. A “thank you” page will also often contain next steps that the user should take, such as clicking a link in a confirmation email or checking out other content produced on your website. On most websites, there generally is not much content on a “thank you” page other than a brief message welcoming people to their mailing list.

Most webmasters do not realize that their “thank you” page is an incredibly valuable piece of advertising real estate. A user that lands on your “thank you” page after opting in has already indicated they are interested in your content and have taken a specific action to receive more of it. They are much more likely than other users to take another action, such as signing up for a free trial of a premium service, clicking on a banner ad, or opting into another mailing list through a co-registration advertising unit.

While you might make \$10.00 in ad revenue for every 1,000 people that read an article on your website, you can make between \$100.00 and \$750.00 for every 1,000 new subscribers that land on your “thank you” page. For specific information about how to monetize your “thank you” page, read the monetization chapter of this book.

Wrap-Up

Implementing good opt-in forms on your website is your first step to building a large and profitable email list. Collecting opt-ins from your website should be the core of your list-building efforts. While other list-building strategies might require an upfront cash investment, subscribers that opt-in through your website are effectively free. Spend sufficient time writing compelling copy, create a highly desirable lead magnet, and implement an opt-in form plugin, and your mailing list will grow steadily over time.

Action Steps:

- Develop a lead magnet to offer to new subscribers.
- Write the messaging (copy) that you want to use on your opt-in forms.
- Pick which opt-in form plugin or service you want to use on your website.
- Set up your opt-in form plugin and connect it to your email service provider (ESP).
- Place your opt-in forms on your website and verify that they are working.
- Set up a split-test to try to improve your opt-in rates.

CASE STUDY #2

SignWell

SignWell (signwell.com) is a “software as a service” (SaaS) company founded by Ruben Gamez that helps businesses get their documents electronically signed. SignWell focuses on making electronic signatures easy and convenient, cutting down on turnaround time. It’s currently used by over 61,000 (paid and free) users for legally compliant electronic signatures. SignWell is also SOC 2 Type 2 and HIPAA compliant.

With hundreds of thousands of monthly visitors to its website, email marketing is an important tool for SignWell to turn many of those leads into customers. While SignWell leverages its freemium offering for distribution and signups through its viral loop (document signers convert to become document senders), contract templates are used to attract important leads. These leads are drafting agreements that will eventually need to be signed. Free contract templates serve as lead magnets that indirectly attract the right type of visitors that eventually sign up to SignWell.

In addition to getting a free template, many people opt-in to a 30-day drip campaign focused on avoiding pitfalls and mistakes in legal agreements. These educational emails include information on how SignWell can make document signing easier and more convenient, along with calls-to-action to try the tool for free.

This strategy is similar to a strategy that Gamez previously used to attract email subscribers for another SaaS product that he owns, Bidsketch. Bidsketch ([Bidsketch.com](https://bidsketch.com)) makes it easy for businesses to create client proposals in minutes.

While both SaaS products use templates as a primary distribution strategy, Gamez was surprised to learn that less than 5% of visitors were opting into SignWell’s drip campaign. Using a combination of exit intent surveys, HotJar surveys, and even phone calls with anonymous visitors, he was able to figure out what was holding back visitors from opting in. This information was used to increase the opt-in conversion rates to over 20%.

Phone calls with anonymous visitors were key. Gamez said during an interview that “People think that you only get on the phone with leads or customers. The truth is, even if you’re not going to immediately see direct ROI from a phone call with someone, it pays long term to do whatever it takes to get an important lead funnel working. In this case, nothing we tried worked, so that meant I had to talk to some of these anonymous visitors to find out what was happening.”

Using this free template strategy, SignWell attracts 15,000 new email subscribers each month as of June 2022. Gamez says that he can attribute 20% of the company's customers directly to email marketing. He closed by saying, "Email marketing has always been an important tool in our acquisition strategy. What we have in place is just the start, there's a lot more we'll be testing and trying in the future."

CHAPTER THREE

16 Ways to Grow Your Mailing List Independently of Your Website

Building your mailing list through your website will allow you to steadily collect opt-ins and grow your list over time. If you want to accelerate how fast your list is growing, you can make use of some of these alternative strategies that work independently of the traffic your website normally receives.

While sign-ups through your website will happen automatically once plugins are set up, the strategies listed below will require either a financial investment or a steady investment of your time and energy. Do not let this scare you off. Paid acquisition strategies can be some of the most consistent and profitable ways of making money through email marketing. For example, let's say that you can make \$10.00 in revenue from each email subscriber on your mailing list. If you could acquire a new email sign-up for \$2.00, you would buy as many of those leads as are available because it is better than any other investment you can make. If you put \$2.00 in the stock market, you will be lucky if you get a 10% return on that investment in one year, and it turns into \$2.20. If you pay \$2.00 to acquire an email address and can make \$10.00 off it over the course of the following year, that is a return on investment of 500%. If you have a well-honed conversion funnel, spending money to acquire email sign-ups can be one of the most profitable investments you can make.

Try Co-Registration Advertising

Co-registration advertising networks allow you to advertise on other websites' "thank you" pages. After someone signs up for a mailing list on a website that is running a co-registration ad unit, they will be presented a list of offers from third-party advertisers (like you). If the subscriber selects your offer and presses the submit button, the advertising network will provide you the subscriber's contact information to add to your mailing list through an API call or by periodically sending you a spreadsheet of new sign-ups. You can expect to pay \$0.50-\$3.00 per sign-up through a co-registration ad network.

You can see an example of a co-registration ad unit below:



Thank you for joining MarketBeat Daily Ratings

To complete your subscription, please choose your free trading & investing guides from our trusted partners:

	☐ Yes	How to (Safely) Invest Like a Wall Street Pro It doesn't matter if you invest a thousand dollars ... or a million dollars. If you have access to the right strategies and tactics - and exclusive information from top investing experts - you can enjoy great wealth and freedom. Learn how here. Privacy Policy
	☐ Yes	FREE STOCK TRADING BLUEPRINT WINS UP TO 81% OF THE TIME FREE STOCK TRADING BLUEPRINT™ reveals a step-by-step method that wins up to 81% of the time using the little-known, "under the radar" technique that many traders don't even know exists (ADDITIONAL ACCESS) Privacy Policy
	☐ Yes	Exclusive Access to Energy's Most Profitable Opportunities 2015 will undoubtedly be the biggest year ever in the oil and energy markets. If you have access to the right strategies and tactics - and exclusive information from top investing experts - you can enjoy great wealth and freedom. Learn how here. Privacy Policy
	☐ Yes	Free Trading System for Trading Forex & Futures Think scalping is easy? Think again. This high-frequency, low-risk trading system keeps all the action but cuts the risk! Easy to learn, fun to trade. Full system sells for \$997 - but we're giving you 2 of our most profitable indicators ... FREE. Privacy Policy
	☐ Yes	Retirement News & Insights Sign up for Just One Thing newsletters from BlackRock and receive the latest insights and retirement research to consider in your own planning. Privacy Policy

[No Thanks](#) [SUBMIT & CONTINUE](#)

The quality of the sign-ups that you receive from co-registration advertising will vary depending on the sites that your ad is running on. When working with a co-registration ad network, I recommend asking for a list of sites that they have available for you to advertise on. Only agree to place your ads on websites that are similar to yours or are in the same industry. Subscribers that come from unrelated websites are less likely to be engaged with your content and will be less likely to purchase anything from you.

The quality of leads can also vary among multiple sites in the same industry. One site may send subscribers that connect well with your content, and another may send subscribers that are not engaged with your content and are of no value to you.

Given the ongoing cost of running a co-registration advertising campaign and the disparity of lead quality on a site-to-site basis, you will want to monitor performance on a per-ad-network and per-website basis every month. Are the subscribers that came from a particular website's co-registration ad unit as engaged as users that sign up through your website? Are they opening emails at the same rate as other subscribers?

Are they clicking on links? Are they buying products and services from you at the same rate as other subscribers? While running a co-registration advertising campaign can be incredibly profitable, you must monitor your campaign's performance regularly to weed out underperforming websites and ad networks.

Co-registration advertising is more prominently used in some industries than others. You will frequently see these units on financial websites, sports websites, travel websites, business opportunity websites, and disaster preparation websites. While you can run a co-registration advertising campaign for a website in just about any niche, it works better for some industries than others.

Here are some of the largest co-registration advertising networks:

- **After Offers**

After Offers (afteroffers.com) works with advertisers and publishers with travel websites, financial websites, Internet business websites, and survival/disaster preparation websites.

- **CoregMedia**

CoregMedia (coregmedia.com) is a general co-registration advertising network that works with publishers and advertisers in a large number of industries. CoregMedia advertises that it works with many major advertisers like Kohl's, Nokia, Gap, Dish Network, Red Lobster, and Wal-Mart.

- **Fluent**

Fluent (fluentco.com) is a lead-generation company that provides co-registration leads to a wide variety of industries. They primarily offer low-cost leads for products and services that would be relevant to a broad set of lower and middle income consumers.

- **Investing Media Solutions**

Investing Media Solutions (investingmediasolutions.com) works with advertisers and publishers that operate financial websites.

- **Opt-Intelligence**

Opt-Intelligence (opt-intelligence.com) is one of the largest co-registration advertising platforms online. Opt-Intelligence works with many major advertisers and publishers in a wide variety of industries.

- **Tiburon Media**

Tiburon Media (tiburonmedia.com/index.html) is a general co-registration advertising network that works with several major companies including Microsoft, Adobe, Cisco, Dell, Disney, and Toyota.

Lead Generation Services

Lead generation services, such as Fluent (fluentco.com) and Lead Pulse (leadpulsemedia.com), share many similarities with co-registration advertising services. They also allow you to pay a fixed fee to receive an email sign-up for your mailing list, but their leads tend to be much less expensive and much less targeted than leads that come from more traditional co-registration providers. You can purchase leads from these services for as little as \$0.40 per sign-up, but the email sign-up will come from a generic offer funnel or survey site rather than another website in your industry.

Lead generation providers tend to have much greater scale than co-registration advertising networks. They have much more inventory and often rely on paid ad-spend themselves to generate leads, which allows them to generate massive lead volume for their advertisers. If you wanted to, you could purchase 100,000 new subscribers per month or more through lead generation providers.

Adding thousands of email sign-ups from a lead generation service can negatively impact your deliverability because leads from these services are untargeted and a significant percentage of leads will never open any of your messages. To prevent this, you need to actively remove unengaged email subscribers from your mailing list. We remove anyone that signs-up for MarketBeat through a lead generation service that does not open an email within the first 21 days of their subscription. This keeps our email engagement rates where they need to be to keep email service providers such as Gmail, Outlook, and Yahoo happy.

You also need very good tracking and analytics tools to measure return on investment (ROI) from leads from these services to determine if you are running a profitable campaign. We do a cohort analysis to measure the ROI for all the subscribers that register from a given lead source in each month. Our goal is to break even on advertising spend from lead generation services in 90-days. If it's April and our leads from

January have broken even or shown a profitable ROI, we know that we are hitting our target performance goals.

It's also important to note that the quality of leads will vary significantly from one lead generation provider to another. MarketBeat has experimented with several lead generation services over the years with mixed results. We would often find that a campaign would be profitable for the first several months, only to become unprofitable after all the leads in the lead generation provider's database had seen our offer. As of the publication of the third edition of this book in 2022, MarketBeat is not currently utilizing any lead-generation services but will likely test them again in the future.

Lead generation services can be a very powerful tool given the ability to generate a massive volume of email sign-ups at an affordable price, but they can also be dangerous given the deliverability risks. Lead generation services are effectively the gasoline of email marketing. They can either add significant scale to your email marketing efforts or they can blow up in your face. If you have a clear understanding of your funnel and have learned a lot about deliverability, pursuing leads from lead generation providers can be a good idea. If you are just beginning to learn about email marketing, you should pursue other sign-up methods.

Swap Email Sends with Other Mailing List Owners

If you have built up a mailing list of a few thousand subscribers, swapping email sends with other mailing list owners can be an extremely effective way to grow your mailing list. When you do an email swap, you will send a marketing email to your subscribers on behalf of another website, and they will send an email that you write to *their* mailing list.

The email that you send to your email swap partner's list should attempt to get their subscribers to sign-up for your mailing list. Your email should offer their subscribers a lead magnet that they can opt-in to receive. It should describe what they will receive if they opt-in and have several links to your landing page where you collect email opt-ins. If you do not have a landing page dedicated to collecting email sign-ups on your website, create one now.

Note that you should never send your actual mailing list to your email swap partner, and they should never send their actual mailing list to you. Your swap partner will send out your email to their subscribers, and you will send out your swap partner's message to yours. Your mailing list should be treated like classified information. It should never be given to any third party under any circumstances. You do not know what kind of spam an unscrupulous partner might send to your list, so it is best to keep that information under tight wraps.

To find email swap partners, make a list of as many websites as you can that are similar to yours. Review your list and remove any websites

that do not have opt-in forms on them. It is unlikely that a website has a mailing list if they are not actively soliciting opt-ins. If possible, try to make a list of 50 different websites that you could potentially swap email sends with. Go through your list and send an introductory email to each website's owner that provides some background information about you and your website. Tell them that you are actively seeking for other websites to do email swaps with. Ask if they have a mailing list and if they would be interested in doing a swap with your list. Since email swaps are generally a no-lose proposition for both parties, you will find that many other webmasters are more than happy to do email swaps with you.

If you want to streamline the process of finding email swap partners, you can use a service called Safe Swaps (safe-swaps.com) to locate webmasters who are interested in doing email swaps with other mailing list owners. Safe Swaps is a paid service that costs \$29.95 per month to use.

Email List Rentals

If you have a sizable advertising budget to grow your mailing list, you can pay other mailing list owners to email their list on your behalf. Email list rentals work like email swaps. Instead of repaying the list owner by mailing your list on their behalf, you will pay them a negotiated fee for the privilege of their mailing list. Afterwards, you will create an email that contains an offer for a lead magnet and a link to sign up for your mailing list. The list owner then sends the promotional email to their mailing list on a set date and time for the agreed-upon fee.

Historically, email list rentals would be sold on a cost per thousand (CPM) basis. This means if you wanted to email 10,000 subscribers on someone else's mailing list and they charged a \$25.00 CPM, you would pay a \$250.00 fee. In more recent years, email list rentals have moved in a pay-per-performance direction where an advertiser pays the email list owner based on the number of clicks or the number of email sign-ups they receive from the promotion. For example, MarketBeat might pay another investing email list \$3.00 per click or \$10.00 per email sign-up to promote one of our lead magnets. Which of these two pricing methods is the best deal for us will vary depending on a variety of factors, including who the publisher is and what their audience interest is in our lead magnet.

Prices for email list rentals can vary depending on what industry or niche the mailing list is in. For example, emailing a list of investors will cost much more than emailing a list of computer gamers, because selling products to investors is much more profitable. For lower-end categories of mailing lists, you might be able to rent an email list for \$10.00-\$20.00 CPM. For high-end categories of mailing lists, you might pay \$50.00-\$100.00 CPM to email someone else's list.

In the Internet marketing space, you might see email list rentals referred to as “solo ads.” In other spaces, you might see email list rentals referred to as “dedicated email sends” or “advertising email blasts.” Do not let this throw you off. “Solo ads,” “advertising email blasts,” and “dedicated email sends” are just another name for email list rentals.

There are several online databases that advertise email lists available for rent. NextMark (nextmark.com) is probably the largest online database of email, phone, and snail mail mailing lists with more than 60,000 mailing lists available for rental. Unfortunately, their search tool is a bit antiquated, so you may have to comb through several pages of results to find a list that you want to email.

A wide range of quality exists among email list rental providers. Since you never actually see the provider’s subscriber list, there is no way to independently verify the size or quality of their mailing list. While many email list rental providers are professional and completely above board, there are some unscrupulous providers that try to pass off compiled lists, purchased lists, and unrelated mailing lists as a high-quality and relevant list available for rental. Because of the level of trust involved, you should only work with very reputable mailing list owners. If possible, consider using an agency that works with advertisers in your industry to do email list rentals. A good email advertising agency will already have relationships with mailing list owners in your industry and can mitigate the possibility of working with dishonest mailing list owners.

Do Not Buy a Mailing List

While renting an email list is a commonly accepted practice in the email marketing industry, buying an email list is not advisable. When renting a list, you are paying a list owner to email their list on your behalf. You are effectively borrowing the permission that their subscribers have given the list owner to email them. While there is nothing that’s necessarily illegal or immoral about purchasing a mailing list, generally it’s a bad idea because individuals on a purchased list have not opted in and have not given you permission to email them.

Using purchased email lists to get customers is usually not a very effective marketing strategy. Most email lists available for sale are low-quality, out-of-date, and are not maintained very well. People on these lists won’t find your content engaging and won’t want to receive your emails. More importantly, they are very unlikely to buy anything from you or respond to any of your offers.

Many email service providers (ESPs) will not let you use a purchased list with their services because of the damage that mailing a purchased list can do to the reputation of your domain name and IP address. Emailing purchased lists usually results in an unacceptably large

number of spam complaints and undeliverable emails. This runs the risk of your domain name and IP address being added to a blacklist, which causes your future mailings to end up in subscribers' spam folders or not be delivered at all. To maintain your reputation, your best bet is to only email people that have directly given you permission to do so.

Make Your Email Content Shareable

If you publish an email newsletter, place social media sharing buttons and a "forward to a friend" link in each of your newsletters. These buttons will encourage your current email subscribers to share and forward your email content to their friends and other people in their social networks, giving you new connections and access to potential new subscribers. You can also consider placing a call-to-action at the bottom of your newsletter with a link to subscribe, which will encourage anyone who received a forwarded copy of your newsletter to sign up for your mailing list. Most email service providers include tools to make your email content shareable, so it shouldn't require much work to add social sharing and "forward to a friend" links to your emails.

Archive Email Content on Your Website

Whenever you publish an email newsletter or another piece of informational or educational content, post a copy of that email into an archive of newsletter content on your website. If you are using WordPress, this might mean creating a new category for newsletter content and publishing any new newsletter content as a post in that category. Whenever you add a new email newsletter to the archive, share it on all of your available social media channels. This will broaden the reach of your email content and make it visible to followers not already on your email list. It will also provide a second way for your subscribers to see your new content if they happen to miss your email. Google and other search engines will also index the archive of newsletter content on your website, which may also increase the quantity of organic search traffic that you receive.

Own a Physical Store?

If you own a physical store or have any other kind of retail location, ask every customer if they want to sign up for your email list at checkout. You can ask each customer something like, "Would you like to sign up for our mailing list and periodically get coupons in your email?" If the customer says yes, have them write down their email address on a sign-up sheet on a clipboard. At the end of each day, add these customers to your mailing list. Some modern point-of-sale systems will streamline this process by asking your customers if they want to sign-up for your email list at checkout and then sending the customer's email address on to your email service provider.

Leverage Your Email Signature

Adjust your and your employees' email signatures so they contain a call-to-action and a link to sign up for your mailing list.

Here's a simple email signature with a call-to-action that I have used in the past:

Matthew Paulson

To: subscriber@marketbeat.com

Subject: Signature Example

—

Matthew Paulson

Founder and CEO, MarketBeat

Want the latest news and updates about MarketBeat?

Sign-Up for Our Newsletter Here

Run a Contest or Giveaway

Find something of high-perceived value that you can use as a giveaway or a contest prize, like an iPad or an iPhone. Require everyone participating in the contest to sign up for your mailing list to enter the contest. Promote the contest through your personal and company social media channels, as well as any other marketing channels you might have available. Remember to add social sharing buttons to the contest page on your website, so it is easily shareable.

Social Media Offers

Develop a high-value lead magnet or another offer, such as an eBook or free report, and share it on all your available social media channels. Require that users enter their email address to access the lead magnet or other offered item.

Make sure you use every social media channel you have available, including Facebook, Twitter, LinkedIn, Instagram, Pinterest, Tumblr, and other social media profiles that you have set up. Share the offer through both your personal social media accounts and any profiles for your business. Share the offer multiple times over the course of a few weeks for maximum exposure.

YouTube Calls to Action

If you or your company have a YouTube channel, add calls-to-action in the description of your videos to subscribe to your mailing list. Include hyperlinks in video description that direct viewers to a landing page on

your website where users can opt-in to your mailing list or respond to another offer.

You can also create a short and memorable URL that you can share at the end of your videos. At the end of each of your video, you could say something along the lines of “If you would like to get more news and updates from MarketBeat, sign-up for our email list at marketbeat.com/ratings/newsletter.”

Set Up Google AdWords

If you have money to invest in your list-building campaign, you can use Google AdWords to drive traffic to a landing page, where users can enter their email address in exchange for a lead magnet or another offer. Make sure you use the conversion tracking pixel that Google provides to identify which keywords and ads are driving the most opt-ins.

After your campaign has been running a while, you can use Google’s cost-per-action (CPA) bidding to optimize for email sign-ups. AdWords also has an extension that allows advertisers to place an opt-in form directly in search results, but that feature is currently only available to a select group of publishers. While creating a Google AdWords campaign is beyond the scope of this book, I recommend reading *Ultimate Guide to Google AdWords* by Perry Marshall and Mike Rhodes if you want to learn how to create a Google AdWords campaign.

For many years, MarketBeat did not have an active Google AdWords campaign because the cost per lead was significantly higher than other paid acquisition sources. In the past year, we found success with Google AdWords by hiring a media buyer with relevant industry experience who helped us create an effective lead magnet and landing page, and also run our AdWords campaign. You can view an example of our AdWords landing pages at marketbeat.com/newsletter/pdfoffer.aspx.

Presenting at a Trade Show?

If your organization is presenting at a trade show, you have a prime opportunity to gather new email sign-ups. Run a giveaway and offer a highly desirable prize. Consumer electronics such as iPads, Kindles, and video game systems work great as prizes. Allow attendees to enter your drawing by dropping their business card into a fishbowl. You will need to make it clear that contest participants are signing up for your mailing list.

At the end of the conference, pick a winner and then add all participants to your mailing list. Send a welcome email to every new mailing list member. Your welcome email should remind them about the contest, why they have been added to your mailing list, and provide information about your products and services. You should also include an opt-out link in your welcome email so that anyone who doesn’t want to receive email from you can easily unsubscribe.

Many trade shows give you the opportunity to either scan attendee badges or outright purchase the event's attendee list. While I generally advise against purchasing email lists, buying a conference attendee list can be an effective marketing strategy. You should not immediately add attendees to your main mailing list, but you can send them a few emails inviting them to opt-in to your mailing list, perhaps in exchange for a lead magnet.

Put QR Codes in Your Print Marketing Material

If your business makes use of print marketing material, add a QR code that users can easily scan with their phones. Use the code to redirect users to a mobile-friendly landing page on your website where you can ask them to opt-in to your mailing list. You can easily create a QR code using any number of websites that offer free generators, such as qr-code-generator.com. Also include a short URL that redirects to your mobile-friendly landing page directly below the QR code. Not everyone has a QR code scanner on their phone, and it may be easier for them to simply type a URL into their smartphone's web browser or write it down for later use.

Add a Facebook Page Call-To-Action

If your organization has a Facebook business page set up, you can add a call-to-action button on the header of your Facebook page to attract email sign-ups. To create a call-to-action button on your organization's Facebook page, navigate to your page, and click the "Create Call to Action" button in the header of your page. You can choose between a number of button texts including "book now," "contact us," "use app," "play game," "shop now," "sign up," and "watch video." I personally recommend using "sign up" because it's simple and it tends to convert well. You will also be asked to provide the URL where users can then add themselves to your mailing list. The URL should be a landing page that introduces your mailing list and a form so users can easily sign up.

How to Create a Landing Page to Collect Opt-Ins

Throughout this chapter, there are several strategies that discuss sending traffic to a landing page to collect email addresses. A landing page is a single purpose webpage that exists solely to persuade users to take a specific action, such as completing an opt-in form or purchasing a product. While the process of building a landing page is beyond the scope of this book, I do want to provide a couple of basic tips and point you to some resources that can help you create landing pages for your business.

Don't try to create a landing page using raw HTML or have a landing page created by a professional web designer. There are several great tools available including LeadPages (leadpages.com), Unbounce (unbounce.com), and Click Funnels (clickfunnels.com) that make creating landing pages simple. Most of them have drag-and-drop

interfaces which allow you to put a great landing page together in a short amount of time. These services will also integrate with your email service provider (ESP) so your sign-up form works without any coding on your part.

Remember that the only thing on your landing page should be your opt-in form. That means no sidebars, navigation, or any other extraneous content. It should have a title, a bit of sales and marketing content, maybe a video, and your actual opt-in form. Always keep the focus on the single action you want your subscribers to take. When you add additional content to your landing pages, users are more likely to be distracted and are less likely to take the indicated action.

For more tips and recommendations about how to put a landing page together, Unbounce has compiled a resource titled “101 Landing Page Optimization Tips”¹⁴ which provides detailed instructions on how to create landing pages that work. This resource can be accessed at unbounce.com/101-landing-page-optimization-tips.

The Importance of Continually Growing Your List

Even if you have a large mailing list with tens of thousands of subscribers, you should continuously work on growing your email list. A small percentage of your users will unsubscribe from your mailing list every month because they lose interest in the topic area you write about, or they simply no longer want to receive your emails. There will also be some subscribers whose email addresses are no longer valid, because they switched ISPs or moved to a new email address.

You will need to continually attract new subscribers to your mailing list to replace those that drop off over time. Additionally, users tend to be most engaged with the content of a mailing list when they first subscribe. Over time, their open rates and engagement rates will naturally decline. Keep gathering new subscribers to ensure there is always a percentage of your subscribers that are highly engaged with your content.

Wrap-Up

While the bulk of your email opt-ins will likely come from your website, there are many other ways to grow your mailing list independently of your website. Not every strategy listed in this chapter will be appropriate for every organization, so take time to consider which of the 16 strategies presented in this chapter you can use to grow *your* mailing list.

Whether you want to leverage social media, do paid advertising campaigns, or run a contest, there are always more ways to accelerate your list growth beyond getting opt-ins on your website.

Action Steps:

- Make a list of 50 potential partners that you can do email swaps with.
- Leverage your social media profiles to build your mailing list and promote your existing email content.
- Determine whether paid list-building strategies including co-registration advertising, Google AdWords, and email list rentals are appropriate for your mailing list.
- Add social sharing and “forward to a friend” buttons to your email content.
- Make a shareable archive of past email content on your website.
- Consider what other ways you can grow your list independently of opt-ins from your website.

CASE STUDY #3

GMB Fitness

GMB Fitness (gmb.io), founded by Andy Fossett, is a website that offers home-based training programs that combine gymnastic and martial arts exercise movements for fitness enthusiasts at all levels of strength and experience. I had the opportunity to interview Fossett as part of this book. The company began by offering DVDs, but quickly transitioned to offering video training courses and membership programs. Their content teaches what they call “physical autonomy” and is delivered through a variety of exercise tutorials and online coaching.

GMB Fitness uses email as one of their primary marketing channels. Fossett said that email marketing is the single most important part of their business after the video content they produce. They have developed a variety of different opt-in forms and related autoresponder sequences based on specific goals, such as handstands and stretching. They also have a general autoresponder series that teaches their philosophy of exercise and publishes a weekly newsletter to subscribers that have completed their autoresponder series. They have also created onboarding sequences that help new customers engage with their website and the products they purchase.

Fossett told me email is also an invaluable communication tool between his company and its audience. He commented, “It gives us a chance to help them and increases their trust in us, which increases the likelihood of a beneficial long-term relationship. We also get feedback and intelligence that helps us know what our audience wants to buy and what they think of our current products. We can use that to improve our programs and marketing.”

In order to attract opt-ins to their website, GMB Fitness uses a variety of mini-programs that teach about specific fitness topics their audience is interested in. Their free subscribers receive access to a “members area” that contains about a dozen free video resources that are tightly coupled with their paid products.

Fossett informed me that the most effective opt-ins scratch a specific itch. For example, their customers couldn’t care less about content that teaches them how to stretch properly. However, if they package stretching instruction videos around an ailment that stretching solves, such as painful mobility, readers will sign up for those opt-ins in much greater numbers.

As GMB Fitness has gained a reputation for producing great content, they have had the opportunity to publish guest posts on major fitness sites, which have generated a lot of opt-ins. Fossett said, “We had a series

of five posts on artofmanliness.com that drove a couple thousand subscribers. We've since had a couple of large websites feature us for a series on a tight theme, and each has performed well."

When I asked Fossett why he thinks his business does so well, he said there are no secrets. If anything, the only secret is to "work your butt off making great content for several years." Fossett and his team have worked hard to build a professional, graphically appealing website that contains great content. He commented, "We make it very clear that we are experts with quality materials, so the other stuff works easily. Without the foundation, all the best tactics can fail."

One piece of advice Fossett has to offer is: pay attention to what your messages look like on mobile devices. A study from Movable Ink finds that as many as 66% of all emails opened are done on a smartphone or tablet.¹⁵ He said, "If your emails don't look good on an iPhone, you're missing out. You need to make sure that your messages are easy to read and click on using mobile devices." He added that there are simply no excuses for sending emails that don't render correctly on mobile, because nearly all major ESPs include mobile preview tools.

Another tip that Fossett gave was to consider re-sending an email to subscribers that don't open it. He said, "A few days after you send an email, create a segment of people who did not open it. Then change the subject line and send it to those people again. It's a simple way to get a 10+% increase in people seeing and clicking your messages."

Fossett also reiterated the importance of testing. He advised that you should test multiple subject lines, multiple from-addresses, and multiple calls-to-action to see what works best. He also suggested testing the frequency of your autoresponder series by creating two different versions of an autoresponder series with the same messages sent at different sending frequencies to see which generates the most engagement and sales.

GMB Fitness has grown a mailing list of nearly 60,000 subscribers. Fossett informed me they are adding 1,000 new subscribers each week and hope to hit 100,000 subscribers within the next year.

The most impressive part of GMB's email statistics are its engagement numbers. He says it isn't uncommon for them to have 60% of their recipients open any one email. Nearly 80% of his company's sales come from people that are on at least one of their email lists.

He closed by saying, "The main point is that email is a great tool that can generate lots of sales and subscriptions if you use it effectively. It's a tool that reaches almost 100% of the people online, and it's relatively inexpensive to use, so the ROI on learning to leverage email effectively is probably higher than any other form of promotion."

CHAPTER FOUR

Mailing Your List: How, What, and When to Send to Your Audience

As your mailing list grows, you will be faced with the challenge of regularly sending educational and marketing content to your mailing list. You will need to decide how often you want to email your list, what types of email you want to send, and whether you want to leverage advanced strategies like marketing automation and list segmentation. You will need to create a series of welcome emails in an autoresponder series that will help new subscribers get engaged with your content. You will also need to create a schedule of mailings so subscribers that have completed your autoresponder series continue to receive email from you on a regular basis.

The First Email Your Subscribers Receive

The first email that every new subscriber will receive from your mailing list is called the welcome email. Sending a well-written welcome email to each of your subscribers is the first step in nurturing long-term subscribers that will always be happy to receive your email. This email should accomplish several different tasks, including thanking subscribers for joining your mailing list, setting expectations for the type and quantity of email they are going to receive, getting your subscribers to whitelist your email address, and encouraging them to take further action.

At the top of your welcome email, include a personal message that thanks the subscriber for signing up for your mailing list. If appropriate for your industry, use personal language as if you were writing to a new friend that you just met for coffee. Next, you should tell your subscribers what kind of email they are going to receive and how often they are going to receive it. This will help your subscribers set a mental expectation for what kind of emails they should expect.

You should also ask your email subscribers to whitelist your email address or add you to their safe sender list so that your messages never go to their spam folder. Feel free to copy MarketBeat's whitelist instructions page located at marketbeat.com/safe-sender. Finally, you should consider what action you want your users to take next. You might want them to read a particular piece of content on your website, persuade them to check out one of your products, or ask that they recommend your mailing list to a friend of theirs. Include a hyperlink with a clear call-to-action at the bottom of your email and thank them again for joining your list.

Here is the copy for the actual welcome email currently being used by MarketBeat:

Matthew Paulson

To: subscriber@marketbeat.com

Subject: Welcome to MarketBeat Daily

Hi there –

Thank you for subscribing to MarketBeat Daily!

With your free subscription, you will receive a concise daily summary of analysts' upgrades, downgrades, and new coverage (delivered at approximately 1:00 PM ET).

In the meantime, be sure to add MarketBeat.com to your safe sender list or address book to ensure your newsletter gets delivered to your inbox. [Click Here to Learn How.](#)

You might also be interested in our premium email newsletter, MarketBeat Daily Premium, which provides instant email and SMS alerts for stocks that interest you, additional ratings data, and delivery before the market opens.

[Click Here to Learn More About MarketBeat Daily Premium.](#)

Thanks!

Matthew Paulson

MarketBeat

Creating an Autoresponder Series

An autoresponder series, sometimes referred to as a welcome series, is a series of pre-written emails that every new subscriber receives in sequential order after signing up for your mailing list. A new subscriber might receive your welcome email on the first day of their subscription, another email on the third day of their subscription, another on the fifth day of their subscription, etc. The purpose of an autoresponder series is to send a consistent set of messages to every new subscriber, so they can become familiar with your writing and your company's products and services.

There are seven different ways that you can use the emails in your autoresponder series:

- Promoting your company's products and services
- Providing additional educational content to your subscribers
- Cross-promoting your social media channels and SMS distribution list
- Asking them to add your email address to their safe sender list
- Promoting another company's products as an affiliate

- Highlighting existing content on your website to your new subscribers
- Asking subscribers for feedback about your content and your company's products

Creating an autoresponder series is more of an art than a science. There is no perfect length for a series, and there is no perfect number of emails to include. You will be able to track the performance of any one message, but it's difficult to split-test an entire autoresponder series. I recommend sending out messages anywhere from two to four days apart in your autoresponder series and having a total length between two and four months. This may mean that you are including as many as 30 emails in your autoresponder series, but it doesn't have to be a daunting task if you simply write a new email every few days as your oldest subscribers near the end of the series.

Every major email service provider (ESP) includes the ability to create a series of autoresponder messages that new subscribers will receive automatically over time on the dates that you specify. Typically, you will simply need to enter the subject line and body of your email into a form provided by your ESP. You will also need to specify when a new subscriber will receive a particular email, such as on the 10th day of their subscription. Some email service providers will also let you push an email to the next day when an autoresponder message is scheduled to go out on a weekend or holiday when someone is unlikely to check their email.

If you want to see how an autoresponder series works in practice, consider creating a new email account and using it for the sole purpose of watching autoresponder emails come in from lists that you have signed up for. Use the single-purpose email account that you created to sign up for mailing lists of some of your competitors and well-known marketers to get ideas for your autoresponder series.

You can see all the autoresponder emails sent out by MarketBeat just by completing an opt-in form on the MarketBeat website. Pat Flynn (smartpassiveincome.com) also has a particularly good autoresponder series that's worth checking out.

Here's a sample layout of what the first 30 days of an autoresponder series might look like:

- Day 1: Send your welcome email.
- Day 2: Highlight some of your website's "best-of" content.
- Day 4: Introduce your company's products and services.
- Day 6: Ask subscribers to add your email address to their safe sender list.

- Day 8: Provide a piece of educational content or training material.
- Day 10: Invite your subscribers to sign-up for your SMS list (or social media accounts if you do not have an SMS list).
- Day 12: Promote one of your company's products or services.
- Day 14: Ask subscribers for feedback about your content.
- Day 16: Promote another company's products as an affiliate
- Day 18: Invite your subscribers to follow you on social media.
- Day 20: Provide more educational content or training material.
- Day 22: Promote one of your company's products or services.
- Day 24: Provide links to helpful stories and resources around the web.
- Day 26: Reintroduce some older content on your website to your new subscribers.
- Day 28: Promote another company's products as an affiliate.
- Day 30: Offer a one-time discount on your company's products and services.

The biggest mistake that you can make with your autoresponder series is not having one at all. If you don't regularly email your list, they will become disengaged with your content and will forget that they gave you permission to email them in the first place. If you try to email a mailing list that you haven't contacted in six months, invariably some subscribers will forget who you are and accuse you of spamming them. Sending regular emails every few days for the first several months of a user's subscription is arguably the best way to keep them engaged with your content and interested in your company's products and services.

Broadcast Emails

In addition to your autoresponder series, you will want to regularly send messages to your entire email list. These messages are known as broadcast emails because you are broadcasting a single message to your list.

Broadcast emails are one-time messages that get sent to your entire mailing list at a specific date and time for a specific purpose. They typically do not get re-sent to your email list, because your entire audience has already been exposed to that message. Broadcast emails are often used to make an announcement, encourage subscribers to engage with a piece of content, or encourage subscribers to buy a specific product. They are also arguably the most critical component of keeping email subscribers engaged over time.

Broadcast emails serve three primary purposes. First, they keep users who have completed your autoresponder series engaged with your content. By regularly sending new educational and informational content to your mailing list, they will continue to receive value from you, will be more likely to stay engaged with your content, and will be less likely to

unsubscribe. Second, sending broadcast emails is the best way to make announcements to your list and keep them informed about what's going on with your business. Finally, sending broadcast emails to promote products and services will be one of your key monetization points. You can use broadcast emails to promote your company's products and services, or you can use them to promote another company's products and services as an affiliate.

Planning Your Broadcast Email Calendar

You will want to develop a schedule of the emails that you plan to send to your mailing list each month prior to the first day of that month. By creating a plan ahead of time, you can space out your emails appropriately throughout the month and can create a good rhythm of educational and content emails, followed by sales and marketing emails. If you send too many sales emails in a row or don't take a day off from mailing your list for several days, you may upset some of your subscribers and cause them to unsubscribe from your list.

I recommend printing out a calendar from the web and physically writing down the emails that you want to send out. You don't need to write out the *entire* email you plan on sending—just the broad category of the message, such as “newsletter,” “marketing email,” “product launch announcement,” “tip/resource,” or “content promotion.” By putting your broadcast email schedule on paper, you'll be able to visually see if your messages are spread out equally and aren't too focused on any single type of email.

Creating your broadcast email calendar is also more of an art than a science. There is no ideal number of emails you should send at any given month. There is no perfect frequency that suggests you should email every day, every other day, or every third day. There are no hard rules that suggest you should send at least one educational email for every sales email that you send out. The most important thing is to consistently send relevant email content to your subscribers to keep them engaged with your mailing list.

The frequency at which you send broadcast emails will be somewhat dependent upon the niche of your mailing list. For niches that have highly committed and highly engaged fans, you will want to email more frequently. Sports fans, investors, and news junkies may want to receive email from you daily because the information in those niches is constantly changing. Niches with hobbyists and casual fans probably won't want to receive email from you daily. The general rule of thumb that I use for mailing frequency is that you should never mail your list any less than once per week, and you should almost never mail your list any more than once per day.

Writing a Broadcast Series

If you are launching a new product or running a promotion to generate sales for an existing product, you will want to send a series of emails over the course of several days. When you only send one email about a product or service that you want to promote, your subscribers might miss the email altogether or might simply not have enough information to make a purchasing decision. By sending a series of emails over a few days or even a couple of weeks, you are keeping the product or service fresh in their minds. You can also use different selling techniques in the variety of messages you send to your list.

Here is an example layout of how a series of emails can work:

- **Announcement Email (Day 1)**

Your first email should serve as an official announcement for the availability of your new product or for the promotion that you're running. Describe what the product does and how it can help your subscribers. If you are running a sale, you should include the discounted pricing information as well as how long the sale will be available.

- **FAQ Email (Day 3)**

The goal of the second email is to provide as much information as possible about the product or promotion to your subscribers. Think of all the major questions a subscriber might ask about your product or the promotion and answer them in an email. This email can be 1,000 words in length or longer. People that are really interested in your product will take the time to read all of it.

- **Video Tour Email (Day 5)**

Record a YouTube video that shows how your product or service works. If it's a software program or digital information product that you're selling, do a screencast that shows it off. Your email should be little more than a link to watch your video and a link to purchase the product if the subscriber is interested. The video that you record will help visual learners connect with your product more than they might have otherwise.

- **Features and Benefits Email (Day 7)**

In this email, you will remind your subscribers what your product does and how it can help them. Write about the specific problems that your product can solve for them. Include a list of all the major features of the products and how it can benefit them.

- **Social Proof Email (Day 9)**

Collect a few testimonials from your existing customers and send them out to demonstrate social proof. Subscribers will be more likely to buy your product if they know that other people like them have already purchased your product and gotten value out of it.

- **Warning Email (Day 11)**

In the second-to-last day of your campaign, you should try to create a sense of urgency and warn subscribers that tomorrow will be the last day whatever discount or bonus you are offering will be available. You can also use this email as another opportunity to remind your subscribers of the features and benefits in your product or service.

- **Last Chance Email (Day 12)**

On the last day of your campaign, you should tell your subscribers that it's their last opportunity to take advantage of the discount or bonus you are offering. Be clear that the price will be increasing, or the bonus will be going away after tonight and that they should act now if they want to take advantage of the offer. This email is generally very short and contains little other than the "last chance" warning and a link to your sales page.

- **Second Last Chance Email (Day 12)**

We often send out a second, third and even a fourth email in the afternoon or evening of the last day of an email campaign. These messages all contain a variation of the "today is the final day of the sale" messaging and other copy we have used in our campaign. In our 2021 New Year's campaign, we generated 91 sales from the first email on the last day of the campaign and 247 sales from the second, third and fourth emails we sent that day. If you only send one email on the last day of your campaign, you are leaving money on the table.

A Sample Email Series from MarketBeat

To provide a better idea of what an actual broadcast email series can look like, I've made the copy that MarketBeat used for an entire email launch available online for free for readers of *Email Marketing Demystified*.

The email series linked below was for our New Year's Eve sale at the end of 2021. The campaign was sent to approximately 2 million subscribers and generated approximately 400 sales of our premium subscription at \$199/year per subscriber. To access the free sample broadcast series, visit mattpaulson.com/sample-campaign.

Tracking Your Results

Some of the broadcast emails that you send your audience will be much more effective than others. It may not be immediately apparent why one email receives better engagement than others, because only by consistently looking at your numbers over time can you begin to identify commonalities between emails that work and those that don't.

Here are the numbers that you should track in every email:

- **Sends**

This is the number of people that your email was sent to. Your number of sends should equal the total size of your mailing list.

- **Bounces**

This is the number of messages that were returned as undeliverable. If your bounce rate is higher than 2%, you may need to clean up the mailing list or your domain name, or your mailing IP address may have been blacklisted.

- **Opens**

This is the number of times your email was opened by subscribers. Note that open rates are much less reliable than they used to be because some email clients block tracking images and others (such as Apple Mail) open tracking images regardless of the email was opened or not.

- **Open Rate**

This is the percentage of subscribers that opened an email, out of everyone who received the message. Open rates can vary dramatically based on your industry and the engagement of your mailing list. For well-maintained lists, open rates tend to range from 15% to 35%.

- **Clicks**

This is the total number of subscribers that clicked on a link in your message.

- **Clickthrough Rate**

This is the percentage of people that opened your email, out of everyone that got messaged, and clicked on a link. A good marketing email will have a clickthrough rate of between 5% and 10%.

- **Unsubscribes**

This is the number of people that unsubscribed from your list by clicking on the unsubscribe link in any given email. Seeing a higher-than-usual number of unsubscribes can indicate a message didn't engage well with your mailing list.

There are additional metrics that you should track in sales and marketing emails:

- **Conversions**

This is the number of sales or other sign-ups that occurred because of an email.

- **Conversion Rate**

This is the percentage of people that clicked on a link in your email that purchased a product or service because of the email.

- **Revenue**

This is how much money you made in sales from people clicking through. At the end of the day, the revenue that your email generates is the metric that matters the most.

Whenever you send out an email to your mailing list, go back and review how the message performed 72 hours after it was sent. By this time, most of the people that are ever going to read your email will have done so. Compare the open rates, clickthrough rates, and conversion rates to previous emails. Were the numbers significantly higher or lower? If so, try to identify how your current email is different from any previous messages you sent. Ask yourself what you can learn based on the performance of your most recent email.

Is Open Tracking Dead?

For the last two decades, marketers have relied on open rates as one of the primary metrics to determine if an email marketing campaign is successful. In late 2021, Apple implemented a new technology called Mail Privacy Protection (MPP) which made email open tracking unreliable for iPhone, iPad, and macOS users that use the Apple mail app. MPP was first introduced as part of iOS 15 as a means of protecting user privacy from unwanted tracking pixels, sometimes referred to as “spy pixels.”

MPP downloads all images in an email, including tracking pixels, using a third-party server to prevent email senders from knowing when a recipient has opened their message. This means that every email sent to an email account using Apple Mail with MPP enabled will be marked as opened, regardless of whether the user opened the email. MPP also obfuscates location data, making it more difficult for marketers to segment users based on geography.

There are approximately 900 million active iPhone users as of mid-2022, most of which will have MPP technology enabled on their email client. You should expect that 20% to 40% of your email list, depending on your niche and your audience, will have MPP enabled. Being unable to accurately track open rates for 20% to 40% of an email list will have profound implications, both for measuring the performance of an email campaign and for measuring the engagement of your users.

Many email service providers are blocking email opens triggered by MPP as to not artificially inflate open rate data. They are also encouraging marketers to switch to other metrics to track email performance and user engagement. Clicks, conversions, and revenue are the metrics that marketers should use to track email campaign performance in 2022 beyond. Clicks are arguably a better metric to track than opens, because a click indicated that a user opened your email, read it, and was interested enough in the email to click on your link and learn more. Open rates just tell you how many people opened your message,

not how many people were interested in the content of your email. Conversions are ultimately the best metric to determine whether an email campaign worked, because your conversion data will tell you whether you made money from an email or if you didn't.

MPP also has profound implications for email list hygiene. Historically marketers would automatically unsubscribe users that haven't opened an email within a certain period, often 6 or 12 months. Removing inactive users improves your engagement metrics making it more likely that email providers will deliver your messages to your subscribers' inboxes and not the spam folder. MPP makes it more difficult, but not impossible, to determine which of your users are active and which are not. Email list hygiene in a post-MPP world is covered in detail in chapter seven of this book.

Some email marketing experts, especially those that sell expensive courses and consulting services, have sowed fear, uncertainty, and doubt about the future of email in a world where open counts and location data can no longer be accurately tracked. Don't buy into the fear. Open rate data is still available for non-Apple Mail users. Location data can still be tracked on clickthrough. Email performance and user engagement can be tracked through other metrics. While marketers certainly need to adapt to MPP, it is far from a death knell for email marketing.

Create a Weekly or Bi-Weekly Newsletter

One of the best ways to keep your mailing list engaged with your content over time is to publish a weekly or bi-weekly newsletter containing content that is interesting to your readers. By consistently sending a newsletter on a specific day of the week, your subscribers will begin to expect and look forward to your weekly newsletter. They will get in a habit of reading it on a specific day of the week and are more likely to be engaged with your content over time.

Your newsletter should contain five to ten stories or news items that users can scan through and click on to learn more if they are interested. This doesn't mean that you need to write five to ten original articles for your newsletter, though. In fact, you don't need to create any new content for your newsletter at all. You can simply repurpose content that you have recently published to your website for your newsletter. If you aren't creating original content, you can simply act as a curator and link to interesting stories that your subscribers will be interested in.

For example, Hiten Shah publishes a weekly newsletter for software entrepreneurs called SaaS Weekly (hiten.com), which contains a round-up of stories that are interesting to software entrepreneurs. He doesn't publish any original content in his newsletter but has built a following of more than ten thousand subscribers based on his ability to find interesting stories to share with other software entrepreneurs.

HubSpot has put together an article titled “18 Email Newsletter Examples We Love Getting in Our Inboxes”¹⁶ that shows off several particularly high-quality newsletters. If you need ideas about how to create a newsletter, this is a great place to start.

Marketing Automation for Email

If your company or organization sells several different products or has customers with multiple divergent interest areas, you might consider using marketing automation techniques, so customers only receive email content that is relevant to them.

Email marketing automation is the process of sending targeted email content to a certain set of subscribers who have taken a specific action or expressed a specific interest. In other words, email marketing automation is simply sending the right email to the right person at the right time. By sending more targeted and relevant content to your subscribers based on their interests and actions, they are more likely to stay engaged with your mailing list and buy products and services from your company.

For example, if a customer signs up for a 30-day free trial of a product, they should receive an email campaign that teaches them how to use that product and sells them on continuing with the product after their 30-day trial is completed. Obviously, only users that sign up for a free trial of that product should receive those emails, because they would be irrelevant to anyone else. When you send an irrelevant email to people, they will be confused as to the purpose of the message and will likely become disengaged with your content.

There is a lot of upfront work involved with creating marketing automation campaigns. Most email service providers will do the heavy technical lifting for you, but you will need to write an entire series of emails for each campaign that you create and will have to figure out how to trigger a campaign for a specific person when they take an action.

If your mailing list is in a very specific niche and you generally only send out content about one or two topics, marketing automation may not be necessary. If your company doesn’t sell any products or only sells one or two products or services, email marketing automation might be overkill. Marketing automation can be an incredibly effective tool, but it may not be worth the effort for smaller and more focused lists.

Here are some types of email marketing automation campaigns that can be very effective:

- **Welcome Series**

You may not realize it, but your initial welcome series (or autoresponder series) is a form of marketing automation. Sending a

welcome series to new subscribers to your list is a great way to get them up to speed about your content and your company's products and services.

- **Product Education Emails**

Whenever a new customer buys a product or service from your company, send them a series of emails that teaches them how to use it. This will increase the likelihood that they will use and get value from your product. By increasing the percentage of your customers that use your product, you are less likely to get refund requests, and customers are more likely to buy from you again in the future.

- **Order Confirmation Emails**

Whenever someone buys a product or service from your company, send an email thanking them for their order along with their order details. You should also provide a call-to-action in this email that will try to get users to return to your website to re-engage with your content or to view related products.

- **Subscriber Re-Engagement Emails**

When a subscriber hasn't opened an email from you or visited your website in a couple of months, send them some highly valuable content to try to get them re-engaged with your content. You can also send an email asking for feedback to see if there's something you can add or change that might engage them more.

- **Anniversary Emails**

Send subscribers a virtual anniversary card after they have been on your mailing list for either six months or one year. You can also include a time-limited coupon for your company's products or services to encourage them to take action and become a customer.

- **Free Trial Emails**

If you offer a service that has a free trial, you should send anyone currently in a trial some information about the product they are

using, as well as sales and marketing emails to persuade them to upgrade to a paid subscription.

- **Former Customer Email**

If you run a subscription or a recurring service business, consider creating a campaign that reminds former customers about the features and benefits of your service and allows them to re-register at a discounted rate. These emails work extremely well if written correctly and can prevent you from losing customers forever.

- **Cart Abandonment Emails**

If a customer adds a product to their shopping cart on an ecommerce website but doesn't complete the purchase, send them information about the products in their shopping cart over the next several days. This can be a very effective way to save lost sales.

- **Upsell Emails**

If you have a multi-tiered pricing plan, send an email to customers asking them to upgrade to the next level or service whenever they are about to reach the limitations of their current plan.

- **Triggered Emails**

Triggered emails are sent when a user takes a specific action, such as visiting a certain page on your website. For example, you might want to send a sales email to someone that clicks on a "compare products" page on your website.

The Power of Triggered Emails

Imagine if you had the power to send someone a message when they were in their inbox going through their email. Your new message would appear at the top of your subscriber's inbox, just waiting to be read. Your message would get incredibly strong open and clickthrough rates, because the email would be impossible to miss. While this ability might seem like a marketer's fantasy, it is entirely possible by setting up a triggered email campaign.

Triggered email campaigns are emails that get sent to your subscribers when they take a specific action, such as opening one of your

emails or clicking on a link in one of your other email campaigns. Triggered emails can also be fired when someone visits a specific page on your website, such as your landing page or checkout page. Triggered email campaigns are incredibly effective at catching the attention of your subscribers. You may find that a triggered email gets double or even triple the open rate of a normal email blast to your list and open-to-click rates as high as 10%.

MarketBeat has had great success leveraging triggered emails to promote its top advertisers. Whenever one of our subscribers clicks on an advertisement in our newsletter or on our website for the first time each day, we send them a marketing email that promotes one of our best-performing affiliate offers. We have setup our targeting software so that no more than one triggered email is sent per day and our subscribers do not receive the same triggered campaign twice.

MarketBeat operates at significant scale and drives more than 50,000 clicks to its advertisers each day. This means we will send as many as 50,000 triggered campaign emails per day to our subscribers. On average these emails have a 40% open rate and a 10% clickthrough rate, generating an additional 2,000 ad clicks per day for our best advertisers.

While triggered campaigns are incredibly powerful, they aren't universally supported by email service providers and marketing automation platforms. We had to custom build a platform so that we could send triggered emails exactly the way we wanted to. SendInBlue, Drip, and Constant Contact are ESPs that advertise having the ability to setup custom email triggers. If you plan on using triggered emails as part of your email marketing program, ask your ESP if their platform will allow you to make custom email triggers.

List Segmentation

Another aspect of email marketing automation is segmentation. Segmentation is simply the process of breaking up a mailing list into smaller lists—known as segments—based on interests.

If you use an email service provider with marketing automation functionality, you can send an email that allows users to express interest in learning about various topics. Users will click on one or more topics they are interested in, and they will automatically be added to the segments or sub-lists they select. Granted, you may have to email your mailing list multiple times to get a good percentage of your subscribers to self-select into different segments. When segmenting your mailing list, you will be sending a larger number of emails in each month, but each email will only be sent to a specific portion of your list. This will increase the relevance of the emails that you send to any given subscriber.

For example, if you had a blog about building websites, you might have some users that are interested in different content management

systems like WordPress, Drupal, and ConcreteCMS. Users that are interested in WordPress might not be interested in getting email about Drupal and ConcreteCMS. If you have a piece of educational content about WordPress you want to send to your mailing list, you might only mail it to the segment of your audience that has expressed interest in learning about WordPress.

Segmentation works best for large mailing lists that have more than 25,000 subscribers and for lists related to broad topics with smaller interest areas. If you have a smaller list, it may not be worth the effort to segment your audience if there will be only a small number of people in any given segment. If your mailing list is very focused on a single topic, segmentation may not be necessary. You should identify between three and six interest areas to use as segments of your mailing list. If you try to create too many, you may end up with very small segments that aren't big enough to be worth mailing individually.

At MarketBeat, we segment users based off interest categories and user behavior. For example, if a user clicks on an ad about options trading, we automatically put them into our options trading segment. We have about ten different segments for different categories of investing that people could be interested. That way, when someone approaches us about sending an advertising email about an options trading product, we can send it only to the people we know are already interested in options trading. By only emailing users about only the content they are likely to be interested, we have higher engagement rates and lower unsubscribe rates.

Wrap-Up

While developing a plan to regularly email your mailing list through your autoresponder series and through broadcast emails may seem like a big chore, it doesn't have to be. Start simply by writing your welcome email and the first few emails in your autoresponder series. Continue to add a new email to it every couple of days until it's complete.

As your first subscribers begin to complete the series, start sending periodic broadcast emails to your list to ensure that all your subscribers are regularly getting email from you. Over time, consider more advanced strategies like list segmentation and marketing automation to maximize the effectiveness of your email marketing efforts.

Action Steps:

- Write your welcome email and enter it into your email service provider.
- Write your first three autoresponder emails and add them into your email service provider.

- Create a schedule of all the broadcast emails you want to send to your list next month.
- Consider sending a weekly newsletter to your subscribers.
- Track the performance of every email that you send.

CHAPTER FIVE

Writing Email That Inspires Users to Take Action

You have undoubtedly written thousands of emails in your life. You probably send and receive email from friends, family, coworkers, and even complete strangers on a regular basis for any number of reasons. While writing an email to any one person is a straightforward endeavor, sending an email to a large group of people is an entirely different skillset. You need to craft a message that attracts the attention of a diverse group of individuals, clearly communicates a single objective, and inspires them to take a desired action. If that doesn't sound hard enough, you must do this without the use of video, audio, images (sometimes), and other dynamic content. You also must deal with the technical peculiarities of email, avoid spam filters, and comply with your country's anti-spam laws.

Writing effective email is both an art and a science. There are many best practices to follow when writing email that are covered in this chapter. You can also test different body copy, subject lines, and calls-to-action to determine which types of email will generate the most revenue with your list. While it's normally good to follow copywriting best practices, sometimes email lists respond in unexpected ways. You might write a great email and get zero sales. You might write a short two sentence email and get dozens of sales. You won't always know why one email performs better than the other, but over time you will have a better understanding of what types of content and messaging resonates with your audience.

Understanding Your Audience

To effectively write to your audience, you first must understand who they are. How old are your typical subscribers? What do they do for a living? What gender are they? Are they married? Where do they live? What are their interests? What problems do they face? Why did they sign up for your mailing list? If you don't know these things, conduct a survey, and ask people to share information about themselves, so you have a better idea of who makes up your email list.

I recommend creating a fictional character that epitomizes your typical customer, known as an avatar. The character that you create should have a name, an age, a gender, a job, a hometown, personal interests, and problems that they face daily. The avatar that I created for MarketBeat is named Bill. He is about sixty years old. He's married, is a homeowner, and has some money to invest in the stock market. He likes

to pick his own stocks but isn't sure whose advice he should listen to. He can live just about anywhere in the United States or Canada and loves to keep up with the day-to-day news in the stock market. He's also very concerned about having money to live on during his retirement years. By creating an avatar, you will have a better idea of who you are marketing to and, in many ways, can get inside the minds of your subscribers.

When you write an email to your mailing list, write as if you are sending a personal message to your avatar. Ask yourself what your avatar would need to hear to act based on your email. What kind of hopes do they have that you can encourage? What kind of fears do they have that you can assuage? If you write to your avatar and use lots of "you" language, subscribers will subconsciously think that your email was written to them specifically and will be more likely to engage with your message. Keep the focus on your subscribers as much as possible. Make your emails about them, not about you.

Here's an example of an email that uses personal language:

Matthew Paulson

To: subscriber@marketbeat.com

Subject: Crazy market volatility

Hi [Name] –

Did you see what happened in the market with TSLA today? It was down by 2.3% this morning. When I checked my computer after lunch, it was up by 1.8%.

I don't know what you think, but it seems like there has been a lot more volatility in the stock market for the last few months. You've probably seen stocks that go up in the morning, down in the afternoon, and go back up after hours. It's crazy.

Would you like to be able to identify the most volatile stocks in the S&P 500 so that you don't have to feel like you're riding an emotional roller coaster every day?

Here's a free report (just for you) which shows which stocks are most likely to see volatility in the weeks and months to come.

[Click Here to Get Your Free Report](#)

Matthew Paulson

MarketBeat.com

Parts of an Email

When getting ready to put together an email, it would be easy to think that the only thing you must write is the message body. However, there are several different components of every message that you send to

your list. You need to put as much thought and effort into the other parts of your email as you would in the main message body.

Here are the key components of an email:

- **Subject Line**

This is the subject of your message. It is the first thing your subscribers will see and will determine whether they open your message.

- **Preheader**

The preheader is the preview text included after the subject line in some email services, such as Gmail. It can serve as a second subject line that will further encourage users to open your email. If you don't intentionally add a preheader, most email services will use the first sentence or two of your email as a preheader.

- **“From” Name**

This is the name of the person sending the email. Use your personal name in lieu of the name of your company, because email users are more likely to open an email from an actual person.

- **Message Body**

This is the main text of your email.

- **Call-to-Action**

This is a hyperlink at the bottom of your message body that persuades users to take a specific action, such as clicking on a hyperlink.

- **Signature**

Keep your email signature simple. Long email signatures can be a distraction to the main content of your email. I personally just use

my name on one line and the name of my company on the following line.

- **Postscript**

Consider periodically using a “P.S.” below your email signature to serve as a secondary sales tool after your main email. For example, you could include something like, “P.S. Remember that our service comes with a 30-day money-back guarantee. If you’re not satisfied with our service within the first 30 days, just let us know, and we’ll provide you a full refund.”

- **Footer**

Your footer usually contains your unsubscribe link and other information that you need to include to stay compliant with anti-spam laws, such as your mailing address and the name of your company. Your footer will likely be the same for every email that you send to your list.

Types of Messages

Every email that you send to your mailing list will be sent for a specific purpose. You might have an announcement to make or want your subscribers to read a piece of content you recently posted. You may want them to check out one of your company’s products or keep them engaged by sending them helpful information.

Here are some of the main reasons that you will email your list:

- **Announcements**

Whenever you have something big to announce, you should announce it to your email subscribers, so they know they are valued members of your community.

- **Internal Sales and Marketing**

You will periodically want to send sales and marketing emails to your subscribers about your company’s products and services. Make sure you only email subscribers about a product or a sale they haven’t already purchased.

- **Third-Party Advertising**

In order to generate additional revenue, you can promote another company's products and services as an affiliate or through another advertising deal that you negotiate. Read the monetization chapter of this book for more information about how to do this.

- **Weekly Newsletter**

Consider creating a weekly newsletter for your subscribers that contains useful and interesting content. Your weekly newsletter will help keep users interested and engaged with your content.

- **User Engagement**

You will want to regularly send your subscribers valuable tips, resources, and other educational information that will keep them engaged with your mailing list.

- **Feedback**

Whenever you need feedback about an idea, email your audience and ask them for it. Ask two or three questions and request they respond with their feedback by replying.

- **List Management**

You may need to periodically send messages to users relating to the status of their subscription. You might need to reconfirm their subscription if they haven't opened an email from you in a while, or you might want them to identify specific interests as part of a segmentation campaign.

Give, Give, Give, Ask

While you will email your audience for many different reasons, you need to keep a healthy balance between sending emails that provide value to your audience and emails that take value away.

Emails that contain information helpful to your readers at no cost such as tips, educational content, resources, and training videos, *provide* value to your audience. Emails that ask your audience to purchase a

product or take action that benefits you more than them will *take* value from your audience.

I recommend sending at least two emails that provide value to your audience for every one email that takes it from them. Ideally, you will provide so much value to your audience that they respond to your sales and marketing emails out of sheer gratitude for the value you have already provided. This principle is outlined in detail by Gary Vaynerchuk in his book, *Jab, Jab, Jab, Right Hook: How to Tell Your Story in a Noisy Social World*.

Writing Great Subject Lines

Your subject lines are the most important words that you will write as part of your email marketing strategy. If you write a subject line that is uninspired and doesn't grab the attention of your subscribers, they probably aren't going to open your message.

According to a report from Chadwick Martin Bailey, 64% of people say they will choose to open an email because of the subject line.¹⁷ If you write a great subject line, you'll receive higher open rates, which will lead to more clickthroughs and more sales. A well-written subject line can often receive double the open rates of a poorly written one, which will in turn double your clickthroughs and double the sales generated by an email.

Here are some examples of a few different types of subject lines that you can use:

- **Confrontation:** Quit Wasting Your Time with Options Trading
- **Curiosity:** Strange Question...?
- **How to:** How to Double Your Revenue with One Little-Known Email Marketing Technique
- **Humor:** Forget Black Friday – Enjoy Wine Weekend
- **Numbers:** What 83% of Golfers Screw Up on the Course
- **Reply-To:** RE: Your Subscription to MarketBeat Daily Premium
- **Shocking:** How I Lost 48 Pounds in ONE WEEK
- **Testimonial:** “MarketBeat made me \$12,384.32 in one trade”
- **Time Sensitive:** Tonight's Deadline (Last Chance!)
- **Tips:** 3 Ways to Double Your Facebook Following
- **Warning:** Don't Miss Out!

Here are some of the subject lines that have received the highest open rates in the history of MarketBeat:

- An important reminder ... (40.8% open rate)
- RE: Clean Water Project (27.6% open rate)

- I'm Sorry:\ (27.1% open rate)
- Bad News (25% open rate)
- Good News! :-\ (24% open rate)
- Clearing up some confusion (24.6% open rate)
- Important (please read) (23.9% open rate)
- Black Friday ...in June? (21.9% open rate)
- Weird Question? (21.4% open rate)

There are also several techniques that can modify subject lines to emphasize words and to make unsaid promises about the content of your message. If you are going to use any variation techniques (listed below), switch them up from email to email, and don't use any one technique more than twice each month. Subscribers will notice these patterns if used too often, rendering them ineffective.

Here are the techniques:

- **Make an Email Appear Personal**

Make your entire subject line lowercase to imply that the message is personal in nature, because individuals don't always put the same effort into writing an error-free and correctly-capitalized subject line. For example, "how I beat the stock market" sounds a lot more personal than "How I Beat the Stock Market."

- **Imply Strong Emotion and Importance**

You can uppercase your subject line to imply strong emotion or importance to your email. For example, "I BEAT THE STOCK MARKET" implies urgency and importance.

- **Specific Numbers**

You can use specific numbers, like 23.6 or 29%, to imply accuracy of your data. People are naturally wired to think that numbers are less likely to be fabricated if they are more specific or have a decimal point. For example, "How I Beat the Market by 7.8% in 2015" would imply that there's more math showing how I beat the stock market by that *exact* number.

- **Emphasize**

You can emphasize a particular word by uppercasing only that word or by surrounding that word with asterisks. For example, “How I BEAT the Stock Market by 7.8% When Others Failed” draws attention to the word “beat.”

- **More Information Inside**

You can add ellipses (three periods) at the end of your subject line to imply that there’s much more for users inside of your email. For example, “How I beat the stock market...” implies that I will share details in the body of the email.

- **Communicate Two Things at Once**

Use brackets when you need to communicate two different things about an email. For example, “How I Beat the Stock Market [Free Video]” implies that users will both learn how to beat the stock market and get a free video in their inbox.

Don’t believe that you must write every email subject line from scratch. Feel free to use the subject lines listed in this chapter. You can get good ideas for subject lines by searching for “subject line ideas” in your search engine of choice.

I also recommend signing up for the mailing lists of well-known Internet marketers like Russell Brunson, Ryan Deiss, Frank Kern, and Eben Pagan so that you can see how entrepreneurs that make millions of dollars each year perform their craft.

Writing an Announcement Email

Periodically, you’ll have a new project or some other news that you want to share with your mailing list. It will be very tempting to write an email that communicates how excited you are for your project and how it’s going to change your business. Remember that your audience cares about themselves much more than they care about you, so always make announcements in such a way that keeps the focus on your subscribers.

Your announcement email should also attempt to generate excitement and enthusiasm in your subscribers by suggesting how your announcement can change their lives. Finally, don’t write something vague that’s filled with a lot of hype and doesn’t tell your subscribers the specifics of what you want to announce. Be clear and concise about the details of your announcement in your email.

Here’s an example of an announcement email I might send to MarketBeat subscribers:

Matthew Paulson

To: subscriber@marketbeat.com

Subject: Something New from MarketBeat

Hey [Name] –

There have been a lot of ups and downs in the market recently. Some of your stocks are probably doing quite well, and there are others that you might want to sweep under the rug.

You've really got to pick out strong companies with good fundamentals to ride out the waves of a volatile market.

If you'd like help identifying a few great companies with good fundamentals to add to your portfolio, we've developed a brand-new screening tool that will allow you to find companies that are poised to appreciate by more than 10% over the next 12 months through some newly developed, advanced trading algorithms that hedge funds don't even have access to.

We've found one company that has a potential upside of more than 35%. Now, wouldn't that be a nice return to brag about on the golf course?

We call this new tool the MarketBeat Volatility Opportunity Screener, and it's included free with your existing subscription to RatingsDB.

[Click Here to Access the MarketBeat Volatility Screener](#)

Thanks!

Matthew Paulson

MarketBeat.com

Writing a Promotional Email for an Advertiser

If you are promoting another company's product or service in exchange for an affiliate commission or another form of compensation, you are personally endorsing that product or service, and that should be reflected in your email. When writing a marketing email for an advertiser, communicate the features and benefits of the product you are promoting. Make it clear how the product can help your subscribers specifically and always disclose that you are getting paid to help the company generate sales.

Here is an example of a marketing email for an advertiser that I might send:

Matthew Paulson

To: subscriber@usgolftv.com

Subject: New irons for your bag

Hey [Name] –

With the spring golf season just two months away, it's hard to not start salivating over the opportunity to get on the course. If you're like me, you've probably already dusted off your golf bag, cleaned up your clubs, and gotten everything else ready for the season. I think what I'm most excited about for this year's golf season is my brand-new set of irons from XYZ Golf.

I was down in Florida a month or so back, and a buddy had an early set of the new XYZ irons. They have some of the best grips I've ever seen and have a newly designed clubhead specially made to increase both speed and accuracy. They also have this amazing little wedge that has gotten me out of the sand on 100% of the shots I've taken. There are a lot of iron clubs on the market right now, but I really think the XYZ clubs are the ones to beat.

In fact, XYZ irons are so good that I want to make sure you can get your set ahead of the season. XYZ's generally not in stores yet, but I've found one retailer that has 40 full sets she's ready to sell for just \$299.97 apiece. I don't think you'll be able to find a better price anywhere else.

If you'd like to check out the new XYZ irons, click on the link below. I also want to let you know that I will receive a small commission if you purchase using the link below, but I wouldn't ever recommend a product or service that I wouldn't use personally.

Click Here to Get Your XYZ Irons

Matthew Paulson

MarketBeat.com

Writing Content Promotion Emails

If you create a new resource, such as a very long blog post, a new podcast episode, or a new eBook, send an email to your audience letting them know it's available. Don't assume your subscribers will read every blog post on your website because that rarely happens. When you have a great new piece of content for them to consume, let them know via email, so they won't miss it and will stay engaged with your mailing list. If you want your subscribers to promote your content, use a bit of the social capital you have built up with them, and ask them to share your content. Remember to include links so that a subscriber can easily share your post on Facebook as well.

Here's an example of a content promotion email I might send:

Matthew Paulson

To: subscriber@marketbeat.com

Subject: New resource for aspiring entrepreneurs

Good morning –

One of the hardest challenges that every new entrepreneur makes is taking the leap and acquiring their first customer. Many new entrepreneurs get distracted by working on their name, building their website, creating business cards, reading business books, and going to conferences. While these things can be fun to do, none of these things help your business generate revenue.

I've always wondered why new entrepreneurs don't just start identifying prospects, setting up meetings, and trying to get sales. I had a discussion the other day with a newer entrepreneur, and he told me that he doesn't know how to make a sales call to ask for a meeting. Certainly, some new entrepreneurs don't make sales calls because they are afraid of being rejected, but others simply don't know how to generate sales.

If you want to learn the exact steps you need to take and the right words to say to identify a new prospect, get a sales meeting with them, and close the deal, I've developed a brand new 5,000-word blog post just for you. It's titled "The Five Steps of Customer Prospecting: What to Do and What to Say," and it's available at the link below.

Click Here to Read "The Five Steps of Customer Prospecting"

Enjoy!

Matthew Paulson

Founder, MarketBeat.com

Learn How to Make a Sales Call Here

Writing Feedback Emails

Market research is one of the best uses for your mailing list. Nobody knows more about what your subscribers want than your subscribers themselves. Whenever you are thinking about launching a new product, a new service, or creating another resource for them, always ask for feedback ahead of time. People love to share their opinions with strangers, so you'll probably receive a lot of responses if you take the time to ask for feedback. Only ask a few questions at a time and leave the questions open-ended, so they have room to tell you what they really think.

Here is an example of a feedback email that I might send:

Matthew Paulson

To: subscriber@marketbeat.com

Subject: Quick question?

Hi [Name] –

As a subscriber to MarketBeat Daily Premium and RatingsDB, you've had access to analyst ratings changes, earnings announcements, and insider trades well before the market opens each morning.

We're getting ready to start on the next round of improvements to our services, and I wanted to get your feedback before we started. If you could take a moment to provide your thoughts and insight, I would be immensely grateful.

Here are the questions:

#1 – What do you like most about our services? What do you like the least?

#2 – Do you feel that MarketBeat Daily Premium is too cluttered? What could be removed?

#3 – Do you have any ideas or suggestions to improve our daily newsletter or our research software?

If you'd be willing to help, simply reply to this email with your feedback.

Thanks in advance,

Matthew Paulson

Founder, MarketBeat.com

Writing Sales and Marketing Emails with AIDA

To write an effective sales and marketing email, you need to take your subscribers through a series of steps to get them to take a desired action, such as purchasing a product or service. You first must grab their **attention**, create **interest** in your product or service, instill a personal **desire** for your offer using your subscribers' hopes and fears, and convince them to act. These four steps make up the acronym AIDA, which was first penned by advertising pioneer E. St. Elmo Lewis in 1903. While the concept AIDA was developed in the print era, it continues to work well as a framework for email copywriting.

The first step is to grab the **attention** of your readers. In the world of email marketing, this means getting your subscribers to see and open your email. Your subscribers may receive as many as one hundred emails every day. They probably do not read most of the emails they receive and may only open five to ten messages on any given day. This is why some of the most engaged email lists in the world only have open rates of 30-

40%. To get consumers to open your emails, you need to stand apart from the crowd by writing a compelling subject line and using a personal “from” name. After someone has opened your email, keep their attention by telling an interesting story, fact, joke, or anything else that someone can’t help but read.

After getting a subscriber’s attention, you will need to smoothly transition to the actual purpose of your email, so you can generate **interest** for the product or service you’re promoting. You can often do this through an analogy that ties the content of your email back into the introduction you used to grab their attention. After the transition, you will extol the features and benefits of what you are selling your audience and show them how it can solve a particular problem for them or make their lives easier.

The next step is to create an emotional **desire** in your subscribers. Try to get your users to think about the emotions they feel whenever they face the problem that your product or service can solve. Also, paint a picture of a desired future state that subscribers can achieve when they purchase your product or service. By helping them remember the negative emotions caused by the problem and showing them what their life can be like if they purchase your product or service to solve it, you will help your customers become emotionally ready to purchase.

The final step is to call your subscribers to take a specific **action**, which is usually purchasing your product or service. Tell your subscribers exactly what they need to do to purchase your product and finish your email by reminding users of the picture you painted of a desired future state.

Here’s an example of a marketing email that was sent out by USGolfTV that uses AIDA:

Todd Kolb

To: subscriber@usgolftv.com

Subject: I’m bored out of my mind.

I don’t know about you, but in my house over the holidays, there’s just not a whole lot to do beyond stuffing our faces full of food and hearing my grandma share the same story year after year. There’s rarely anything good on TV besides the occasional football game. There’s nothing for the serious golf fan to watch and enjoy. That is, until now.

If you want to start off with a better golf game than you had in the fall, I’d encourage you to take the time to start watching The Prairie Secret video training series in your free time during the holidays. You’ll avoid the usual round of holiday boredom and get some great ideas to improve your golf game.

When next spring comes around, your golfing buddies will be out of practice and will be finishing their games several strokes higher than they finished last fall. You, on the other hand? You lost three strokes over the winter by doing the drills outlined in The Prairie Secret.

Want to get your copy of The Prairie Secret? Click the link below to get your copy today.

[Click Here to Get Your Copy of The Prairie Secret](#)

Todd Kolb

USGolfTV

The Six Steps to Generating a Sale from Email Marketing

To generate sales from a marketing email, there are six different steps that people need to take in sequential order to become a customer:

1. A customer must sign up for your mailing list.
2. A customer must become engaged with your content and read the emails you sent.
3. A customer must receive and open a marketing email.
4. A customer must click a link in your marketing email to your sales page.
5. A customer must read the sales material for your product or service on your landing page.
6. A customer must complete the sign-up form to purchase your product.

As email subscribers work through the six steps of becoming a customer, many of them are going to drop off the map and will never become customers. Furthermore, they will likely drop out at different points along the way. All your subscribers will make it through step one. Half might make it through step two. Around 15% of your subscribers might make it through step three, 5% might make it through step four, while 3% of your subscribers might make it through step five. Finally, 2% of your subscribers might make it through step six.

The key is to get as many subscribers as possible from one step to the next. If subscribers drop off at *any* point in these six steps, they will never become customers. You should work on optimizing all six of these steps to ensure the highest percentage of subscribers possible make it from any one step to the next step. The best method is continually running split-tests at every step of the process. By trying different opt-in forms, email marketing copy, subject lines, calls-to-action, and landing page copy over time, you'll identify the language that will help drive more sales.

Best Practices to Follow With Your Email

There are several other best practices that you should follow when sending email to your list:

- **Don't Rely on Images**

Between 10% and 30% of your users will never click “enable images” on your emails. Never rely on images to convey key points in your copy. Use clear and descriptive ALT text on any images that you do include. You can also consider using CSS styling to make your ALT text larger and more visible to subscribers that do not enable images.

- **Avoid Grammar and Spelling Errors**

Poor grammar, capitalization, and spelling can be a huge turn off for many of your email subscribers. If you want to speak with expert authority to your audience, you need to do so with proper, clear writing. No one will believe you are an authority on anything if you can't write a complete sentence. Double-check every email you write for grammar and spelling mistakes and consider having another person check over your messages or use Grammarly ([grammarly.com](https://www.grammarly.com)) before they are sent out to your subscribers.

- **Include Multiple Hyperlinks**

If you have a specific hyperlink that you want users to click on, add a total of three hyperlinks to each email. Hyperlink your main call-to-action at the bottom of your message body and just above your email signature. Also hyperlink a few relevant words in the first paragraph of your email to the page you want users to go to. Finally, include a final call-to-action below your email signature and in any “P.S.” that you include with your email.

- **Avoid Design-Heavy Email Templates**

Subscribers are more likely to read email that comes from an individual person than a faceless company or nonprofit. While companies frequently use templates in their email, *people* almost never do. If possible, avoid using a design-heavy template so that your emails appear more personal to your subscribers.

- **Limit Each Email to One Call-to-Action**

Don't try to get your subscribers to take multiple actions in one email. Each email that you send should have one single purpose and a single call-to-action that you want them to take. Users are less likely to respond when they must consider which, if any, of your calls-to-action that they want to take.

- **Have a Clear Unsubscribe Link**

Don't try to hide or obscure your unsubscribe link. Have a clear unsubscribe link that says "Click Here to Unsubscribe" in a normal font size. If you try to obscure your unsubscribe link, your subscribers may report your messages as spam, which can put you in jeopardy with your email service provider if your account generates too many spam complaints.

Should I Hire a Professional Copywriter?

There are many professional email copywriters that you can pay to create email marketing campaigns on your behalf. However, you probably should *not* hire one, especially if you are just getting started. Learning to become an effective copywriter takes experience. When someone else is writing copy for you, you won't have the opportunity to practice and learn how to write your copy for yourself. Good copywriters can be very expensive to hire, which will make it much more difficult to run a profitable email marketing campaign.

There are two instances where it might be appropriate to hire a professional copywriter to write email for you.

If your business is already generating more than six figures per year when you start email marketing, it may be more cost-effective for you to hire a copywriter. At \$200,000 per year, your time is worth about \$150.00 per hour. If it takes you three hours to write an email and a copywriter can do a better job than you at \$150.00 per message, go ahead and write a check to the copywriter.

The other instance is for creating your autoresponder series, but only if you don't have much experience writing email, and you can easily afford the fees. By having a professional copywriter create your autoresponder series, you'll have relevant email copy that you can repurpose as broadcast emails down the line.

Wrap-Up

In this chapter, I've put together a basic overview of email copywriting and a list of best practices to follow when writing email to your subscribers. Copywriting is a skill that will take a lot of time and practice to master. Most of the email that you send for the first several months won't be very good, and that's okay. Continue learning and practicing email copywriting by following experts like John McIntyre (dropdeadcopy.com), reading marketing email sent out by your competitors, and consuming educational content about copywriting from places like Copyblogger (copyblogger.com/blog). Over time, your copywriting skills will improve and mature, and eventually writing email to your audience will come naturally.

Action Steps:

- Create an avatar that epitomizes a typical subscriber.
- Practice writing sales and marketing emails using AIDA.
- Know the eight parts of every email and the seven reasons to email your list.
- Identify additional copywriting resources that you can learn from and rely on in the future.

CASE STUDY #4

USGolfTV

USGolfTV is a digital publishing and television production company based out of Sioux Falls, South Dakota. It was founded in 2010 by Todd Kolb, who is a PGA teaching professional. Todd is responsible for content creation and general business strategy. I was an equity partner in this company from 2014 to 2017 and was responsible for a variety of marketing and revenue growth projects during that time, including growing the company's mailing list from 5,000 subscribers to over 75,000 subscribers.

As a business, USGolfTV is made up of three primary components: the USGolfTV TV show, the company's video training products, and the company's website (usgolftv.com). The television show, USGolfTV, is a regionally syndicated program that is available in about 12 million homes in 25 states through a variety of cable channels, including Cox, Time Warner, and Midco Sports Net. The show provides golf tips, product reviews, and industry trends. It makes a minor profit, but its real value is that it gives the company a substantial amount of credibility whenever its owners approach a potential advertiser. Because USGolfTV can give advertisers exposure on television, in its email newsletter, and on its website, advertisers are much more likely to consider advertising to their audience.

The second major component of the business is the company's video training products. USGolfTV has produced several web-based video training courses that help golfers improve a specific part of their game. These products are primarily through email marketing and working with affiliates. The USGolfTV website has a pop-up opt-in form to get new subscribers to opt in to a 5-day video course which will teach them about a specific part of golf, like putting. After they receive the five videos in the series, they will receive marketing emails for the full premium video course associated with the 5-day course. When you buy one of their premium video courses, you will receive a series of videos featuring Todd in addition to written instructions to help you implement what you are learning on the course. These videos are sold and delivered through a piece of software called ClickFunnels (clickfunnels.com), which serves both as a landing page service and a product delivery service. These video training products cost between \$27.00 and \$235.00 depending on which program you buy.

The final component of the business is the USGolfTV website, which serves as the glue that brings all the other parts of the business together. USGolfTV has a team of 5-7 writers that publish golf news,

product reviews, and other content on USGolfTV.com. The website receives traffic from all the usual sources, including organic searches, social media, and news portals like Google News. USGolfTV generates revenue on the website through Google AdSense, through private sponsorships, and by gathering email sign-ups, so the company can promote its own paid products to its audience. The economics of selling internally produced products on USGolfTV's website are astonishing. We know that 5%-10% of visitors will sign up for a free course on the website, and 3% of those people will buy one of USGolfTV's premium courses that has an average sale price of \$100.00, so we can take those numbers and say the business expects to make between \$200 and \$250 from every 1,000 visitors on its website through email marketing alone.

USGolfTV has done a few things with email marketing particularly well. The company regularly does email swaps with several different partners in the golf industry to promote its mailing list and its products. USGolfTV also periodically pays to be featured on another brand's email list to grow its own mailing list and sell its products. USGolfTV has even traded commercial space on its television show in exchange for email sends. The golf industry is very much built on relationships, and USGolfTV's team has leveraged that reality by using its existing relationships to attract affiliates and do email swaps.

USGolfTV uses a pop-up opt-in form on its website like the one used that MarketBeat used for years. We know that customers are more likely to purchase USGolfTV's paid video courses if they opt-in to multiple free video series, so the website rotates lead magnets daily. If one video series isn't useful to a reader, the series that gets promoted the next day might be more interesting to them. The website also includes several in-post lead forms to promote specific lead magnets that are tied to the content of the post. The company does not run a co-registration ad on its "thank you" page, however, because co-registration ads haven't taken off on sports websites yet. They do place a display advertisement unit on "thank you" pages, which does quite well.

I sold my equity interest in the company back to the other owners in 2017 so that I could focus exclusively on MarketBeat. At the time of my departure from the company, the USGolfTV website received approximately 100,000 visitors each month and had an email list of more than 75,000 golfers. Since my departure, the company has continued to grow and has had found new success with a YouTube channel that has more than 35,000 subscribers. I continue to be optimistic about USGolfTV's prospects and wish Todd, Nick, and the rest of the team the best of luck in growing their business.

Note: The information in this case study was accurate as of the time of my departure from USGolfTV in late 2017. Specific numbers mentioned in this case study, as well as aspects of USGolfTV's

business model, have changed since I sold my interest in the company.

CHAPTER SIX

Monetization: Six Ways to Make Money with Your Mailing List

Building a mailing list serves no purpose if it does not also further your company's financial objectives. If you run a for-profit company, your ultimate goal is to generate new revenue and get more customers through your email marketing efforts. This chapter will teach you how to sell more of your company's products and services through email marketing and how to generate additional revenue through email advertising networks and through affiliate marketing.

Sell Your Own Products

Most companies use their mailing lists to market their own products and services. If someone comes to your website and completes an opt-in form, they have already expressed interest in your content and are probably a potential customer for your company's products and services. Send emails that educate and inform your subscribers about your products and services regularly. Don't assume that your subscribers already know about what you have to offer, because not everyone pays equal attention to all the emails you send, and new subscribers are being added to your mailing list regularly.

If you do have products or services that you can sell to your mailing list, you are probably better off promoting your own products than another company's products, even those you would receive an affiliate commission for promoting. When you sell your own products and services, you get to keep 100% of the customer's payment. When you are promoting someone else's product, you may receive as little as 10% of the revenue generated by a sale.

If you don't have any products or services that you can sell to your audience, consider making a course that teaches something to your subscribers or helps them achieve a specific goal. While the product creation and launch process is beyond the scope of this book, read my internet business creation book, *Online Business from Scratch* (fromscratchbook.com), for advice on how to create and market your first product. You can also read Jeff Walker's book, *Launch: How to Sell Almost Anything Online, Build a Business You Love, and Live the Life of Your Dreams*, for additional guidance on the process of launching your first product.

Here are some strategies that you can use to generate sales for your company's product or service:

- **Use Your Autoresponder Series**

Sprinkle information about your company's products and services in your autoresponder series. Subscribers are often most engaged with your mailing list soon after they first subscribe, so don't wait more than a week or two before sending them sales and marketing material.

- **Run a Sale**

Periodically, consider offering a time-limited discount on one of your company's products or services to generate additional sales. Offer a 20-30% discount on whatever you are promoting, but only make that discount available for a fixed time period, such as three, five, or seven days. Send multiple emails during the sale that extol the features and benefits of your company's products and services. On the last day of the sale, send your subscribers an email reminding them of the deal and making it clear the sale is ending that night. By having a hard deadline for your sale, potential customers who are on the fence will be more likely to take action to avoid missing the sale.

- **Offer Special Bonuses**

Another way to add urgency to the purchasing process is offering a special bonus to customers that purchase by a specific date. It can be another of your products or a small add-on product that you create to serve specifically as a bonus. At MarketBeat, we frequently send users a free copy of my dividend investing book, Automatic Income (automaticincomebook.com), as a bonus that's not otherwise available. A special bonus campaign will operate very similar to a sale campaign because subscribers will be getting something they wouldn't otherwise normally receive and have to take action by a specific date and time.

- **Relaunch Existing Products**

If you have a product that you launched more than a year ago, consider adding some new features and benefits and launching it to your mailing list as a "new and improved" version of your product. The new version of your product will provide a great excuse to execute an email marketing campaign as if you were launching a

new product, and subscribers will take a second look at a product they might have otherwise ignored. Make sure you give all your existing customers a free upgrade to the new version to avoid any hard feelings. You can make a relaunch campaign more effective by offering a sale or a special bonus during the launch period to your subscribers.

- **Group Products Together**

If your company offers complimentary products and services, consider creating a campaign where customers can buy two products at once for a single price. You should offer a slight discount for the combined product offering and consider adding a bonus that's only available to people who purchase both products in a package.

- **Create New Products**

If your existing products and services aren't getting the sales traction with your mailing list that they once were, you can always create a new product. When I was at USGolfTV, we regularly launched new premium video training courses so that we would have fresh products and content to promote to our audience. When you have a new product, you can create buzz with a pre-launch marketing campaign and generate a level of interest that you otherwise might not be able to when marketing an existing product.

At MarketBeat, we use our mailing list to sell subscription information services to our subscriber base. Our cheapest products are alert services, such as MarketBeat Momentum Alerts, that we sell for \$99/year. We also sell our premium daily newsletter, MarketBeat Daily Premium, for \$199/year and our suite of investment research tools called MarketBeat All Access for \$399/year.

Through our daily newsletter, our autoresponder series, and broadcast emails that we send to our mailing list, we generate more than \$3 million per year in recurring annual revenue from the subscription products we sell. We also regularly launch new products, relaunch existing products, and offer time-limited discounts and bonuses for customers that buy during campaigns.

Promote Third-Party Products and Services as an Affiliate

There are thousands of companies that will pay you commissions for any sales that you generate on their behalf, an arrangement known in the online business world as affiliate marketing. Promoting other companies' products and services to your mailing list can be an extremely effective

way to generate revenue if you can find a product with an affiliate program that is a great match for your audience.

Affiliate marketing is my favorite way of selling online advertising. Because you are only getting paid by the direct value you create for an advertiser, you can receive outsized compensation when you find products and services to promote that are a great fit for your audience. MarketBeat once approached an advertiser who was regularly buying ads on our website through Google AdWords about developing a direct affiliate relationship. By moving to a direct deal, we were able to eliminate both their media buyer's fees and Google AdWords' fees. We also improved the copy to make it more relevant to our readers and were able to promote their offer in our newsletters and not just on our website. Within a few months, their monthly spend with MarketBeat had increased by more than 400%.

There are other benefits to setting up direct affiliate relationship with advertisers. When an advertiser is paying based on performance, there will never be requests for discounts when a campaign didn't perform as expected. They won't question how many clicks you sent on a given campaign, because you are getting paid per sale and not per click. There are no middlemen taking a cut of your earnings, because you have a direct relationship with the company you are promoting. You can also work with your affiliate advertisers to find creative ways to promote their products and services, such as SMS blasts and push notifications.

Everyone with a mailing list should test promoting affiliate offers to their audiences. Even if your company produces its own products and services, you should still consider promoting other companies. You can only talk about your products so much before your audience gets sick of hearing about them.

Finding Products to Promote

Finding products and services to promote as an affiliate is a straightforward process. There are several large advertising networks that focus exclusively on creating affiliate relationships between advertisers and publishers. These networks will handle any necessary paperwork, provide banners and other creative tools to use on your website, serve as an intermediary in the relationship, and make sure you get paid for your efforts.

Affiliate networks also make it very easy to find products and services to promote. They will list advertisers by category and show which advertisers' other publishers are currently having the most success with. Keep in mind that you will have the most success promoting products closely related to the content that you write about. If you have an investing website, you want to primarily promote investing-related services like stock brokerages and research tools. You wouldn't get good

results promoting unrelated services like web hosting and domain name registration services.

Here is a list of some of the larger affiliate advertising networks:

- Amazon Associates (affiliate-program.amazon.com)
- Awin (awin.com)
- Click Bank (clickbank.com)
- CJ / Commission Junction (cj.com)
- eBay Partner Network (partnernetwork.ebay.com)
- Flex Offers (flexoffers.com)
- Impact (impact.com)
- Rakuten Marketing (rakutenmarketing.com/affiliate)
- ShareASale (shareasale.com)

If you are overwhelmed by the sheer number of advertisers that list their products on affiliate networks, you can simplify the process by looking at what products and services your competitors and other similar websites are promoting. If several other websites are all promoting a specific advertiser and they have been for several months, there's a good chance they are making good money promoting them.

To identify which network a particular advertiser is using, simply do a web search for the name of the advertiser followed by the word "affiliate program," and the sign-up link will appear more often than not.

How Does an Affiliate Marketing Email Actually Work?

After you have found an advertiser that you want to promote and have signed up for their affiliate program through an advertising network, you will be given hyperlinks to use that will track any sales you generate. They may also provide an image tag that serves as a tracking pixel to include in your email.

You will write a sales and marketing email to your audience as you normally would for your company's products and services. Then use the hyperlink they provided you as the hyperlink in your call-to-action so that sales are properly tracked. If they provided a tracking pixel, place it in your HTML at the bottom of your email, so the number of times the offer was viewed can be properly tracked by the affiliate program.

How Much Can I Make Through Affiliate Marketing?

With affiliate marketing, payments are made based on the actual sales that you generate. The amount of money you can make through affiliate marketing depends on several factors including the size of your list, the relevance of the product or service to your list, and the effectiveness of the marketing copy that you use to write a product. If you have a small list and are ineffectively promoting a product that's not

relevant to your list, you probably won't make anything through affiliate marketing.

If you have a larger list of highly engaged subscribers who trust your recommendations and you can promote a product or service that's very relevant to your audience, you can make tens of thousands of dollars per month. If you have a list of a few thousand subscribers, you will probably earn \$100-\$200 per month through affiliate marketing for the first several months. Your revenue will steadily increase over time as your list grows and as you identify products and services to promote that are a good match for your list.

MarketBeat's list, which has approximately 3 million subscribers, generates more than \$1 million per month through affiliate advertising with stock brokerages and financial newsletter publishers. I share this not to boast, but rather to show that there is a very high ceiling in what someone with a large email list can earn through affiliate marketing.

What Best Practices Should I Follow as an Affiliate?

There are several best practices that you should follow when promoting products and services to your audience as an affiliate:

- **Be Transparent**

You should always disclose to your subscribers if you are receiving a commission for promoting a product or service for honesty, transparency, and even legal reasons. In the United States, the FTC requires that you disclose any payment that you receive for endorsing a product or service. You can read the FTC's endorsement guidelines at <https://www.ftc.gov/news-events/topics/truth-advertising/advertisement-endorsements>.

- **Promotion Equals Endorsement**

If you are promoting a product as an affiliate, you are personally endorsing that product as something your subscribers should use. If you wouldn't personally use a product or service, don't promote it to your mailing list. Your subscribers will lose trust in you if you promote low-quality products and are only concerned with the affiliate commissions you generate.

- **Don't Over-Promote One Product**

You will see diminishing returns after you continue to promote the same product over time. Rotate the products and services that you promote to avoid overexposing any one advertiser to your mailing list.

- **Include a Bonus**

To ensure a subscriber signs up for something through your affiliate link, create a bonus product that's only available to those who sign up through your affiliate link. You can use one of your existing products or create an educational piece of content to serve as your bonus. Have subscribers forward you the welcome email or the receipt that they get from the advertiser in exchange for the bonus product you create.

- **Follow Program Rules**

Each affiliate advertiser will have their own set of program rules. They may place limitations on the language that you use and the ways that you promote their product or service. Take the time to read the rules set by each advertiser to avoid having your relationship terminated through inadvertently breaking one of their program rules.

Pat Flynn (smartpassiveincome.com) is a great example of someone who does affiliate marketing properly through email, his website, and his podcast. He has established himself as an online business expert and recommends tools, products, and services to his audience that can help them build their online businesses. He states that he only promotes products that he can personally recommend and is generally transparent when he receives an affiliate commission for promoting something. He has built such a large audience, and his affiliate marketing is so effective that the commissions he generates through his promotions have become far larger than the actual revenue he makes from his other online businesses. It's not uncommon for Flynn to generate between \$50,000 and \$100,000 each month through his affiliate marketing efforts.

Rent Your Mailing List

If you have grown your mailing list to more than 25,000 subscribers, advertisers may be interested in paying you to send an email to your mailing list on their behalf. If your mailing list is smaller than 25,000 subscribers, your list may not be large enough to attract the interest of advertisers yet. Let's say you have a mailing list of 30,000 subscribers, and an advertiser agrees to pay \$40.00 CPM to email your list. They

would pay you a total of \$1,200 to send an email promoting their product or service. Renting your list to advertisers can be very profitable if you have built a large mailing list.

Advertisers pay to rent mailing lists in a variety of different ways. They may pay a mailing list owner a flat fee to send an email to their mailing list. They may also pay on a cost per thousand impressions (CPM) basis, a cost per click (CPC) basis, or a cost per action/sale (CPA) basis. Advertisers will generally want to pay publishers on a performance basis (CPC or CPA), because that puts the performance risk on the publisher. Publishers generally want to charge an advertiser a flat fee or on a CPM basis, because they get paid regardless of whether the email performs well or not. What advertisers end up paying will be a negotiation that factors in industry standards and the value created by the publisher's email promotions.

Finding Advertisers to Rent Your List

The biggest challenge with renting out your list is finding advertisers. Unless you are already established as a reputable mailing list owner with advertisers in your industry or are working with a reputable advertising agency that sells dedicated emails, you may have trouble letting advertisers know your list exists and is worth renting. There are disreputable publishers that try to sell mailings to low-quality, stolen, or scrapped mailing lists; to avoid trouble, advertisers primarily want to work with larger publishers that have built a good reputation.

If you are just getting started renting out your mailing list, your best bet is to find an advertising agency that works with mailing lists in your industry. You will be able to get a lot more list rentals if you can get a reputable agency to endorse and promote your mailing list. While an agency may take a 30%-50% commission on anything they sell, a *good* agency will make you far more than they cost you. Their sales team will be able to get you in front of advertisers that normally wouldn't talk to you and will even make deals on your behalf.

When we were first establishing MarketBeat as a brand, we worked with a variety of finance-specific advertising agencies that sold newsletter sponsorships and dedicated emails to our mailing lists. These agencies include Investing Media Solutions, Strikepoint Media, and Investing Channel. These agencies had existing relationships with large financial advertisers, represented our list to the advertisers, and did all the billing work. All we had to do was send the emails and cash checks. Working with an advertising agency that caters to your niche is a great move early on because it shortcuts the relationship building process and doesn't require you to sell directly.

The other option is to virtually pound the pavement and try to find advertisers by approaching them directly. You can identify advertisers by

looking for them on your competitors' websites and mailing lists. If you are running Google AdSense ads on your website, you can see which advertisers are frequently showing up on your website and can approach them directly. You will need to put together a media kit which will highlight the size and demographic nature of your audience and will contain a list of various types of advertisements an advertiser can purchase. You can view MarketBeat's media kit at marketbeat.com/advertising. Approaching advertisers directly can be a lot of work but may be an effective way to generate list rental deals if you are a natural seller.

As MarketBeat has grown over the years, we brought on a director of business development to work directly with advertisers. Once you reach a certain size, can hire your own sales and implementation team, do your own billing, and have existing relationships with advertisers, it makes more sense to go direct with your largest advertisers. Direct relationships eliminate the commission that advertising agencies take and allow you to collaborate more creatively with your advertisers.

The Process of Renting Your List

When you make an agreement with an advertiser to rent your mailing list, there are several steps involved. You and the advertiser will agree to send an email to a set number of subscribers at a specific date and time. Several days before the email is scheduled to be sent, they will send you a copy of the email. You will then send a test email to the addresses they provide and will approve the message after they make sure everything looks right and the links are working properly.

On the agreed upon day and time, you will send the email to your list. A few days after the email has been sent, the advertiser will generally request performance information about the send, such as total sends, total deliveries, total opens, and total clicks. You should provide that information to them in a timely manner. At the end of the month, you or your advertising agency will invoice them, and they will mail you a check 30 days later.

Run Co-Registration Advertising Units

In the list-building chapter of this book, we discussed co-registration advertising from the perspective of an advertiser. As a mailing list owner that collects organic opt-ins from your website, you can also generate revenue by running a co-registration advertising unit on the "thank you" page that subscribers see after signing up for your mailing list. After the user signs up for your mailing list, they will be presented with a list of additional offers they can also choose to opt in to. If a new subscriber selects any of the offers listed, you'll receive a small commission from the advertiser, and the subscriber's name and email address will automatically be passed on to the advertiser.

Co-registration advertising units can be wildly profitable if you receive a sizable number of opt-ins each month. On a normal page of your website, a display advertisement from Google AdSense or another network might yield between \$1.00 and \$10.00 for every thousand people that view the ad. A co-registration advertising unit can make anywhere from \$250.00 to \$1,250.00 for every thousand views on your “thank you” page. Users that have just opted into your mailing list are extremely likely to engage with an advertisement, because they have already demonstrated they are willing to take action by signing up for your mailing list.

The amount of money you make from co-registration advertising will vary depending on the niche of your mailing list and the number of people that sign up for your email list on your website every month. Advertising networks that offer co-registration ads will often provide an estimate of what they believe your website can make for every new subscriber. For lower-value and general-interest mailing lists, you might be able to make an average of \$0.25 for every new subscriber that sees your co-registration advertising unit. For some specific niches, like finance and investing, publishers make between \$0.50 and \$1.25 for every subscriber that sees their co-registration advertising unit. To calculate how much money a co-registration advertising unit could make your business in each month, simply multiply the number of website opt-ins you get each month by the estimated amount of revenue you can make per view with your co-registration advertising unit.

While adding display ads to your website from a network like Google AdSense is a straightforward process, getting started with a company that offers co-registration advertising can be more involved. There are only a handful of advertising companies that offer co-registration advertising units, and you generally can’t sign up for them by filling out a form on a website like you can with some networks. Typically, you will need to contact several co-registration advertising companies and provide them information about your mailing list and the demographics of your subscribers. They will give you an estimate of what they think you can make per impression with your mailing list and will typically want you to sign a 12-month agreement to run their unit. Placing ad code on your website for a co-registration unit is also a bit more involved than putting up a display ad, because you must pass the subscriber’s information back to the network through your ad tag. You can find a list of co-registration advertising companies in the list-building chapter of this book.

If you aren’t collecting many opt-ins per month and co-registration advertising companies aren’t interested in you, you can also monetize your “thank you” page with a display advertising unit from Google AdSense or another display advertising company. Your “thank you” page should be a relatively clean page with little more than a thank you message and the display ad centered on your page. While a “thank you”

page with a display ad unit won't perform quite as well as a co-registration advertising unit, you will find that the ad unit on your "thank you" page can earn ten to fifteen times more than display ads on other pages.

At MarketBeat, we work with three different co-registration advertising companies to run co-registration advertising units on our "thank you" pages. We also place co-registration ads on interstitial pages in front of special reports that we promote to our mailing list to generate additional ad revenue from these units. Through the networks we work with, we generate more than \$100,000 in revenue each month from the tens of thousands of monthly organic opt-ins that we attract.

Run Banner Ads in Your Newsletter

If you regularly publish a newsletter to your mailing list, there are advertising networks that will pay you to insert banner advertisements in your newsletter similar to those that might appear on your website. These ads are either sold on a cost-per-click (CPC) or cost-per-impression (CPM) basis. With these advertising networks, you will be given an HTML snippet to include in your newsletter. They will then sell ad placements in your newsletter to their network.

Here are some advertising networks that work with newsletter banner ads:

- **AdMailr** – admailr.com
- **BuySellAds** – buysellads.com
- **Jeeng (Formerly PowerInbox)** – Jeeng.com
- **LiveIntent** – liveintent.com
- **Newsletters.co** - newsletterdirectory.co

Remember to keep a healthy balance between content and ads in your newsletter. The amount of educational and informative content should take up significantly more space than the ads. A good rule of thumb is to place an ad at the top of your newsletter and at the bottom of your newsletter, leaving the rest of the room for non-advertising content. If you have too many ads in your newsletter, subscribers will be less likely to engage with your content in the future.

At MarketBeat, we use a combination of text ads and banner ads in our daily newsletter. We work with an advertising network that sells text-based, cost-per-click advertisements in our newsletter to several different financial advertisers. The ads match the look and feel of the rest of our newsletter and are randomly rotated daily.

Drive Traffic to Your Website

If you have a website with a lot of content, chances are you are already running display advertisements from networks like Google AdSense, OpenX, Exponential, Taboola, and others. Whenever visitors come to your website and view and click on ads, you generate revenue—so the more visitors, the more money. Consider using your newsletter and other emails that you send as a traffic generation strategy for your website. If you can send your subscribers back to your website over and over again, they will likely view and click on more ads than they would otherwise.

Wrap-Up

While there are only a handful of different ways to monetize your mailing list, there are dozens of variations and twists on the six methods listed in this chapter. There are any number of ways to promote your own products and promote other companies' products as an affiliate to your list. Several co-registration advertising networks are available that you can run on your website, and several ways exist to generate revenue by including advertisements in your email content.

Action Steps:

- Run a special bonus or sale campaign to promote your company's products to your mailing list.
- Find two or three products that you can promote to your mailing list as an affiliate.
- Consider placing a co-registration advertising unit on your "thank you" page.
- Try to identify an advertising network that can place banners in your newsletter and help you rent your mailing list.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Email Deliverability and List Maintenance

When you send a letter through the U.S. mail with a stamp and a delivery address, you can be fairly certain your letter is going to arrive safely in a few days. This isn't always the case with email. While you shouldn't run into many issues if you are following best practices and sending high-quality content to your mailing list, there's always the possibility of being added to a blacklist or facing some other deliverability issue that will prevent a percentage of the messages from being delivered or redirect them to subscribers' spam folders. For this reason, it's important to follow email best practices and proactively monitor your mailing list for any issues that might hinder the deliverability of your messages.

Use an Email Service Provider (ESP)

To ensure every message possible makes it to the inboxes of your subscribers, you should always use an email service provider like MailChimp, Drip, or ConvertKit. If you run your own mail server, you are likely to make configuration mistakes that will reduce your delivery rates. It would require finding your own mailing list software and actively monitoring the reputation of both your sending IP address (the Internet address that your email delivers from) and your domain name.

Your ESP will handle all the technical infrastructure and make sure you are following best practices to ensure your messages get to your subscribers' inboxes. They will warn you when you have deliverability issues. They also have relationships with the most popular email providers and with email blacklist operators. If you run into deliverability trouble, you are going to want an ESP at your side to help clean things up.

If you are paying less than \$250.00 per month for your email service provider, know ahead of time that you might not be getting the best support in the world. ESPs make their real money from selling enterprise plans to large customers. They aren't always concerned with keeping people that have \$25.00 or \$50.00 per month plans happy with their services. You will typically receive the level of service that you pay for. If you are on a lower cost plan, know that you will need to take a more active role in monitoring and managing your email deliverability rates.

It can also be a good idea to have a backup email service provider in place. ESPs can shut your account off without notice if they believe you are spamming or if you inadvertently break another one of their rules.

While this is a rare occurrence for most email service providers, it's always good to have a "Plan B" ready to go if your account gets blocked. Have a low-tier account set up with a second email service provider that allows you to import your mailing list from another provider. Finally, make sure you regularly backup your mailing list from your ESP, so you can move them to another provider if your account gets suspended.

Set Up DNS Verification Records

Email is a technology that was first developed in the 1970s. At the time, spam, viruses, and fraudulent emails weren't an issue. The technical specification for email does not include any security measures and makes it easy to fake the "from" email address of a message.

As the volume of spam and other fraudulent email has mushroomed, the Internet Engineering Task Force (IETF) has developed additional protocols that use your domain's DNS records to verify the origin of an email. The four major protocols include Sender Policy Framework (SPF), DomainKeys Identified Mail (DKIM), Domain-based Message Authentication, Reporting, and Conformance (DMARC), and Brand Indicators for Message Identification (BIMI).

Internet service providers and other mail providers actively look for DNS entries that correspond to these email verification protocols. If your domain name does not have SPF and DKIM records set up, or if they are not set up properly, mail providers will often put your messages in your subscribers' spam folders. If they find other things wrong with your email or see that the IP address sending your email is on a blacklist, they may not deliver your messages at all.

You may or may not need to set up SPF records for your domain name depending on how your email service provider functions. Many ESPs will send email using one of their domains, which allows them to automatically add SPF, DKIM, and DMARC records without any intervention on your behalf. You will want to read your email service provider's documentation about them to determine whether you need to manually add SPF and DKIM to your DNS records.

If you are paying less than \$100.00 per month, your ESP is probably sending mail using one of their domain names on your behalf. If you are using a high-end plan and your ESP supports what's known as white labeling, you may need to add SPF and DKIM records to your domain's DNS records.

Here are some domain authentication guides put together by major ESPs. Read the guide associated with your email service provider to get the information most relevant to you:

- AWeber - help.aweber.com/hc/en-us/articles/204026716-What-s-Email-Authentication-How-Does-It-Apply-To-Me
- Campaign Monitor - <https://help.campaignmonitor.com/email-authentication>
- Constant Contact - https://knowledgebase.constantcontact.com/articles/KnowledgeBase/34717-SPF-Self-Publishing-for-Email-Authentication?lang=en_US
- ConvertKit - <https://help.convertkit.com/en/articles/2502558-using-a-verified-domain-for-email-sending>
- Drip - <https://help.drip.com/hc/en-us/articles/4424702626829-Email-Setup>
- GetResponse - <https://www.getresponse.com/help/what-is-dkim-and-how-do-i-configure-it.html>
- iContact - <https://kb.icontact.com/hc/en-us/articles/360025667951-Email-Authentication-DKIM-SPF-and-DMARC-Information>
- MailChimp - <https://mailchimp.com/developer/transactional/docs/authentication-delivery>
- SendGrid - <https://docs.sendgrid.com/ui/account-and-settings/spf-dkim>

SPF Records

Sender Policy Framework, better known as SPF, is an email validation technology that detects mail spoofing by allowing ISPs and other email services to verify whether any given email from a domain name has been authorized by the administrators of that domain. A domain owner will publish a list of IP addresses and other domains authorized to send mail on their behalf as a specially formatted text DNS record. Whenever a mail server receives an incoming message, they can use a domain's SPF records to verify that the email was sent by a server with permission to send email on behalf of that domain.

If your email service provider sends out mail using its own domain, you don't have to worry about setting up SPF records. If your email service provider sends out mail using your domain name or supports white labeling, then setting up appropriate SPF records for your domain is mandatory.

While there's a lot of technical jargon surrounding SPF and other DNS verification tools, setting them up isn't all that difficult. For example, I use SendGrid as my primary email service provider. In order to tell the world that SendGrid has permission to email on behalf of my domain name, I would need to use "v=spf1 include:sendgrid.net ~all" as the text in my SPF record. The "include:sendgrid.net" indicates that SendGrid can send email on my behalf and the "~all" indicates that other sources claiming to be sending mail on behalf of my domain may not be trustworthy.

To find the appropriate SPF record for your email service provider, simply do a web search for the name of your email service provider followed by “SPF.” Once you have identified the appropriate record, you will need to log in to your domain name registrar and add the appropriate record.

Many email service providers will walk you through this process as part of your initial setup with specific instructions and step-by-step guides. If that’s not the case, there are dozens of videos on YouTube which will show you how to add SPF records to your domain. You can use a tool published by MX Toolbox to verify the placement of your SPF records, which is located at mxtoolbox.com/spf.aspx.

DKIM Records

DomainKeys Identified Mail (DKIM) is another email validation technology that verifies a sender has permission from a domain’s administrators to send email on behalf of a particular domain. Additionally, DKIM allows messages to be individually signed using public key encryption so a recipient mail server can verify a message has not been modified during transport. Any DKIM enabled email will include a digital signature that an email server can use, along with a domain’s public DKIM encryption key to ensure the message received is identical to the message that was originally sent. Like SPF records, DKIM records are placed in a domain’s DNS records. Most major email service providers sign their outgoing mail with DKIM, including Gmail, Outlook.com, Yahoo, and AOL.

If your email service provider uses its own domain name to send mail on your behalf, DKIM keys will already be set up without any work on your part. If your email service provider sends mail using your domain (sometimes known as white labeling), you should set up DKIM records in your domain’s DNS records to maximize deliverability rates. Unlike SPF records, which are usually the same for every user of an email service provider, DKIM keys must be generated on a per domain basis. You will need to acquire DKIM DNS records directly from your email service provider and copy them into your DNS records. You can use a separate tool published by MX Toolbox to verify the placement of DKIM records, which is located at mxtoolbox.com/dkim.aspx.

DMARC Records

Domain-based Message Authentication, Reporting, and Conformance (DMARC) is a newer protocol that builds upon the DKIM and SPF records used to detect mail spoofing. Placing a DMARC record in your domain tells mail providers that your domain is protected by SPF and DKIM authentications. DMARC records also provide instructions to mail servers relating to how messages that can’t be properly authenticated should be handled. A domain owner can use a DMARC record to instruct

mail service providers to either put messages that fail authentication into a user's junk mail folder or not deliver them at all.

In most cases, it's probably not necessary to add DMARC records to your domain. While SPF and DKIM records validate that an email comes from your domain name, DMARC merely provides instructions regarding what to do with messages that can't be authenticated. They probably won't positively impact your email deliverability and can also cause legitimate email to be rejected if they are not set up properly.

At MarketBeat, our DMARC record is currently “v=DMARC1; p=quarantine; pct=100; rua=mailto:dmareports@analystratings.net;”. This tells email service providers to quarantine messages that do not pass authentication and forward a copy of them to the special inbox that we have setup. Setting up a special reporting email address in your DMARC record allows you to verify that your authentication is working and gives you a heads up when someone might be trying to spoof your email sending domain or if your email sends are not properly authenticating.

Brand Indicators for Message Identification (BIMI)

Brand Indicators for Message Identification (BIMI) is a relatively recent email specification that allows for the use of brand logos within supported email clients. The BIMI group (bimigroup.org) is a working group setup by major email providers including Google, Yahoo, SendGrid, FastMail, MailChimp, and others to encourage the adoption of the BIMI standard among email service providers and email senders.

The BIMI specification requires an email sender to have existing SPF, DKIM, and DMARC records setup for their sending domain. A sender's DMARC record must also either be set to “quarantine” or “reject” non-authenticated email. This is a safety measure so that a brand's logo is not displayed on email that may not have come from the brand. Some email service providers, most notably Gmail, also require a verified mark certificate (VMC) from DigiCert or Entrust which certifies that the logo in the BIMI record is associated with a given brand and domain name.

To receive a VMC, you must also have your logo trademarked which can take several months. Finally, BIMI records require that the image you specify is in the scalable vector graphics (SVG) format so that your logo can scale to any size required.

MarketBeat's BIMI record is currently setup to “v=BIMI1; l=https://www.analystratings.net/images/marketbeat-bimi.svg;”. As of the publication of the third edition of this book, MarketBeat does not have a verified mark certificate (VMC) setup. While we have the MarketBeat name trademarked, we never bothered to trademark the signature MarketBeat “M”, which is what we use for our BIMI logo. We are in the

process of trademarking the MarketBeat “M” so that we can purchase a VMC.

For most email senders, I recommend setting up a basic VIMI record because that will show your logo in some ESPs, including Yahoo. Trademarking a logo and purchasing a VMC will take months and likely cost thousands of dollars, so I only recommend large brands pursue a VMC.

If you want your logo to show up to Gmail users next to your messages, but don’t want to mess with getting a VMC, there is a shortcut to displaying your logo with your email that many email senders have discovered. Simply create a Google account for the email address that you send mail from and upload a profile picture to your account. The picture can either be a picture of you or your brand’s logo and it can even be animated if you desire.

When you send out an email blast from your ESP, your Google profile picture will be shown to users next to your messages as long as your sending email address matches your Google account’s email address. Please note that you can create Google accounts for email addresses that do not end with @gmail.com, but you will need to be able to receive a message and click on a confirmation link to confirm your account.

Single Opt-In vs. Double Opt-In

When a subscriber first signs up for your mailing list, you may or may not require the subscriber to click on a link in a confirmation email to confirm their subscription. A mailing list that requires a subscriber to click through on a confirmation is known as a “double opt-in” mailing list, because users first opt-in on your website and then opt-in again through the link in your confirmation email. Mailing lists that simply add new users to its subscriber list without sending a confirmation email are known as single opt-ins.

Some email service providers (ESPs) require their customers to operate double opt-in mailing lists and will not add a new subscriber to your mailing list unless they click a link in a confirmation email. Other ESPs are more flexible and allow you to choose between requiring a single opt-in or a double opt-in. If your ESP requires a double opt-in, you don’t have much of a say in the matter. If you have a more flexible ESP, you will have to decide whether a single opt-in is sufficient or if you want to require a double opt-in.

For many years, requiring a double opt-in was seen as a best practice for email marketers. By requiring a double opt-in, you know that every subscriber signing up for your mailing list wants to receive messages from you, because they have to click a link in a confirmation email that’s specific to their email account to verify that they want your messages.

Statistics show that confirmed opt-in mailing lists receive better than average open rates, fewer bounces, and fewer issues with deliverability, primarily because bad email addresses don't get added to double opt-in mailing lists.¹⁸

With a single opt-in mailing list, a bad actor can easily subscribe other people to your mailing list by entering their email addresses into your opt-in forms. It's also possible that people are inadvertently added to mailing lists when a new subscriber accidentally enters a typo into an opt-in form. While these inadvertent opt-ins are rare, they have been used as a reason for some ESPs to require mailing list operators to use double opt-ins.

During the last few years, the tide has been shifting among marketers to favor only requiring a single opt-in. Single opt-in proponents argue that it's not in the best interest of marketers to make it harder for subscribers to sign up for their mailing lists. Opt-in confirmation rates have been falling during the last few years, which has led double opt-in mailing list operators to wonder if they are losing subscribers that would otherwise be engaged and interested in their content.

Single opt-in mailing lists generally grow much faster than double opt-in mailing lists. While they might have lower open rates and higher bounce rates, single opt-in mailing lists tend to have a higher total number of engaged subscribers.

At MarketBeat, we do not require a double opt-in. We believe we would lose too many subscribers before they have a chance to decide if they like our content. Instead, we include a very prominent opt-out link in our welcome email and use data provided by our email service provider to automatically remove invalid and spam-reporting email addresses from our mailing list.

We also use engagement metrics to automatically remove inactive subscribers. If we can't confirm that a user has opened an email from us in the first 21 days of their subscription, we remove them from our mailing list. Even though we don't require a double opt-in, we maintain an average deliverability rate of 99.5% and an average open rate of 20%, because we automatically clear out invalid and inactive email addresses from our mailing list.

User Engagement is King

Major email providers, including Gmail, Outlook, Yahoo, and AOL, are increasingly focusing on how users are engaging with your messages to determine whether your messages will appear in your subscribers' inboxes or their junk mail folders. If a user opens an email, replies to an email, or clicks on a link in an email, an ISP knows that the user is engaged with the message and probably wanted to receive it. If a

subscriber regularly deletes or simply ignores an email, it's probably a spam message or another email that a subscriber didn't want to receive.

Email providers will look at the aggregate engagement data of all their subscribers over time to determine the quality and relevance of email sent by a given domain name and IP address.

For example, if you send an email to 1,000 people at a particular email provider and only five of them open your message, the email provider is likely to believe their users probably don't want your email and may put future emails that you send in their users' spam folders. On the other hand, if you send an email to 1,000 people at an email provider and 400 of them open the message and click on a link in the email, the email provider will know that their users are engaged with your content and that future messages you send should be placed in their users' inboxes.

To maximize your deliverability rates over time, you will want to try and write email in such a way that encourages users to be engaged with your content as measured by the metrics that mail providers use to track engagement—opens, clicks, and replies. Use engaging subject lines to persuade users to open your email. Include several links in each email with a clear call-to-action. Most importantly, try to get users to periodically reply to your messages. You can do this by asking your subscribers for their feedback and having them provide their answers by replying to your messages.

You should also actively remove invalid, inactive, and spam-reporting email addresses from your mailing list to keep your engagement rates high. Remove users that report *your* messages as spam from your mailing list. They probably don't want to receive your messages and receiving too many spam reports can jeopardize your relationship with your email service provider.

If a subscriber's email address gets returned as invalid (sometimes referred to as a hard bounce), you should remove their email address from your mailing list, because they are never going to receive your message regardless of how many times you try.

Finally, you should remove any subscriber from your mailing list that has not opened any of your messages within the last 12 months. If you mail your users every day, remove any subscriber that hasn't opened an email from you in the last 90 days. Having extremely inactive subscribers on your mailing list will hurt your average engagement rates. Plus, it is not worth paying your email service provider to email subscribers that are never going to open your messages.

The importance of user engagement rates cannot be understated. The single best improvement we have ever made at MarketBeat to our deliverability program is mailing less frequently to inactive subscribers.

Most of our email blasts are now only delivered to users that have engaged with our messages in the last 30 days. Every few weeks, we will send one message to our entire list regardless of their last activity date to try to get inactive users back onto our 30-day actives list. By only emailing our most active users most of the time, we are getting better open rates, lower spam folder rates and are spending less on email delivery with our email service provider.

Tracking User Engagement in a Post-MPP World

Removing inactive users from your mailing list, a process known as sunsetting, is an incredibly effective way to increase your email engagement and improve deliverability. For this to work, you need to know which users are actively engaged with your list and which have gone dormant. Prior to Apple's implementation of Mail Privacy Protection (MPP), this was a straightforward task because you could see which users were active based on their date of last open. Now that open rate data is less reliable than it used to be, marketers must rely on other metrics to measure user activity and engagement.

These are the other metrics that we have available to determine user activity and engagement:

- Last Click – When did the user last click on a link in an email?
- Last Verified Open – When did the user last verifiably open an email? Email service providers can differentiate between real and automated tracking pixel firings.
- Last Website Visit – When did a user last visit our website?
- Last Date of User Activity – When did a user engage with your brand in any way? (Website usage, app usage, SMS clicks, email clicks, etc.)

Here's how MarketBeat has adapted its email engagement and sunsetting practices with the launch of iOS 15:

- **New User Grace Period**

New users get daily emails for the first 30 days regardless of their other activity. If they do not confirm their subscription, click on a link in an email, or take some other activity to show they are engaging with MarketBeat within the first 30 days, we permanently unsubscribe them from our email list.

- **Last Click**

Clicks tend to be much more valuable to list managers than opens, but they also happen less frequently than opens. We email everyone daily who has clicked on a link from MarketBeat in the last 90 days, regardless of other email activity.

- **Last Date of User Activity**

This serves as a sufficient proxy for email opens. We email anyone that has verifiably opened an email in the last thirty days, logged into our website, or shown some other form of activity. After 30 days of inactivity, we reduce users to weekly emails unless they have clicked on a link in an email in the last 90 days. After 90 days of inactivity, we will continue to email them monthly to try to get them to re-engage with the list.

When iOS 15 launched in late 2021, we were expecting MPP to create a major shift in the landscape of email marketing, but it has largely been business as usual. We found that using the alternative metrics listed above were comparable to using pre-MPP open rate data. We try to email about the same percentage of our list daily that we did in a pre-MPP world, we now just arrive at which users are active and which users are inactive using slightly different metrics.

As of the publication of this book in mid-2022, there are a few best practices emerging about list management in a post-MPP world. First, marketers should ignore automated opens triggered by MPP because they do not indicate user engagement. Your ESP may likely already be ignoring these automatic opens. Second, marketers should increasingly rely on click data and other user activity data to determine which users are active and which are not. Finally, open rate data is still valuable if you can effectively exclude automated opens.

Email deliverability is more of an art than a science because the data we have to work with is imperfect, and ESPs are regularly changing the criteria that they use to determine whether a domain is a good sender or considered a spammer. This was true prior to the launch of MPP, and it is also true today. List management best practices for a post-MPP email marketing landscape will continue to evolve over time as marketers gather more data and figure out new ways to identify which users are active and which are not.

Your ESP's Role in Deliverability

The level of assistance your email service provider will offer regarding deliverability is generally proportional to the monthly fee that you are paying. As an enterprise customer of SendGrid, my dedicated sending IP addresses and my domains are automatically checked against

blacklists daily. If they see any issues, they will automatically file a removal request on my behalf.

MarketBeat has a dedicated account representative that can personally intervene with any issues we have, and we also receive email notifications if our deliverability rate drops below a certain percentage so we can take remedial action. While having additional delivery monitoring and blacklist remediation services are nice, they are usually only available to very high-end customers that send hundreds of thousands of messages each month. If you are paying under \$100.00 per month to your email service provider, you will need to take a more proactive role in the deliverability of your email by regularly monitoring your deliverability rates and checking for blacklist issues.

Check for Reputation, Blacklist, and Deliverability Issues

The most important thing that you can do to ensure your emails continue to make it into your subscribers' inboxes over the long term is proactively monitor for issues on a regular basis. Your domain name or the IP address that sends your email can be added to a blacklist at any date and time without any kind of notice. For this reason, it's important to set up a weekly or bi-weekly plan to verify that your messages are getting properly delivered to your subscribers' inboxes.

Here are the recommended steps you should follow each week to monitor your deliverability rates:

- **Review Statistics Provided by Your ESP**

Your email service provider will generate delivery statistics for each email that you send. Review the statistics for all the emails you sent in the last week. If your average bounce rate increases by one percent or more, or if your average delivery rates fall by one percent or more, your domain or sending IP address may have been added to a blacklist.

- **Use MultiRBL to Check for Blacklist Issues**

MultiRBL (multirbl.valli.org) can check your domain name or the IP address that sends your email against 224 known blacklists. There are several other online tools that check for blacklists, but MultiRBL is by far the most comprehensive. If your ISP has assigned you a dedicated IP address, you will need to check both your domain name and the IP address assigned by your ESP for delivery issues. If you don't have a dedicated IP address, you will only need to check your domain name against MultiRBL, because your ESP will

automatically monitor their shared IP addresses for blacklist issues. Note that smaller ESP service plans generally do not include a dedicated IP address.

- **Review Your Recent Bounced Messages**

Your ESP should provide a log of recent bounced messages, along with a message from the recipient's email server as to why the message couldn't be properly delivered. You should scan through this list every week to identify any potential blacklist issues. If you see a similar error message appear several times in a row, you should take the time to identify and address the issue. If you find that your delivery rates are dropping, your bounced messages log will usually help you identify the root cause.

- **Check Your Sender Score (Optional)**

SenderScore (senderscore.org) compiles a massive amount of email data from ISPs and other mail providers. Their free reporting tool can warn you about several deliverability issues relating to your sending IP address, such as spam reports, blacklists, and spam traps. If you haven't received a dedicated IP address from your email service provider, you can skip this step.

- **Check for Email Provider Specific Issues (Optional)**

Consider creating a new account with Gmail, Outlook.com, Yahoo, and AOL for the sole purpose of subscribing to your mailing list to see if any messages show up in your spam folder. If you regularly see messages sent to a certain email provider showing up in a spam folder, you probably have a deliverability issue that needs to be addressed. If you want to automate this process, you can use a service called MailMonitor (mailmonitor.com), which will tell you whether or not you have any deliverability issues with specific ISPs and email providers. At \$79.00 per month, MailMonitor is probably only worth paying for if you have a list of 25,000 subscribers or more. Large senders can look into a tool called eDataSource (edatasource.com) that provides more advanced deliverability monitoring tools.

Place a recurring note in your calendar on the same day every week to check for deliverability issues. The process only takes five minutes but can be easy to forget if you don't set a calendar reminder.

What to Do When You Get Blacklisted

If you have a large mailing list, you are inevitably going to land on a blacklist at some point. There are hundreds of blacklists maintained on the web, and each has its own specific set of guidelines that can cause your domain name or sending IP address to be blacklisted. Invariably, too many users will click a “report spam” button, or you will send too many bounced messages and your domain or IP will get added to a blacklist.

When this happens, don’t let it ruin your day. Many blacklists are only used by a very small number of email services. Some blacklists may not impact your deliverability at all. MarketBeat’s sending domain is constantly getting put on Polish blacklist, but it doesn’t concern us given that Poland is not one of our key markets. Getting placed on a widely used blacklist, such as Spamhaus, Spamcop, or Barracuda, will negatively impact your deliverability and warrants immediate action to remedy the issue.

In order to get yourself removed from a blacklist, you typically need to complete a short form on the blacklist operator’s website. You can usually find the link to the removal form in your log of recent bounced messages or through MultiRBL’s blacklist scanner.

If you can’t find the link to the removal form or can’t seem to get yourself removed from a blacklist, email your email service provider’s support address and ask for help. Sometimes, an ESP can get your domain or sending IP address removed from a blacklist when you cannot get the job done yourself. If an organization wants money to remove your domain name or IP address from their blacklist, I do not recommend paying their fee. These blacklists tend to impact a very small percentage of users and most professionals in the email deliverability community do not see them as credible.

Reduce Spam Complaints

Most ISPs and other mail providers include a “report spam” link that allows their users to mark an email as spam. When a user clicks that button, the message will be moved into the user’s spam folder, and your ESP will be notified of the spam complaint.

Your email service provider will want you to maintain a spam complaint rate of less than 0.1%. This means for every 10,000 emails you send, you should receive at most 10 spam complaints. If your complaint rate is consistently higher than 0.1%, your email service provider may intervene and shut down your account or ask you to make changes to your sending practices and reduce your complaint rate.

To keep your complaint rate below 0.1%, you should make the process to unsubscribe from your mailing list as easy as possible. Make sure there is a link to unsubscribe from your mailing list in every email

and that the link works properly. If your spam complaint rate is too high, you can reduce the number of spam complaints you receive by placing an unsubscribe link in both the header and the footer of your email.

Many email service providers will automatically add a “list unsubscribe” header to your emails, which will allow email providers to add their own unsubscribe button near the “Report Spam” button on your messages. An unsubscribe header is a hidden field in an email that provides technical instructions relating to how a subscriber can request to be removed from your mailing list. Using an unsubscribe header is quickly becoming a best practice and can help you avoid many spam complaints. If your ESP does not automatically add an unsubscribe header to your messages already, you can learn how to implement an unsubscribe header by visiting list-unsubscribe.com.

Check Outgoing Emails for Issues

Whenever you are getting ready to send a broadcast email to your mailing list, you should check the message for any potential issues by using your email service provider’s spam check tool. If your ESP does not provide a spam checking tool, there are free services such as Mail Tester (mail-tester.com). These tools will serve as an early warning system and let you know if any questionable content or formatting exists in your messages that are likely to set off a spam filter.

For example, messages that promise users they can make a lot of money or messages that reference erectile dysfunction medications are almost always spam. Spam filters know this and will filter them out accordingly. If you inadvertently put too many dollar signs in your email or make a joke about Viagra, spam checking tools will warn you that the content in your email may be an issue before you press the send button.

Schedule Your Messages for Optimal Engagement

When sending a broadcast email message to your audience, you may be naturally inclined to send it immediately after you finish writing it regardless of the time or day. However, there are specific days of the week and times of day that you can send a message to maximize the number of people that see and open them.

Many email marketers believe that Tuesdays, Wednesdays, and Thursdays are the best days of the week to send email. Your subscribers are generally at work on those days and will be actively checking their email. During the weekend, they are less likely to be at their computers and are less likely to open messages. If you send an email on a Saturday morning and a subscriber doesn’t check their messages until Monday morning, your message may be buried below 100 other received emails.

If possible, try to send your messages at the beginning of the workday (around 8:00 AM) or toward the end of the workday (around

4:00 PM) when your subscribers are more likely to be checking their email. If supported by your ESP, segment your mailing list by time zone, so that your subscribers will receive your message at 8:00 AM or 4:00 PM in their local time. At MarketBeat, we don't have the capability to segment by time zone. We generally send messages at 9:00 AM Eastern Time, so most of the United States will receive our messages at or near the beginning of the workday.

Dealing with Gmail's Multiple Inboxes

In 2014, Gmail began separating its user's inboxes into three separate tabs. In addition to a user's primary inbox, messages from social networking sites are getting put into their own tab, and messages that Gmail considers to be marketing material are sent into a tab called "Promotions."

Because users don't see emails that are put into the promotions tab by default, some email marketers have noticed that their open rates among Gmail users have declined significantly after this change was rolled out. Some email marketers have panicked over this change because they fear they are going to lose sales due to lower open rates and because they believe their messages are unfairly landing in the promotions tab.

While Gmail's multiple tabs are a concern for email marketers, there are a couple of proven ways that marketers can get their messages back in user's primary inboxes. The first thing that you can do is send an email to your Gmail subscribers and ask them to drag your message from the "promotions" tab to the "primary" tab, so they won't miss out on any of the great content you plan on sending them. You might also want to include a quick YouTube video that shows people how to do this to make the process dead simple.

The second thing that you can do to get back in your subscribers' "primary" tab is to get them to reply to your messages. If a subscriber replies to your messages, Gmail will be more likely to believe your messages are important and will put them in the subscriber's "primary" tab. The best time to ask users for a reply is in your welcome message. Simply include a short message like, "Could you reply to this message to let me know that you've received it? I want to make sure that there aren't any issues with your subscription," in your first welcome email. While not everyone will reply, many will.

Gmail and other email providers will continue to develop their email interfaces over time. Don't panic when a major email service provider changes how email is presented to their subscribers. Marketers always find ways to adapt to new features and interface changes that email providers introduce.

Having major problems? Hire a consultant.

If your emails are consistently not making it into users' inboxes and you have done everything else in this chapter to improve your deliverability, it may be time to bring in a deliverability professional to audit your email practices. In the summer of 2018, our messages had very poor deliverability at Hotmail/Outlook. We tried everything we could think of to improve our engagement rates and keep Hotmail happy, but nothing worked.

We ended up hiring SendGrid's deliverability team (sendgrid.com/marketing/delivery-consult) to do a complete audit of our email program and they provided specific recommendations to get us back in Hotmail's good graces. SendGrid's team suggested that we only email users that have opened messages in the last two weeks for about a month, which demonstrated good engagement rates to Hotmail. They then filled out a mitigation form that Microsoft makes available to ESPs and our inbox rates at Hotmail are now on par with other email service providers.

It's very unlikely that we would have ever been able to develop this deliverability improvement program by ourselves, because email deliverability is a very deep rabbit hole and the only way to really know how to keep a specific email service provider is to live and breathe deliverability problems like deliverability consultants do. Deliverability consultants can cost between \$1,000 and \$10,000 for a one-time engagement, but paying the fee was well worth it to make sure that our Hotmail subscribers receive our messages.

Wrap-Up

While it can be easy to feel overwhelmed by the technical components of email deliverability, you don't have to become an expert overnight.

Many deliverability issues won't surface until you have built a large subscriber list and you begin to send a lot of email. Follow the basic monitoring recommendations outlined in this chapter, and you'll know right away if there's a problem that needs to be addressed.

There are several resources available, such as SendGrid's Deliverability Guide⁴⁹, which can help you learn about the intricacies of email deliverability and help you solve any deliverability issues you run into. If you can't figure out how to fix a deliverability issue on your own, your ESP can always step in to help, too.

Action Steps:

- Use an email service provider to send out every message to your mailing list.

- Set up appropriate SPF, DKIM, and DMARC records if required by your ESP.
- Decide whether you want to require a single opt-in or a double opt-in.
- Create a weekly or bi-weekly calendar reminder to check for deliverability issues.
- Periodically remove users that have not opened an email from you in the last 12 months.
- Use Mail Tester or another tool to check for potential issues before sending broadcast emails to your mailing list.

CASE STUDY #5

Oliver Wicks

Oliver Wicks (oliverwicks.com) is a direct to consumer (D2C) business that sells made-to-measure suits online. They produce and sell a variety of formal men's clothing products, including coats, pants, shoes, scarves, ties, pocket squares, suspenders, and chino pants. They are known for offering free alterations as well as free shipping and free returns. Their slogan is "The fit that suits you."

I had the opportunity to speak to William Morris, Oliver Wicks' key account manager, about the company's email marketing strategies. Oliver Wicks used MailChimp as its email service provider under its previous management, but recently switched to Klaviyo because it is better suited for e-commerce businesses than MailChimp is. Oliver Wicks is leveraging Klaviyo's Shopify integration and marketing automation tools to generate more sales for their business.

Opt-ins are gathered by the company through a pop-up opt-in form that appears after users have been on their website for a few minutes. Oliver Wicks also has a footer opt-in on their website and use exit-intent opt-in forms as well. The company offers 10% off a customer's first order as a lead magnet for opting in. Customers can opt-in to receive email notifications when an out-of-stock item comes back into stock. Morris noted that out-of-stock notifications are especially effective at gathering new opt-ins that later convert to sales.

The company sends one email to their list every week on Thursdays when they are not running a sale. Their weekly emails include new fabric releases, informational newsletters, seasonal promotions and sales, and styling tips. They also did a charity campaign where 15% of sales were donated to St. Jude's Children's Hospital. "We don't believe in aggressive sales pitches. Rather, we aim to provide interesting email content to promote genuine likeability of our brand, while offering authentic advice and opinions on dressing like a gentleman and how to wear a suit well," said Morris.

Oliver Wicks has an email list of approximately 21,000 subscribers. They also have an autoresponder series for new subscribers that highlights the company's brand, key messaging, and core products. The company does not yet have a cart abandonment series or an upsell series in place, but plans on adding both soon. Leveraging multi-day sale campaigns is Oliver Wicks' most effective way at generating sales through email marketing. The company does a "Black Friday" campaign each November and a "Christmas in July" campaign each July that offers a site-wide discount on products. The company also does flash sales that

run from a Thursday to a Monday that contains a specific offer, such as a getting a free tie with the purchase of a suit.

Oliver Wicks gets an average open rate of 44.5%, indicating a strong affinity between the company's customers and its brand. The company gets approximately a 3% clickthrough rate and makes about \$5,000 each time a marketing email is sent out. Morris added, "We feel that we see the benefit of this when we look at our marketing stats; our email campaigns score consistently high open rates, with low spam/unsubscribe complaints. Our brand revolves around loyal repeat customers, and interestingly, our direct sales performance from email marketing is fairly low."

"We see the bigger picture here—our friendly approach to customer engagement, in the long run, often leads to repeat customers because they've become fond of us in a very natural, organic fashion," Morris concluded.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Legal Aspects of Email Marketing

While email marketing and other aspects of Internet businesses can sometimes feel like you are operating in the Wild West, email marketing is regulated in the United States, Canada, Europe, and in some other developed countries. You will want to learn about your country's specific regulations regarding email marketing, so you can stay in compliance with the law and avoid getting hit with hefty penalties for unknowingly committing violations.

Before we dive into some of the regulatory environment surrounding email marketing, I should disclaim that I am not an attorney or any kind of legal expert. I believe I have a good understanding of the laws that impact email marketing, but a competent attorney or the government may have a different understanding of the law than I do. If you are planning on doing anything that may skirt the edge of any of the laws mentioned in this chapter, please seek the advice of a competent legal professional.

CAN-SPAM Act of 2003 (United States)

Congress passed the *Controlling the Assault of Non-Solicited Pornography and Marketing Act* in 2003, better known as the CAN-SPAM Act. CAN-SPAM establishes a basic set of rules for all commercial email. Each separate violation of the CAN-SPAM Act can result in penalties of up to \$16,000, so it's important to make sure your messages stay compliant with the law.

The Federal Trade Commission has put together a guide for businesses titled "CAN-SPAM Act: A Compliance Guide for Business," which is located at <https://www.ftc.gov/business-guidance/resources/can-spam-act-compliance-guide-business>. The guide outlines the main requirements of CAN-SPAM and provides a series of frequently asked questions that clarify different components of the legislation. I recommend every mailing list owner in the United States read this guide.

Here are some of the main requirements of CAN-SPAM listed in the guide:

1. Don't use false or misleading header information.

Your "From," "To," "Reply-To," and routing information—including the originating domain name and email address—must be accurate and identify the person or business who initiated the message.

2. Don't use deceptive subject lines.

The subject line must accurately reflect the content of the message.

3. Identify the message as an ad.

The law gives you a lot of leeway in how to do this, but you must disclose clearly and conspicuously that your message is an advertisement.

4. Tell recipients where you're located.

Your message must include your valid physical postal address. This can be your current street address, a post office box you've registered with the U.S. Postal Service, or a private mailbox you've registered with a commercial mail receiving agency established under Postal Service regulations.

5. Tell recipients how to opt-out of receiving future email from you.

Your message must include a clear and conspicuous explanation of how the recipient can opt-out of getting email from you in the future. Craft the notice in a way that's easy for an ordinary person to recognize, read, and understand. Creative use of type size, color, and location can improve clarity. Give a return email address or another easy Internet-based way to allow people to communicate their choice to you. You may create a menu to allow a recipient to opt-out of certain types of messages, but you must include the option to stop all commercial messages from you. Make sure your spam filter doesn't block these opt-out requests.

6. Honor opt-out requests promptly.

Any opt-out mechanism you offer must be able to process opt-out requests for at least 30 days after you send your message. You must honor a recipient's opt-out request within 10 business days. You can't charge a fee, require the recipient to give you any personal identifying information beyond an email address, or make the recipient take any step other than sending a reply email or visiting a single page on an Internet website as a condition for honoring an opt-out request. Once people have told you they don't want to receive more messages from you, you can't sell or transfer their email addresses, even in the form of a mailing list. The only exception is that you may transfer the addresses to a company you've hired to help you comply with the CAN-SPAM Act.

7. Monitor what others are doing on your behalf.

The law makes clear that even if you hire another company to handle your email marketing, you can't contract away your legal responsibility to comply with the law. Both the company whose product is promoted in the message and the company that sends the message may be held legally responsible.

There have been a small number of criminal indictments under the CAN-SPAM Act of 2003 since its passage. To date, only a handful of large-scale spam operations have been targeted by the Federal Trade Commission.

Most email marketers probably don't need to worry about the FTC knocking on their door over a violation, but you should still ensure your mailings follow the CAN-SPAM Act because it's the law and because email providers limit the deliverability of mail from bulk senders who are not CAN-SPAM compliant. The rules outlined by the Federal Trade Commission are straightforward and are very easy to follow. Be honest about who you are, where your business is located, and the content of your messages. Provide clear opt-out instructions and honor opt-out request promptly. Do these two things, and you probably won't have much to worry about.

Interestingly enough, the CAN-SPAM Act of 2003 doesn't actually outlaw spam. The legislation does not require commercial email senders to get permission before emailing someone. When the legislation was first passed, some referred to it as the "You Can Spam" Act, because it didn't do anything to limit the amount of spam that people receive.

The CAN-SPAM Act also generally only applies to people living in the United States. Many spammers are in developing countries around the globe, which makes it extremely difficult to take any legal action against them. Because of the limited jurisdiction of the CAN-SPAM Act and its relatively light regulatory burden, spam continues to be a major problem in the United States and the rest of the world.

FTC Endorsement Guidelines (United States)

If you are going to promote another company's products as an affiliate, you need to be aware of the Federal Trade Commission's paid endorsement guidelines. Generally, you need to disclose whenever you are getting paid to promote a product or service for another company. Your disclosure must also be "clear and conspicuous" and as close to the endorsement as possible. This means that you shouldn't try to hide your disclosure in the footer of your messages or in some other inconspicuous location.

The Federal Trade Commission issued a guide in March 2013 that outlines disclosure rules and recommendations for paid digital media endorsements titled, ".com Disclosures: How to Make Effective Disclosures in Digital Advertising".²⁰

Here's a great example email from marketer Pat Flynn about how to properly disclose affiliate relationships in an email:

Pat Flynn

To: matt@mattpaulson.com

Subject: Limited-time Hosting Special (at \$2.95/mo)

If you're looking to start a new website soon, this is a deal you'll want to take advantage of. Bluehost, the hosting company I recommend for those who are just starting out, is running a short special deal for Smart Passive Income readers only.

Until next Wednesday, you can get a hosting account with a domain for just \$2.95 per month (marked off from \$5.99/mo), which is the cheapest hosting solution available at the moment. I don't usually mention deals in my emails, but this is such a good one I had to make sure you saw it.

You can only get this special deal (or share it with a friend) by going through the following link:

[Affiliate Link Here]

And yes, this is an affiliate link, which means that I do get a commission from Bluehost if you purchase (at no extra cost to you).

Just wanted to be honest about that. Here's the link one more time:
[Affiliate Link Here]

Thanks so much for your support, and I look forward to sharing more with you about my Ghana trip and my upcoming summer trips with the family soon! Cheers, and much love!

Pat Flynn

California Consumer Privacy Act (United States)

The California Consumer Privacy Act (CCPA) was passed in 2018 with the aim of enhancing privacy rights and consumer protections for residents of California. The law went into effect in January 2020 and was expanded in November 2020 when voters passed Proposition 24, which amended and expanded the provisions of the CCPA. The law allows users to access their personal data, know who their personal data is being sold to, decline the sale of their personal data, and request that a company deletes any personal information that a company has collected on them.

The CCPA establishes several requirements for companies that do business in California including:

- Adding a “Do not sell my personal information” link to the homepage of a business, which allows users to opt-out of the sale of their personal information or request that the business delete their personal information.
- Implement processes to obtain parental or guardian consent for minors under the age of 13.
- Designate communication methods for submitting data access requests.
- Update the company’s privacy policy to include required disclosures and outline California consumer’s rights under the law.

The CCPA applies to any company that does business in the state of California, collects consumers’ personal data, and meets certain size and scope criteria designed to exempt small businesses. Specifically, a company must do \$25 million in gross revenue, collect personal information on 50,000 or more consumers, or earn more than half of its annual revenue from selling consumers’ personal information.

If your company is based in the United States and meets the size and scope requirements of the CCPA, you should take active steps to ensure compliance with the law. Compliance with CCPA is not especially burdensome, given that most small businesses will not receive many CCPA requests from California consumers. The primary thing that businesses should do to ensure CCPA compliance is to setup a “Do not sell my personal information page” that is linked from the homepage of their website. You can view MarketBeat’s “do not sell my information page” at <https://www.marketbeat.com/do-not-sell-my-information>.

Canada’s Anti-Spam Legislation (CASL)

The Canadian Parliament passed the Fighting Internet and Wireless Spam Act (FISA) in December 2010. The legislation, better known by the nickname of Canada’s Anti-Spam Legislation (CASL), went into effect on July 1st, 2014. CASL requires that marketers only send email to individuals who consent to receive messages, with a few exceptions. CASL is arguably one of the most stringent pieces of anti-spam legislation in the world due to its consent requirements and other restrictions put in place by the legislation.

Under CASL, you can only send email to subscribers that have expressly opted into your mailing list or to recipients that have passively agreed to accept email through some form of implied consent.

For example, you can email anyone that’s purchased a product from you or has done a business deal with you within the last 24 months under the guise of implied consent. There are also a variety of exceptions for recipients that you have an existing personal or business relationship with and for recipients that you need to notify of a product recall, court order,

or updates and changes to an existing product or service they previously purchased.

CASL also puts several other restrictions on marketers. The legislation requires mailing list operators to have a working opt-out mechanism. CASL also makes it illegal to harvest email addresses using software and installing computer programs without consent. The legislation makes it illegal to alter messages in transit *and* makes it illegal to use false or misleading representations online in the promotion of products or services.

The legislation is enforced by the Canadian Competition Bureau, the Canadian Office of the Privacy Commissioner, and the Canadian Radio-television and Telecommunications Commission (CRTC). Individuals that violate the legislation can face fines of up to one million dollars, and businesses in violation can face fines of up to \$10 million. The law also allows private citizens to take civil action against spammers that violate the provisions of CASL.

If you don't live in Canada, you might think that the provisions of CASL won't apply to you. However, if you live in the United States or another jurisdiction and have subscribers in Canada, you need to pay attention to the legislation. CASL applies where "a computer system located in Canada is used to send or access" an electronic message.²¹ This means that CASL will apply if a sender in the United States sends an email to a Canadian citizen who opens it on a computer or smartphone located in Canada. While it remains to be seen if Canada will try to enforce the CASL outside of its borders through extradition, it's probably a good idea to stay in compliance with CASL if you are going to have any Canadian customers.

The American Bar Association has published an article that contains additional information about CASL's implications for citizens in other countries titled "Canada's Tough New Anti-Spam Legislation: Beware Its Extra-Territorial Reach".²²

General Data Protection Rules (Europe)

The regulatory environment surrounding email marketing changed dramatically in 2018 when the European Union's General Data Protection Rules (GDPR) went into effect. The primary aim of GDPR was to give consumers control over the personal data that companies have about them and to streamline data protection rules for businesses in the European Union. The law impacts email marketers because it includes new permission opt-in rules, requires businesses to store proof of consent and requires businesses to provide a method through which consumers can ask that their personal information removed.

Europe's General Data Protection Rules are a concern for both European businesses and businesses that have customers in the European

Union because it was written in such a way that it applies to the data of citizens of the European Union, regardless of where the company is located. This caused many U.S. businesses to scramble to become GDPR compliant when the law went into effect in May of 2018. Other U.S. businesses simply blocked traffic from the European Union because they felt that complying with GDPR's requirements were unclear and too onerous to comply with.

GDPR's new opt-in permission rules will perhaps have the biggest impact to email marketers. The law requires that marketers receive freely given, specific, informed, and unambiguous consent from a user. This means that users must know specifically what they are signing up for, provide their information to you freely, and click a button indicating they want to receive email from you. Soft opt-in methods such as a pre-checked box that opts a user into your mailing list or requiring users to check a box to opt-out of receiving email from you are not in compliance with GDPR.

The United States only requires you to not email users that have opted-out of your messages under the CAN-SPAM Act of 2003. Europe's rules are much stricter because you are only allowed to email people that have given you consent to email them. This is one of the few anti-spam laws in the world that makes unsolicited commercial email (spam) illegal.

Under GDPR, you also need to track consent so that you can prove that a user opted-in to your mailing list. In practice, this will happen by storing a user's IP address, browser information and cookie information for auditing purposes. Any email service provider that claims to be GDPR compliant will likely do this for you, so it's not something you need to worry about as long as you verify your email service provider is tracking proof of consent.

GDPR also allows users to request what information a business has on file about them and allows users to request a business permanently delete their data. This is a true "right to be forgotten" law that requires businesses, upon request, to eliminate any trace of a user's data from their database. In the years since GDPR rules have gone into effect, MarketBeat has only received a handful of requests from users asking for their data to be removed or be provided to them for review. To comply with these requests, MarketBeat has provided a tool that allows them to download all the data that MarketBeat has stored about their account. MarketBeat also has an unsubscribe page which allows users to permanently delete their account and remove their personal information from our database.

When GDPR rules went into effect, MarketBeat made several other changes to comply with GDPR rules. We rewrote our opt-in forms to make it clear what email users will receive when they sign-up for MarketBeat. We rewrote our terms of service to include several specifics

relating to GDPR compliance and requests. We setup a special email address for users to send GDPR-related requests to. We started logging opt-in sources and IP addresses to prove user consent if that should ever become necessary. We believe we are generally compliant with the principles of GDPR, but it isn't possible to prove compliance with the letter of the law given the vagueness of some of its complaints.

While most U.S. businesses are unlikely to ever have to deal with GDPR-related legal issues, General Data Protection Rules are a serious matter for European companies. As of mid-2022, European regulators have fined nearly 1,200 companies for failing to comply with GDPR rules. Amazon paid the largest GDPR fine totaling €746 million in July 2021 for matters relating to cookie consent. A full list of GDPR fines can be viewed at enforcementtracker.com.

Wrap-Up

While regulations that surround email marketing will vary depending on what country you live in, you probably won't have a lot to worry about if you follow what I refer to as the *three golden rules of email marketing*:

1. Only send email to people that have opted in to receiving your messages.
2. Only send content that you would want to receive if you were a subscriber to your mailing list.
3. Don't be deceptive in the content of your messages, and don't try to hide your identity to your subscribers.

If you only send high-quality, relevant, and honest content to your subscribers, and you only email people that have expressly opted into your mailing list, it's extremely unlikely that anyone is ever going to get upset with you enough to try to hit you over the head with a civil suit for failing to follow anti-spam legislation. You should still pay attention to your country's anti-spam legislation and try to follow its provisions, but you won't have a target on your back if you follow the three golden rules of email marketing.

Action Steps:

- If you live in the United States, verify that your email sending practices comply with the CAN-SPAM Act of 2003.
- If you live in Canada, verify that your email sending practices comply with Canada's Anti-Spam Legislation (CASL).
- If you have subscribers in the European Union, verify that your sending practices are in compliance with the principles of the E.U.

General Data Protection Rules (GDPR).

- If you live in another country, research your own country's anti-spam laws to make sure you comply with your country's laws and regulations.
- Follow the three golden rules of email marketing.

CHAPTER NINE

Outbound Email Marketing

Most of this book has focused on using email as a means of building an engaged audience and generating revenue by selling or recommending products to that audience. While growing a community surrounding your content can work well in many categories, it isn't ideal in others. You can easily build a mailing list in niches that cater to hobbyists and general consumers, but it's much more difficult to grow a mailing list if your company sells a very specific product to certain types of people or businesses. If your company makes a very niche product with a relatively high price point and only has a few thousand potential customers, you are much better off approaching your prospective customers on a one-on-one basis rather than doing traditional list building and trying to attract an audience.

For example, if I ran a farm implement dealer that sold tractors, balers, and combines to local farmers, there might only be a few hundred farms that would ever purchase equipment from my business. My potential customer base simply would not be large enough for building a subscriber list outside of my existing customer base to be worthwhile. This doesn't mean email marketing won't work for this business, but it *does* mean I would need to take a different approach.

I would still send email with news and product information to my current customers, but that wouldn't be my only email marketing initiative. Instead of waiting for local farmers to sign up to receive email from me, I would need to use email as an outreach tool and try to schedule appointments with farmers or invite them into my dealership.

This marketing strategy, known as email prospecting, involves sending personal email messages to certain members of specific organizations in hopes of accomplishing a specific sales objective. When you send a prospecting email, the prospective customers that receive the message won't have opted into your mailing list and generally won't know who you are prior to receiving your email.

At my fictional implement dealer, I might try to get referrals from some of my existing customers. I would then send a cold email to the referral and ask if there is any equipment that they plan on buying in the next 12-24 months and show them what the dealership has that might be able to meet their needs.

Email prospecting won't necessarily replace the need to collect opt-ins on your website, build an email list, and send a mix of content and marketing material to your subscribers in hopes of generating sales. Even large B2B companies with extremely high price points publish white

papers that require a reader to opt-in to their mailing list before getting access to the white paper.

Think of email prospecting as a complement to your existing list-building efforts. While traditional autoresponder messages and broadcast emails will engage subscribers that complete opt-in forms on your website, email prospecting will engage potential customers that have never heard of you or your business. Both strategies work together in a complementary manner to generate new business for your company.

Inbound Marketing vs. Outbound Marketing

Inbound marketing refers to marketing activities that draw customers into your business by creating compelling content and earning your potential customer's attention. Gathering opt-ins and sending autoresponders and broadcast emails to your mailing list are both inbound marketing techniques. Outbound marketing techniques involve actively identifying potential customers through list gathering, social networks, and going out and getting their attention. Cold calling, cold emailing, running commercials, placing advertisements, and attending trade shows are examples of outbound marketing techniques. The remainder of this chapter will focus on outbound email marketing, also known as email prospecting. Email prospecting is the process of identifying potential customers for your company's products or services and sending them a cold email in hopes of getting their attention.

Isn't Email Prospecting Considered Spamming?

Throughout the first several chapters of the book, I recommended that you only email people that have expressly opted-in to your mailing list. However, I also suggest that sending a cold email introducing yourself to prospects can be an effective marketing strategy if you run a certain type of business. These two statements can seem somewhat contradictory at face value but sending someone a personalized, cold email introducing yourself is very different than spamming them.

Spamming occurs when a marketer sends a large volume of unwanted commercial email over a period of time. Sending one or two targeted messages to a specific person at a business for a specific reason is not spamming. It's the difference between sending a few people a single, personal letter and incessantly sending 5,000 people mail they don't want. Sending cold emails for business development purposes is a generally accepted practice in most industries.

Identifying Potential Customers

Amidst your inbound email marketing efforts, potential customers will self-identify themselves by signing up for your mailing list. When doing outbound email marketing, you will need to go out and identify potential customers that you can approach. You probably already know

what types of people or businesses your potential customers are. You just need to find the specific prospects that meet your criteria.

There are several ways that you can identify potential customers:

- **LinkedIn**

LinkedIn has become an increasingly popular way for salespeople to identify potential customers. A user's LinkedIn profile will provide detailed information about their career and personal interests, which makes it a perfect tool to find potential customers. LinkedIn has advanced search tools that let you home in on specific types of people easily. While it is a great way to identify potential customers, you shouldn't use LinkedIn to contact your potential customers unless you do not have access to their email address, because many users don't check their LinkedIn messages. Your message may then get lost among the many less-targeted marketing messages that subscribers receive.

- **Facebook Fan Pages and Groups**

Identify Facebook fan pages and Facebook groups that are relevant to your potential customers. People will frequently self-identify as needing help to solve a problem by posting to a group and asking for suggestions. If you see someone that has written about a problem that your business can solve, send them a message through Facebook to introduce yourself and tell them how you can help them.

- **Twitter Search**

People will also frequently self-identify problems they need help with by tweeting about them. For example, if you are a web designer, you might do a Twitter search for a phrase like "recommend a web designer" to find people who are looking to hire a web designer. The day that I wrote this chapter, I found ten people in the previous week who asked if anyone can recommend a web designer to them. Search for multiple phrases people might use to indicate they have a problem you can solve. Once you identify a potential customer, tweet them, and you might be able to help with their problem. Try to get their email address, so you can send them an introduction email, or their phone number to setup a call.

- **Lead Scoring**

If you have an existing mailing list, you can use a process known as lead scoring to identify the subscribers most likely to become your customers. Lead scoring is simply the process of calculating an engagement score for your subscribers based on the actions that they take, such as reading emails, clicking on links, requesting free reports, following you on social media, etc. If someone is highly engaged with your content, they will be much more likely to become a customer of your business. By calculating a lead score for each of your subscribers, you can see which of your potential subscribers you should put the most time and effort into to acquire them as a customer.

- **Compile a List**

Consider hiring a virtual assistant, an intern, or a relatively low-cost employee to help identify businesses and people that meet your criteria. Have them collect all the key information you would need to send a cold email and put it in a spreadsheet—including the name of the business, the location, the owner, the business's phone number, and the owner's email address. For example, if you wanted to create a list of chiropractors, you could have an intern do a web search for chiropractors in specific cities in the geographic region you are targeting and add them to your spreadsheet. A list that you compile yourself will generally be more up-to-date and accurate than a list you purchase from a list broker.

- **Trade Shows**

Consider getting a booth at the trade shows that are frequented by your potential customers. While your first thought might be to get a booth at an industry trade show, remember that industry trade shows generally cater to people that *work* in an industry and not customers that buy products from that industry. If you were a chiropractor, you would want to get a booth at a trade show frequented by people that have back pain and not an industry show for other chiropractors. While at a show, collect as many business cards as possible, so you can follow up with potential leads via email after the show.

- **Ask for Referrals**

Whenever you get a new customer, ask them whether they can recommend anyone else that might benefit from your company's products or services. By getting referrals from your existing customers, you've instantly identified a new warm lead that you can follow up on.

Finding a Potential Customer's Email Address

When you identify a customer through social media channels such as Twitter, Facebook, and LinkedIn, their email address may not be listed on their social media profile. In some cases, you can get a potential customer's email address just by asking them. If this isn't the case, you will need to do some sleuthing on the web to identify a person's email address, so you can send them an introduction letter.

Here are some ways to find a potential customer's email address:

- **Google Them**

Google the name of your potential customer and the name of their business (if applicable). You may find other websites or other social media profiles that a person has created that do contain their email address. Make sure you go through the first several pages of search results to find all potential websites that may contain pertinent contact information. For more targeted results, consider doing a search of their company's domain name. For example, you could search "site:marketbeat.com Matthew Paulson" to find references to me on my company's website.

- **Make an Educated Guess**

Most companies use a standardized format for their email addresses. For example, all Bank of America employees' email addresses are in the format of firstname.lastname@bankofamerica.com. If I were a Bank of America employee and you were trying to guess my email address, matthew.paulson@bankofamerica.com would probably be a good place to start. If you guess someone's email address incorrectly, the worst thing that will happen is the message will get returned as undeliverable. You can figure out the format of a particular company's email addresses by doing a web search for the company's domain name followed by words like "contact" and "email." For example, I found the email addresses of several Bank of America employees by searching for "@bankofamerica.com email."

- **Make an Uneducated Guess**

If you can't figure out the format of a company's email addresses, you can also use a service called Email Address Guesser (guesser.email) to generate probable email addresses for a person based on their name and their domain name. You can use a Gmail plugin called LinkedIn Sales Navigator (formerly called Raportive) to figure out if any of the probable addresses are accurate. After setting up Sales Navigator in your browser, open a Gmail account and copy and paste all the guesses created by Email Address Guesser into a new message. Hover over each address, and the user's other contact information will appear if the email address is valid.

- **Use a Paid Service**

There are several paid services that will help you identify someone's email address based on their name, geographic location, and the company they work for. Intelius (intelius.com) and Spokeo (spokeo.com) are two paid services that have large searchable email address databases. You can also use business specific search tools like Lusha (lusha.com) and FindEmails.com to find the contact information for a specific person at a business.

Warm Up Your Prospective Customers

Before you begin writing a message to someone, try to find a personal connection with the person you are going to approach. People that you have no connection to at all are known as cold leads. Prospects that have some connection to you, or have been referred to you by a mutual acquaintance, are considered warm leads. It's much easier to sell to a warm lead than a cold lead, because people have a harder time dismissing others that they have an existing personal connection with. If you can turn a cold lead into a warm lead by identifying a mutual friend, acquaintance, or interest, you are much more likely to have success from your introduction email.

To identify potential connections with your prospects, look at their Facebook, LinkedIn, and other social media profiles to see if you have any mutual friends or connections. If you find a mutual connection, ask the connection if they would be willing to introduce you to the prospect through email. If the connection doesn't respond to your request, it's still worthwhile to mention the names of your mutual connection in your introduction email.

If you can't find a personal connection, try to create one through an organization that you are both a member of, such as a university or a

service club. If that's not possible, you can try to create a personal connection through a common interest or hobby. Regardless of what kind of connection you create, having common ground with a prospect will get you a lot further than having no connection at all.

Writing Effective Cold Introduction Emails

After you have identified someone's email address and have figured what kind of personal connection you can make with them, it's time to send them an introduction email. Your introduction email should identify any common bonds that you have with them, let them know how you became aware of them, identify what potential problems they might have that you can help with, and provide a clear call-to-action detailing the next steps you would like them to take.

Here's an example of an introduction email I might send if I were offering consulting services:

Matthew Paulson

To: prospect@marketbeat.com

Subject: Help with your website?

Hi [Name] –

We haven't had the opportunity to meet yet, but I saw you had posted on Twitter that you are looking for a digital marketing expert to help generate more traffic to your website. I wanted to take a moment to introduce myself and see if there's an opportunity for us to work together to do just that.

My company, Matthew Paulson Consulting, works with small- to medium-sized businesses like yours and helps them grow their social media following and collect more email opt-ins with the goal of driving more sales. We've helped several other [category of business] businesses like yours and think that we could do a lot to grow your audience online.

Would you be available for a phone call tomorrow or the next day to see if there's a way that we can help generate more website traffic and leads for your company?

Feel free to respond to this message or call me on my cell-phone at (605) XXX-XXXX at any time.

Matthew Paulson

Matthew Paulson Consulting

P.S. I saw that we are both connected to Laycee and Jared Kluin on LinkedIn. I went to college with both Laycee and Jared. They're a great couple. Love those two.

There are several things that you should take note of in this email:

- **Focus on the Prospect**

The content of the message focuses primarily on the prospect and their needs. Start the email by using the person's first name. Use lots of "you" language to make the message more personal, and focus on their specific needs, not what you have to offer.

- **Keep It Short**

The above email is less than two hundred words long. Keep your first introduction email short so that it's easy for the recipient to read. You can dive into detail on how you can help them in a phone call or in a follow-up email.

- **Create a Personal Connection**

At the bottom of this email, I mentioned that we had two mutual connections on LinkedIn. The "P.S." section of your email is a great place to tell someone how you are connected to them without interrupting the flow of your message.

- **Ask for a Next Step**

At the bottom of my email, there is a clear call-to-action for what the next step would be. In most cases, your next step should be getting your prospect on the phone, so you can better qualify them and see if they are a good fit for your services.

- **Use a Relevant and Personal Subject Line**

There's a good chance your prospect's email inbox is already full of other messages. You need to write an intriguing subject line to get your message noticed. Subject lines with a question mark work particularly well. Also use uncommon language that will instill curiosity in the recipient. An example of a subject line that follows these principles is "Strange question?" The subject line is short and will coerce a prospect into opening your message out of curiosity more than anything.

If you are looking for more resources about how to effectively write a cold email, Steli Efti of [Close.io](https://close.io) created a resource titled “8 cold email templates that will generate warm leads for your sales team!”,²³ which provides several great examples of cold emails that get great response rates. John Corcoran has put together another great resource that provides guidance on cold approaching people on the OkDork blog titled “How to Connect with VIPs: 5 Tips for Cold Emails”.²⁴

Following Up with a Potential Customer

Don’t be surprised if you don’t receive a response after you send someone a cold email. Some of the most effective cold emails only yield a response rate of 35%. Sometimes people just aren’t interested in what you have to offer, and that’s okay. Not every prospect is going to become a customer. That doesn’t mean you should immediately give up on a prospect if they don’t respond to your first email.

It’s worthwhile to send one or two follow-up messages if the prospect missed, or didn’t respond to, your first message. If you don’t receive a response after the follow-ups, your prospect probably just isn’t interested, and you should move on to the next one. Don’t send an endless stream of messages asking prospects if they received your email or if they want to get in a phone call with you. When you’re emailing someone that hasn’t opted into receiving mail from you, you’re really crossing over into the territory of spamming if you haven’t gotten a positive response after the first contact.

Systemizing the Process

To effectively develop your business through email, you are going to need to construct systems and processes to facilitate sending cold emails. You will probably be dealing with many different prospects at once, and many of them will be in different stages. You might have a deal in place with one customer, while at the same time, you are pre-qualifying several more leads and are negotiating contracts with two others. It’s important to keep track of where you are with every prospect, so potential customers don’t fall through the cracks.

Here are the five stages of turning a prospect into a customer:

- **Pre-qualification**

You think the person has a need, but they have not yet confirmed your suspicions. Prospects that you have emailed but haven’t responded are at this stage.

- **Qualification**

You have made contact with a prospective customer, and they have confirmed that they have a need you can meet or a problem you can solve.

- **The Offer**

You make a specific written proposal or offer to address the prospect's need. Your proposal should contain pertinent information about what kind of work you would do for them, including the scope of work and pricing.

- **The Contract**

Prospects at this stage have accepted your offer. They sign off on your proposal, complete payment, and become customers of your business.

- **Delivery and Fulfillment**

After you sign an agreement and the customer makes payment, you deliver the product or service you sold them.

The system that you put in place should be able to keep track of where every prospect is at in these five stages. Each prospect should have a next action associated with them, so you know when to take the next step. You can use a customer relationship management system (CRM) software or something as simple as an Excel spreadsheet to keep track of where all your prospects are at.

There are also several software tools that have been developed over the last few years that make following up with sales prospects over email much easier. These tools tie into your existing email account and send your prospects a series of automated follow-up messages (like an autoresponder series). If your prospect replies to one of your prospecting emails, the automated follow-up sequence ends and then you can pick up and have a human conversation with the prospect. One tool that does this is called Bluetick (bluetick.io).

Getting Started with Prospecting Through Email

When you first start doing email prospecting, commit to sending five to ten cold emails each week. You can even send these emails through your personal email account because of the low volume of outbound messages.

Each message that you send should be personalized to the recipient and their business. Never send a form letter. Prospects can recognize generic emails from a mile away.

If someone responds positively to your introduction email, try to set up a phone call or meeting with them to see if you can do business together. If a prospect says they're not interested, move on to the next one.

If someone doesn't respond to your email after four or five days, send them a follow-up email. If they don't respond to your first follow up, you can send one final message if they are a particularly good prospect. If they don't respond to your third message, you should move on to the next prospect.

There are too many fish in the sea to get hung up on one potential customer.

Wrap-Up

Email prospecting can be an incredibly effective strategy for certain types of businesses. If your company sells high price point products and services and you have a relatively small customer base, you should seriously consider whether email prospecting can complement your list-building efforts.

Action Steps:

- Determine whether inbound email marketing or outbound email marketing is the best approach for your type of business. If you determine that outbound marketing is ideal, complete the steps below:
- Identify the first ten prospective customers you want to approach and find their email addresses.
- Write a sample introduction email that you can use to serve as a template for future cold emails.
- Develop a system to keep track of which step each potential customer is currently in and what your next steps with them are.
- Send your first ten cold emails.

CHAPTER TEN

Web Push Notifications: Your Second Email List

In June 2013, Apple held its annual World-Wide Developer Conference at Moscone West in San Francisco. CEO Tim Cook announced new versions of iOS, OSX and the Mac Pro during his keynote. The audience awed during each announcement as one would expect, but perhaps the most important announcement Apple made that day didn't happen during the keynote. In a breakout session later that day, Apple announced it would be allowing websites to send push notifications to users directly through its Safari web browser. Website owners gained the capability of sending users short notifications in their web browsers, regardless of if the user was currently on their website.

Web push notifications (sometimes called browser notifications) didn't gain much adoption early on due to the lack of broad browser support and the technical difficulty in setting up notifications on one's website. Chrome quickly added support for web push notifications to its browser, but Firefox didn't add support for push notifications until 2016 and Microsoft Edge didn't add support until 2018. iPhone users are unable to receive web push notifications as of mid-2022, but Apple has publicly stated it would add support to iOS for web push notifications sometime in 2023. Marketers really began to take web push seriously in 2017 and 2018, when most major browsers supported the technology and software-as-a-service platforms became available that made it easier to add web push notifications to one's website.

How Web Push Notifications Work

When you visit a website that has web push notifications enabled, your web browser will give you a message that says, "This website wants to send you notifications. Allow or Block?" If you click the block button, that user will not be able to ask you to opt-in to push notifications in the future. If you click the allow button, the website will have the capability of sending you notification messages through your web browser. You will typically receive a welcome notification, which will appear on the lower right of your screen if you are on Windows or on the upper right of your screen if you are on a Mac.

This is an example of what a notification looks like in Windows 10:



8 Stocks to Buy and Hold Despite Market Selloff

We've picked eight stocks that you should consider for your portfolio as we enter 2019.

Google Chrome •

www.americanconsumernews.net

[Click Here to See The Stocks](#)

After you grant a website permission to send you notifications, the owner of that website can send notification messages to your web browser as long as you have it open on your computer. If a notification is sent when you are away from your computer, that message is typically displayed to you whenever you log back on to your computer and open your web browser. Website owners can send you notifications even when you are not on their website and the permission that you grant them to send you notifications lasts indefinitely until you either switch to a new computer or unsubscribe from their web push notifications.

Why Push Notifications are Powerful Marketing Tools

Web push notifications are powerful tools for digital marketers because you have the power to instantly draw people back to your website after they have left. If you have just published a new post on your blog, you can instantly let everyone that's opted into receiving notifications from you know that there's new content on your website. If you're running a promotion or a sale, you can instantly put that offer in front of your audience. Your audience doesn't have to go into their email inbox and find your message in the mess of the 100 other emails they received that day. They don't have to check your Facebook page or Twitter account to see that you're running a promotion. The message is just right there on their web browser where they can't miss it.

Web push notifications have very high engagement rates. Unlike an email sign-up form where a user must type their personal email address into a form, users only have to click one button that says "allow" to sign-

up to receive notifications from you. The simplicity of the opt-in leads to much higher opt-in rates than you would see with email. Since a relatively small number of websites use web push notifications and because notifications are hard to miss, the clickthrough rates can be five to ten times what you might normally get from sending an email to a similarly sized list.

Similarities Between Email and Web Push

The primary focus of this book is email marketing, but there are many similarities between web push marketing and email marketing. Both marketing mediums allow you to build a base of subscribers that opt-in to receive content, information, and promotions from your brand. Both mediums allow you to build a long-term marketing asset that is not controlled by a single major technology company. Both mediums allow you to send a message to your audience whenever you have something to share.

The technologies behind email marketing and web push marketing are fundamentally different, but they can work together in unison to help you achieve your marketing goals. I like to think of web push notifications as a second email list, because it's another group of people that you can send messages to when you produce new content or have something to promote. There will invariably be overlap between your email list and your web push notification list, but there's little risk in sending a person the same message twice using two different marketing mediums.

Choosing a Web Push Service Provider (WPSP)

To start gathering web push opt-ins on your website, you will first need to sign-up for web push service provider (WPSP) such as OneSignal (onesignal.com), PushCrew (pushcrew.com), or Push Monkey (getpushmonkey.com). Your WPSP will perform the same functions for web push that an email service provider (ESP) would provide for email. Like an ESP, a WPSP will gather opt-ins, keep track of your subscribers, allow you to send messages to subscribers, track the performance of your notifications and keep a history of past messages sent.

As of 2022, there are more than 30 different web push service providers that are vying to be the market leader. OneSignal had been the largest player initially because it did not charge users for its service, but they moved to a fee-for-service model like other providers in late 2018. The market is currently wide open and there probably isn't a single WPSP that has more than a low double-digit market share. It remains to be seen if the market will consolidate to a few dominant players in the same way that the email service provider market has.

I don't have a specific recommendation for a web push service provider, but you should look for a service provider that allows you to collect subscribers with the native browser opt-in. Your provider should give you rich statistics about your web push campaigns, allow you to setup interest segments so that you can send the most relevant notifications to your users, and allow you to setup an autoresponder series.

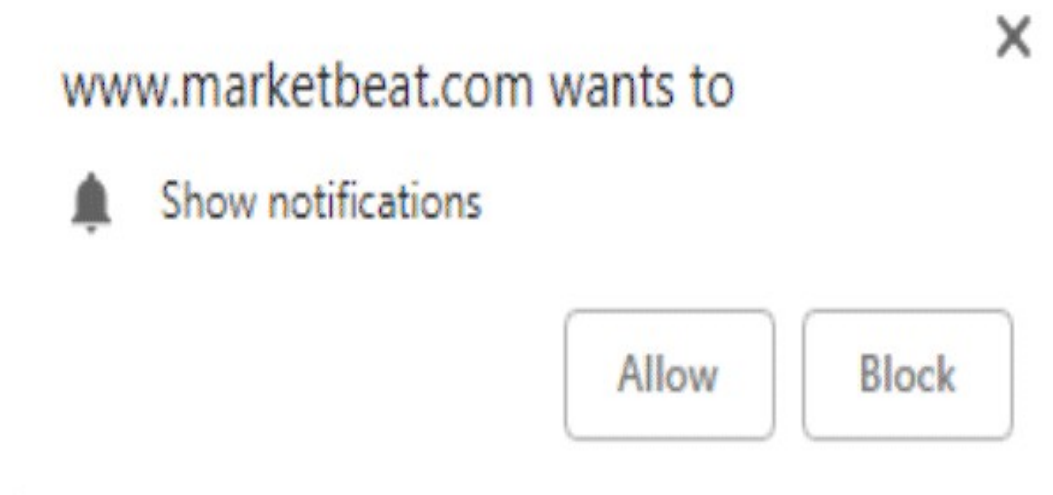
You should also look at the cost of the service and how those costs will scale as your list size grows and as you send out more messages. Pricing can vary dramatically between web push service providers. Before you sign-up with a provider, have a clear understanding of what you'll pay each month when you have 1,000, 10,000 and 25,000 subscribers.

Setting Up Push Notifications on Your Website

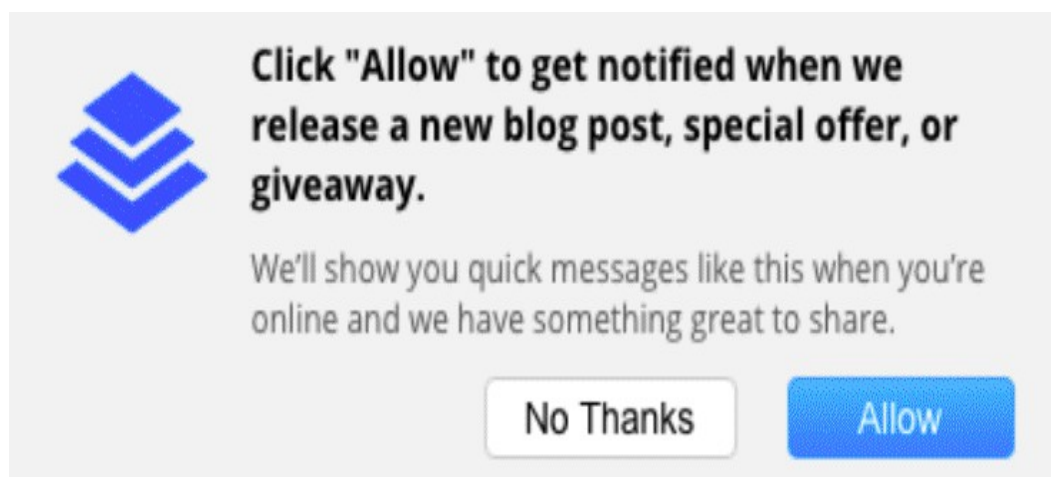
Once you sign up with a web push service provider (WPSP), they will collect information about your website and give you a plugin or code snippet to install on your website. Most WPSP's have developed their own plugins for popular content management systems like WordPress, which makes installing the code that gathers web push opt-ins on your website a breeze.

In the process of setting up an account with your WPSP, you may be asked if your site supports secure connections (HTTPS). Since HTTPS support is a prerequisite of the web push notification technology, WPSPs must use a workaround if your website does not support HTTPS that involves using a two-step opt-in process. If your website does not support HTTPS, you should take the time to add HTTPS support to your website before setting up push notifications. You will receive a dramatically better opt-in rate to your push notification list if your users are able to opt-in through the native browser notification instead of the work-around two-step opt-in that non-HTTPS websites must use.

This is an example of the native browser opt-in:



This is an example of the non-native two-step opt-in:



If you click allow on the non-native opt-in, a new window will popup on a domain controlled by your WPSP that shows the native browser opt-in. Because the non-native opt-in requires two clicks to opt-in instead of one, the opt-in rate will be invariably lower than the native browser opt-in rate.

As of mid-2022, several web browsers now require websites to use a two-step opt-in process. Firefox, Microsoft Edge, and Safari have all limited the ability of websites to immediately fire a browser notification opt-in request. Google Chrome still permits websites to fire the native browser opt-in request, if the website gets a decent opt-in rate. I recommend using the native browser opt-in request for Google Chrome and the two-step opt-in process for other browsers. This may require writing some custom JavaScript but is currently the most effective way to maximize the number of opt-ins you receive on your website.

Once you have installed the code snippet or plugin provided by your WPSP, you should verify that it is working properly. Navigate to the homepage of your website and see if you are presented with the opt-in to

receive push notifications. Click the “allow” button to sign-up for your own push notification list, then use your WPSP to send out a test message. If you receive the test message, your website is properly configured to collect web push opt-ins and send web push notifications to its subscribers.

Initially, you will have a very small web push subscribers list. Don’t get discouraged if you only have a few dozen or a few hundred subscribers, because gathering subscribers is a cumulative process and your subscriber count will grow over time.

What Types of Messages Should You Send Through Web Push?

While you can send an email of any length, you are restricted to very tight length requirements in your web push notifications. The title of your notifications should be no more than 30 characters and the description of your notification should be no more than 100 characters. You can also include a square image with your notification and a 30-character call-to-action button below your message. You effectively have the length of a tweet to communicate the contents of your message in your web push notification.

There are no restrictions about the types of messages that you send to your web push notification list, but your audience may unsubscribe if you send them too many ads or irrelevant notifications. Just like with your email list, you should send a mix of educational content, news, and promotions to your web push notifications list. It’s just fine to send promotions or offers for products and services that your business sells, but you should probably send at least two pieces of helpful content for every one promotional message that you send.

Creating an Autoresponder Series for Your Web Push List

Every major email service provider allows you to send a pre-written series of emails to new subscribers called an autoresponder series. In the same way, many web push service providers (WPSPs) allow you to create an autoresponder series that sends a set of pre-written push notifications to new subscribers over the first several days of their subscriptions.

The first email in your push autoresponder series is your welcome message, which is sent immediately after someone opts-in. I recommend that you send an ad or promotion as your welcome notification, because users that have just opted-in are many times more likely to buy than other users. At MarketBeat, we use a free trial offer for our premium subscription as our welcome notification. We have gotten nearly 100 new customers in the last year that have signed up through our welcome notification.

For the rest of your web push autoresponder series, I recommend sending one push notification per day for the first two weeks that someone is a subscriber. You should include your most popular content pieces as well as your core product offerings as part of your autoresponder series. Feel free to refer to the sample autoresponder in chapter four to get ideas for what to include in your web push autoresponder series. You should include the same types of autoresponder messages that you include in your email autoresponder series in your web push autoresponder series.

How Often Should You Send Push Notifications?

Different brands have come to different conclusions about how often to send push notifications to your mailing list. The website 9to5Mac.com will send as many as 10 push notifications each day and will often send out a notification for each new story they publish. Other brands may only send as little as 3 or 4 notifications per week. My general recommendation is to send one or two web push notifications each day unless you are in an industry that has constantly changing information, such as finance, technology, or news. In that case, you can get away sending a higher volume of notifications.

The optimal time of day to send notifications is when your users are using their computers. If someone's not using their computer when you send your message, they either won't receive it, or will receive it along with several other notifications when they return to their computer. You can determine which hours of the day your website is most active by looking at your Google Analytics reports. For most brands, the best time of day to send a push notification will be mid-morning or early afternoon. There are some exceptions though. A gaming website would likely find that the best time of day to send a notification is late in the evening, and a fitness brand would likely find that their best time of day to send notifications is early in the morning when people are getting up to workout.

Most push notifications will have a setting that allows you to deliver your messages at the same time of day in a user's specific time zone. If you schedule your message for 3:00 PM, that means European and Asian subscribers will get your message at 3:00 PM the following day. I recommend that you do this for every push notification to avoid accidentally sending people notifications in the middle of the night.

Best Practices for Push Notifications

Here are some of the best practices that I have developed for sending web push notifications in the last few years:

- **Preview your notifications before sending them.**

Every web browser renders push notifications a little bit differently and includes a different subset of features included in the technical specifications for web push notifications. For example, you can include calls to action in Chrome, but can't in Safari. Notifications on Chrome will render differently if you are on Mac or on Windows. Microsoft Edge's push notifications will appear in the Windows Action Center when they make push notifications available in the next version of Windows 10. There are some general design rules, such as keeping your title to under 30 characters, but you really need to test your notifications in a real live web-browser to see what they will look like to your users. That way notifications will appear as you intended them to and won't get cut off mid-sentence.

- **Use action buttons to increase clickthrough rates.**

We include a call-to-action in every push notification that we send out in the form of an action button. This gives a second opportunity to instruct your users to act and gives them something obvious to click on. This feature is currently only supported in Chrome and isn't supported in Firefox or Safari.

- **Use large images in your notifications.**

Chrome on Windows and Android allows you to send a 720×480 rectangular image that appears with your push notification. These make your notifications larger and easier to click. They also provide you more screen real estate to communicate your message to your audience.

- **Use custom icons for your notifications.**

Every web push notification sent includes a small square image that you can use to sell your content. If you don't specify an image, your default image (likely your logo) will appear. I recommend including a unique image with each notification to maximize engagement and click-through rates.

- **Don't send the same notification twice.**

If you send the same push notification out twice, it will have a much lower clickthrough rate the second time around. Users are less likely to click on ads and copy they have already seen before. Even if you

are promoting the same piece of content to your list again, use a different image and different text to promote it.

- **Send multiple notifications per day to maximize reach.**

Consider sending two or three notifications to your subscribers, spread throughout the day, to maximize the number of people that you get back to your website through push notifications.

How We Use Web Push at MarketBeat

Web push notifications were a significant source of growth for MarketBeat between 2016 and 2020. Our company uses OneSignal to collect browser notification opt-ins on MarketBeat.com, InsiderTrades.com, DividendStocks.com, and our other websites. We show an opt-in to users immediately on the first page load to maximize opt-ins. We currently have approximately 600,000 users that have opt-ed into browser notifications. The messages that we send out to our distribution list include free reports that link back to our website, breaking news stories and promotional messages from our advertisers.

Web push notifications generated more than \$250,000 per year in revenue for MarketBeat in 2019 and 2020. When web browsers started making it more difficult for websites to show the native browser opt-in request to users in 2021, the number of new opt-ins our websites receive each month started to decline. As of mid-2022, our push subscriber count and revenue has leveled off. We are likely past the peak effectiveness of using web push notifications as a marketing strategy, but they remain a powerful tool to get users to return to your website.

Wrap-Up

Web push notifications provide an incredible opportunity that allow you to build an audience on a newer marketing channel your competitors may not be leveraging. There are no major downsides in gathering web push subscribers, other than the monthly fee you pay to your web push service provider (WPSP). Once you have the basics of your email strategy in place, start gathering web push subscribers and building out your web push strategy immediately.

Action Steps:

- Setup a SSL certificate on your website to enable HTTPS traffic if you don't already have one.
- Choose a web push service provider (WPSP) and sign-up for an account.

- Install your WPSP's code snippet or plugin on your website so that you can start gathering opt-ins.
- Have your WPSP automatically send out new blog posts on your website as a push notification.
- Develop a long-term content strategy for the types of messages you are going to send to your push list.

CASE STUDY #6

GoGo Photo Contest

GoGo Photo Contest (gogophotocontest.com) is a company that was founded by Jason Shea, Stevie Shea, and myself in 2013. The company helps animal shelters and humane societies raise money by running donate-to-vote photo contest fundraisers. GoGo Photo Contest provides software to manage the contest and expertise to promote and market the contest in exchange for a small percentage of the contest proceeds.

The fundraiser that GoGo Photo Contest helps animal shelters run is a pet photo contest where participants upload pictures of their pets directly to the shelter's contest website. Participants and their friends purchase votes for a donation amount set by the animal welfare group, which is usually \$1.00 per vote. Participants will share and promote their entries with their friends through social media and email to get additional votes for their entries. At the end of the contest, the entries that have the most votes will win the contest and get whatever prizes the animal shelter sets for being in the top spot.

GoGo Photo Contest does not rely on traditional inbound email marketing as a marketing channel. Trying to organically grow an audience through traditional list-building methods would not be effective for this business. First, GoGo Photo Contest was a relatively new concept when we introduced it to the market, and most decision makers with animal welfare groups weren't searching for photo contest fundraising software. Since many animal welfare groups were not aware of the concept, most of them would probably never find their way onto our mailing list. Second, there are only approximately 12,000 animal shelters in the United States. This just isn't a big enough set of potential customers to organically grow a mailing list.

It simply wouldn't be effective to use traditional list-building strategies and hope that a meaningful number of animal shelters will sign up for our mailing list and eventually become customers. While inbound email marketing is not a great fit for GoGo Photo Contest, the company has had great results by doing outbound email marketing and using email as a prospecting tool to identify and market to potential customers. We used many of the principles and strategies outlined in the outbound email marketing chapter of this book to attract customers for GoGo Photo Contest.

Our strategy involved identifying the executive directors of as many animal welfare groups as possible using a variety of different methods. Then we sent a cold email introducing them to GoGo Photo Contest and showing them how our platform could help their organization raise

money. Our outreach emails educated our potential customers on the concept of GoGo Photo Contest and suggest they consider it as their next email fundraiser. We would typically send one email per month to an animal shelter director for a few months before we stopped mailing them. If a shelter directly responded and told us they're interested, our team would try to set up a phone call with them to sell them on the concept and persuade them to run a contest.

GoGo Photo Contest also helps animal welfare groups grow their own email lists. The contests that shelters run are inherently social in nature, and many participants will promote their entries through social media, email, and other word-of-mouth strategies. As a result, many of the people that vote in their contest are not part of any of their constituent lists prior to the beginning of the contest. In addition to the funds raised directly through the contest, the animal shelters can send follow-up mail and email in the future to solicit additional donations.

GoGo Photo Contest has helped hundreds of different animal shelters run donate-to-vote photo contests primarily because of its outbound email marketing efforts. GoGo Photo Contest's only revenue stream is its share of the proceeds from each contest, which works out to about 9% of the fundraising total. The company has helped shelters raise a total of \$25 million since the first contest launched in October 2013 and has generated six figures in annual revenue several times over for the last several years. I am no longer directly involved in the company, but it continues to be an email marketing success story and shows the power of outbound email marketing.

FINAL THOUGHTS

At the beginning of this book, I argued that email marketing is one of the most powerful marketing channels that companies have available to them. Investing in email as a marketing channel will result in a substantial return-on-investment and will generate dividends for a long period of time. Given the Direct Marketing Association's statistics that the average business investing in email marketing will receive an ROI of 4,300%, any business should salivate over the potential results of incorporating email marketing into their business.

After I heard those numbers the first time, my first thought was, "How can I get this incredibly effective marketing strategy in the hands of my friends and business acquaintances?" I did some digging to find comprehensive resources that would teach all aspects of email marketing, but that book just didn't exist. So I set out to write one, and *Email Marketing Demystified* is the result. By reading the book, you have learned about the key components of email marketing, including learning about email service providers, building a mailing list, creating a lead magnet, setting up an autoresponder series, sending out broadcast emails, writing effective copy, monetizing your list, staying compliant with best practices and government regulations, and doing email prospecting. Now, it's your turn to take the practical knowledge outlined in this book and implement it in your business.

If you haven't already signed up with an email service provider, that's your first step. The next is to start collecting opt-ins on your website using one of many popular plugins. Then you face the challenge of writing the first few emails in your autoresponder series. In the following several weeks and months, you'll finish your autoresponder series and start writing your first few broadcast emails in hopes of generating some new sales. Over time, your mailing list will grow, you will become a better copywriter, and your sales funnel will become much more effective after trying out different things and seeing what works. If you continue down this path and keep practicing the art of marketing, you will have developed an incredibly powerful skillset that will generate massive results for your business.

APPENDIX

Additional Email Marketing Resources

If you would like to learn more about how you can grow your business through email marketing, there are several other resources that are worth checking out:

- **AutoResponder Madness (autorespondermadness.com)**

AutoResponder Madness is an email training course produced by Andre Chaperon that teaches marketers to use list segmentation and storytelling to create incredibly effective autoresponder series that drive engagement and sales. I have not personally gone through AutoResponder Madness, but it is highly recommended by other email marketers that I know and trust.

- **Drop Dead Copy (dropdeadcopy.com)**

Host John McIntyre interviews expert level email marketers who share their best tips on his weekly podcast, the Email Marketing Podcast. McIntyre also offers professional copywriting services and a membership program that provides training videos and sample emails which you can use as the basis for messages to your mailing list.

- **Email Players Newsletter (bensettle.com)**

Ben Settle's Email Players Newsletter teaches email marketers how to write daily entertaining and conversational emails to your mailing list. While the style of email marketing that Settle promotes isn't perfect for everyone, it's hard to recommend an expert that knows more about email marketing than he.

- **GetResponse's Email Marketing Tips Blog (blog.getresponse.com)**

GetResponse publishes a daily email marketing tip on its corporate blog. I have personally gotten several useful ideas by keeping up

with the content on their blog.

- **Feed the Wolf (feedthewolf.com)**

Copywriting expert Ian Stanley regularly produces written content about effective copywriting and email marketing. He also publishes “The 8020 Email Copy Crash Course,” which teaches email copywriting best practices.

- **MailChimp’s Blog (blog.mailchimp.com)**

MailChimp regularly publishes email marketing news and advice on its corporate blog. Their team regularly writes about new ways to attract opt-ins and publishes content about trends in the world of email marketing.

- **The Rebel’s Guide to Email Marketing**

During the last five years, I’ve read more than a dozen different books that cover aspects of email marketing. There are several mediocre email marketing books that have been written and a couple of good ones. The *Rebel’s Guide to Email Marketing* by DJ Waldow and Jason Falls is one of the best print resources that discusses email marketing.

- **Vero’s Email Marketing Blog (blog.getvero.com)**

Vero publishes weekly content about marketing automation on the blog. This blog is focused on more advanced strategies, such as list segmentation and creating triggered email series.

Here are a few other resources that I have produced that you might want to check out:

- **Online Business from Scratch**

Online Business from Scratch is a book that I published in 2017 that provides a step-by-step-process for developing your own online business. It outlines the processes that I’ve used to build and grow MarketBeat into a seven-figure online business. You can get your copy of *Online Business from Scratch* at FromScratchBook.com.

- **My Personal Blog**

I regularly publish new business tips and advice on my personal blog at MattPaulson.com.

- **My Podcast Interviews**

While I don't host a podcast of my own, I am regularly a guest on several top business podcasts. If you would like to listen to interviews that I've done, visit mattpaulson.com/interviews.

THANK YOU

Thank you for purchasing *Email Marketing Demystified* and taking the time to read it. Reading a nonfiction book can be a time-consuming endeavor. Thank you for choosing to spend some of your valuable time digging through all the information I have to offer.

If you would like to share your thanks for this book, the best thing you can do is tell a friend about *Email Marketing Demystified* or buy them a copy.

You can also show your appreciation for this book by leaving a review where you bought it. To leave a review on Amazon, visit the Amazon product page at MyEmailMarketingBook.com. Please be honest with your review and how this book has or has not helped you on your path to building an Internet business. I want everyone to know how or if this book has changed your life in any significant way.

You can follow me online at my personal blog, MattPaulson.com. You can also follow me on Twitter ([@MattPaulsonSD](https://twitter.com/MattPaulsonSD)).

If we have met in real life, feel free to add me as a friend on Facebook (facebook.com/matthewpaulson). If we have not met in real life, you are still welcome to “follow” me on Facebook.

I am also on LinkedIn (linkedin.com/in/matthewpaulson) and Angellist (angel.co/p/mattpaulson).

If you would like to hear me talk about various topics, feel free to check out the interviews I have done at mattpaulson.com/interviews or check out my YouTube channel at youtube.com/user/MatthewDPX.

Thanks again and God Bless,

Matthew Paulson

October 1, 2022

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Matt Paulson is the founder and CEO of MarketBeat, an Inc. 5000 financial media company that empowers individual investors to make better trading decisions with real-time financial data, in-depth analysis, and best-in-class stock research tools. MarketBeat has been recognized by Barron's, Entrepreneur, Financial Times, Forbes, and Inc. for its rapid growth and success. With nearly 3 million email subscribers, MarketBeat is the largest digital media company in the Dakotas.

As one of South Dakota's most active angel investors, Matt has invested in more than 75 high-growth startups, including Buffer, Bushel, Density, Dollar Shave Club, Lyft, Prismatic, and Wikia. His venture capital firm, Homegrown Capital, makes seed-stage and Series A investments in high-growth technology companies in the Northern Plains states. Matt also invests in commercial real estate projects in partnership with Cresten Capital, including ownership interests in more than 25 apartment complexes, retail centers, and quick-serve restaurants.

Over the past decade, Matt has worked to create new startup resources in South Dakota. He was instrumental in the creation of Falls Angel Fund in 2016, which makes equity investments in early-stage, high-growth companies in the Dakota's. He founded Startup Sioux Falls in 2019, which has since become the premier community and resource organization for startup founders in the region. Matt became the namesake of DSU's Paulson Cyber Incubator in 2020, which aims to accelerate student-led startup businesses. He has written eight entrepreneurship and investing books. The Small Business Administration has recognized Matt for his contributions to the startup ecosystem, naming him their Small Business Champion in 2020.

Matt provides volunteer leadership to several area non-profits and Christian ministries. He currently serves on the Board of Trustees at Kairos University (Sioux Falls Seminary), on the Board of Directors at Startup Sioux Falls, on the Campaign Cabinet for Forward Sioux Falls 2026, and as the Treasurer for Faith Baptist Fellowship. Matt is also the director of Falls Community Growth PAC, which aims to elect pro-growth, community-minded candidates to state and local office.

Matt lives in Sioux Falls, South Dakota, with his wife, Karine, and their two children, Micah and Adylin (Ady).

Connect with Matthew at:

- Matthew's Personal Blog – [MattPaulson.com](https://mattpaulson.com)
- Amazon - amazon.com/Matthew-Paulson/e/B001TA5CW6

- AngelList - angel.co/p/mattpaulson
- Facebook - facebook.com/matthewpaulson
- LinkedIn - LinkedIn.com/in/matthewpaulson
- Twitter - [@MattPaulsonSD](https://twitter.com/MattPaulsonSD)
- Email - matt@mattpaulson.com

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